

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Religion without God - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Religion without God - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

Catalogue identity: Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion ·

philosophy-paper-ii-philosophy-of-religion-07 **Syllabus clause, verbatim:** *Religion without God.*

Evidence discipline: doctrine, attribution and previous-year wording are controlled by the repository owner files.

Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is never an official UPSC key. **Terminology rule:** English-first throughout. The English concept leads; the accurate Sanskrit, Pali, German or Latin term follows in parentheses.

Package practice counts

Component	Count
Taught sessions in the Basic block	18
Verified topic-owned previous-year questions	7 (2018-2025; 2022 is the only year with no owned part)
Core diagnostic MCQs	24
Remedial diagnostic MCQs	8
Total diagnostics	32
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Original solved Mains models	6 (2 x 10, 2 x 15, 2 x 20)
Consolidated register cards	18
ASCII master flow panels	26

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

Exact printed ownership and cross-topic firewall

The printed clause owns the **necessity question** - whether belief in a personal creator is required for religion - together with the non-theistic cases, definitions, functions, objections and costs needed to answer it.

Owned here	Boundary that is not crossed
substantive, functional, multidimensional and family-resemblance definitions of religion	complete definitions of God and ultimate reality belong to the Notions of God owner
Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā, Sāṃkhya-Yoga and the modern non-theistic cases	complete school doctrines belong to the Paper I canonical owners
ritual, sacred order, community, liberation and religious attitudes without a creator	full analysis of the nature and object of experience belongs to the Religious Experience owner
how far prayer, worship, revelation, grace and providence require a deity	detailed faith and revelation questions belong to the Reason, Revelation and Faith owner
whether non-theistic religion retains moral motivation	the full dependence of morality on religion belongs to the Religion and Morality owner
religious naturalism, fictionalism and humanistic religion as boundary cases	Humanism and Secularism, and complete theories of religious language, retain their own owners

ANALYSIS: [FACT] The firewall that governs the whole clause: **non-theistic is not identical with atheistic.**

Rejecting a creator does not entail denying every deity, sacred being, devotional act or transcendent value. Almost

every weak script on this clause fails at that one sentence.

0A. The one question, and the four answers to it

IS BELIEF IN A PERSONAL CREATOR NECESSARY FOR RELIGION?

BUDDHISM	JAINISM	MĪMĀMSĀ / SĀMKHYA	MODERN NATURALISM AND FICTIONALISM
non-theistic	no creator;	no creator;	ultimacy inside
nirvāṇa; no	souls (jīva)	karma/ritual	nature, or
creator	+ karmic matter	self-runs	practice without
			assertion

religion = a path, an ethic and a liberation - NOT, by definition, theism
 WESTERN CRITIQUES OF THEISTIC RELIGION: Feuerbach (projection) · Marx ("opium")
 · Freud (illusion) · Comte (religion of humanity) · Nietzsche ("God is dead")
 THE LIMITING CASE: Cārvāka - closes the route to every supersensible object,
 and therefore ends in no religion at all.

MEMORY: Mnemonic - "Religion = the three D's minus God: Discipline, Dharma, Deliverance." A tradition can supply a path, an ethic and a liberation without a creator deity. Buddhism is the strongest actual counterexample to a creator-necessity definition - provided religion has been defined multidimensionally rather than stipulated as God-relation in your first sentence.

Local source and factual control

- Local searchable John Hick, *Philosophy of Religion*, PDF p. 14, supports comparative definitions of religion that include Theravāda Buddhism although it lacks worship of a creator.
- The local searchable *Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion*, "Nontheistic Conceptions of the Divine," print pp. 59-79 (PDF pp. 71-90), controls the theistic/non-theistic discrimination used throughout.
- Local searchable Chatterjee-Datta, *An Introduction to Indian Philosophy*, especially PDF pp. 37-39 and 144-146, controls the common religious problem and the treatment of Jainism and Buddhism as religions without a creator; local C. D. Sharma controls the caution that creator-denial is not equivalent to the absence of spiritual or ethical religion.
- **[FACT]** No contemporary sociology, opinion survey or claim about the popularity of belief is used anywhere here to establish what religion is.

Source-complete coverage ledger

[FACT] marks retained repository doctrine or verified question data. **[INFERENCE]** marks learner-facing organisation or judgement.

Owner material	Where it is taught here	Retention decision
Owner Section 0 - one-screen map	Section 0A and Session 1	Retained, with the humanistic column corrected to name Comte's religion of humanity and modern naturalism
Owner Section 1 - what makes something a religion	Session 1	Taught in full, with Smart's dimensions and the functional definition made the organising spine
Owner Section 1.1 - necessary, sufficient and over-broad criteria	Session 2	The seven-row criteria table and the working sufficient cluster retained entire
Owner Section 1.2 - which religious functions require a deity	Session 3	The seven-row function table retained, with the petition concession made explicit
Owner Section 2 - Buddhism as religion without God	Sessions 5, 6	Split into the non-creator diagnosis and the complete religious structure
Owner Section 3 - Western critiques of theistic religion	Sessions 13, 14	Feuerbach, Marx, Freud and Comte taught together; Nietzsche taught separately with his ownership routing

Owner material	Where it is taught here	Retention decision
Owner Section 4 - agnosticism	Sessions 4, 15	The four negative positions taught early; the printed 2023 double deliverable taught in full
Owner Section 5 - statement and quote bank	Sessions 13, 14, 15 and Session 18's quotation-discipline block	Retained in full
Owner Section 6 - applied-question drills	The previous-year practice block	Retained as answer routing, with the Nietzsche routing preserved
Owner Section 6A - the five ways of doing without God, parity bench	Session 18 and register card 18	Retained as a six-route bench including the Cārvāka limiting case
Owner Section 7.1-Section 7.4 - model-answer skeletons	Sessions 6, 14, 12, 18 and the practice block	Retained and expanded into complete solutions
Owner Section 9.1 - substantive and functional religion	Sessions 1, 2	Taught as core doctrine, not as optional enrichment
Owner Section 9.2 - Buddhism dossier	Sessions 5, 6	Taught as core
Owner Section 9.3 - Jainism, Mīmāṃsā and Sāṃkhya	Sessions 7, 8, 10	Taught as core , with the three schools separated
Owner Section 9.4 - Nietzsche and post-theistic value	Session 14	Taught as core , with the printed 2025 Nietzsche stem routed to its owner
Owner Section 9.5 - agnosticism and religious naturalism	Sessions 15, 16	Taught as core ; the Advanced dossier records their promotion on 15 August 2026
Owner Section 9.6 - Cārvāka owner-module (2025 Q5(a))	Sessions 11, 12	Taught as core ; it carries a printed previous-year question
Owner Section 9.7 - Mīmāṃsā, <i>apūrva</i> and religion without a deity	Sessions 8, 9	Taught as core in two sessions, argument and objections separated
Owner Section 9.8 - religious naturalism and fictionalism	Sessions 16, 17	Taught as core ; the promotion ledger of 15 August 2026 removes them from Advanced
Owner Section 10 - inter-school debate grid	Session 18 and register card 18	Retained as the nine-row bench
Owner Section 11 - criticisms and replies	Session 18	The four objections and their replies retained in full
Owner Section 12 - fourteen common traps	Distributed across every session's trap block	Retained in full; every trap appears at the point where it is committed
Owner Section 13 - keyword and statement bank	The must-write keyword blocks and register card 18	Retained in full
Owner Section 14-Section 18 - PYQ routing, answer architecture, directive decoder, verdict ladder, quotation discipline	Session 18 and the practice block	Retained in full
Advanced dossier Section 7 - four second-order contrasts	Optional Advanced block only	Second-order debate only; no core content depends on it

[INFERENCE] Correction recorded in this repair. The previous edition of this package pasted the whole of owner Section Section 9-19 into the Optional Advanced block as an unedited source dump, and taught only seven thin sessions above it. Two of those modules - Section 9.6 Cārvāka and Section 9.7 Mīmāṃsā - supply the answer to **printed previous-year questions** (2025 Q5(a) and the 2020 Q6(c) route), and the Advanced dossier's own promotion ledger of **15 August 2026** records that religious naturalism and non-realism/fictionalism "now live in Core and must not be described as Advanced-only". All of that material is therefore taught inside the Basic block, and the Optional Advanced block now carries only genuinely second-order debate.

Origin, chronology and anachronism control

A calendar timeline is not the natural shape of this clause. It is a dispute about the *concept* of religion, not an institution with a founding date. What is required is the minimum chronology that prevents anachronism, plus the dated print anchors an examiner can be quoted at.

CONCEPTUAL ORIGIN OF THE PROBLEM

- Stage 1 A definition of religion is proposed that centres on a personal creator.
- Stage 2 Established traditions are produced that possess doctrine, ritual, ethics, community and liberation, yet no creator.
- Stage 3 The definition is defended by narrowing it -> the charge of question-begging.
- Stage 4 The definition is defended by widening it -> nationalism and ideology walk in.
- Stage 5 A middle criterion is demanded: sacred order + disciplined soteriological practice.
==> the clause exists because Stages 3 and 4 are both unacceptable.

DATED PRINT ANCHORS (assert these; invent no others)

- 1843-44 Karl Marx, Introduction to A Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right ("the opium of the people")
- 1869 T. H. Huxley coins the word "agnostic"
- 1934 John Dewey, A Common Faith ("religion" vs "the religious")
- 1980 Don Cupitt, Taking Leave of God (non-realism; "Sea of Faith")
- 1996 Robin Le Poidevin, Arguing for Atheism (religious fictionalism)
- 1998 Ursula Goodenough, The Sacred Depths of Nature (religious naturalism)
- 2013 Ronald Dworkin, Religion without God (the book that names this clause)

CITE BY WORK, NEVER BY AN INVENTED YEAR

- Nietzsche -> The Gay Science, section 125 (the madman); also 108 and 343; On the Genealogy of Morality
 - Feuerbach -> The Essence of Christianity ("theology is anthropology")
 - Freud -> religion as illusion and cosmic father-projection
 - Comte -> the Religion of Humanity Spinoza -> Deus sive Natura
 - Ninian Smart -> the multidimensional analysis of religion
 - Jaimini -> Mimamsa-sutra 1.1.2 (codana-laksano 'rtho dharmah)
 - Kumarila -> Slokavarttika, against a creator
 - Madhava -> Sarvadarsanasamgraha (the REPORTED Carvaka verses only)
 - Buddhist -> Brahmajala Sutta DN 1; Agganna Sutta DN 27
- Also cite by work: Julian Huxley (evolutionary humanism); Donald Crosby and Loyal Rue (nature as the ground of ultimacy); Andrew Eshleman (fictionalist participation); Howard Wettstein (significance without metaphysical commitment).

ANACHRONISM CONTROL

The Indian non-theistic systems are not "responses to the death of God": they never possessed the theistic horizon Nietzsche is mourning. Marx (1843-44) and Feuerbach precede Nietzsche; Huxley's coinage (1869) precedes all the modern naturalists; Dewey (1934) precedes Cupitt (1980), Le Poidevin (1996), Goodenough (1998) and Dworkin (2013). Keep post-theism and non-theism in separate paragraphs.

The rail explains why the clause exists; the dated strip is the only chronology you may assert. Everything in the third block must be cited by work, never by a manufactured year.

Learning roadmap

Session	Learner objective
1	Decide the clause by choosing and defending a definition of religion
2	Apply the criteria table and the working sufficient cluster
3	Say which religious functions genuinely require a personal deity
4	Separate non-theism, atheism, agnosticism and indifference
5	Reconstruct the Buddhist diagnosis without a creator
6	Show that Buddhism is a complete religion, and place devotional Mahāyāna
7	State the Jain arguments against a creator and place the liberated soul
8	Explain authorless scripture (<i>apauruṣeya</i>) and injunction (<i>codanā</i>)
9	Run the argument for unseen potency (<i>apūrva</i>) and answer Nyāya
10	Use classical Sāṃkhya and Yoga without importing a creator into either
11	Give the Cārvāka epistemology and the attack on concomitance (<i>vyāpti</i>)
12	Apply Cārvāka to religion, answer its critics, and place it as the limit
13	Deploy Feuerbach, Marx, Freud and Comte as critiques of theistic religion
14	Handle "God is dead" as a diagnosis, and respect the ownership routing
15	Answer both deliverables of the printed agnosticism question
16	Evaluate religious naturalism from Dewey to Dworkin
17	Distinguish fictionalism from error theory, non-cognitivism and sublation
18	Construct the theist's denial, the parity bench and the graded verdict

SESSION 1 - THE NECESSITY QUESTION, AND THE DEFINITION THAT DECIDES IT

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. "Religion without God" asks whether a personal creator is *necessary* for something to count as a religion, or whether sacred order, disciplined practice, community and transformation can be enough on their own.

Technical definition. The clause tests a **necessity claim**. A *substantive* definition identifies religion by the kind of object it affirms (God, gods, sacred beings); a *functional* definition identifies it by what it does (orientation to ultimacy, practice, community, meaning, liberation); a *multidimensional* definition identifies it by a cluster of dimensions; a *family-resemblance* definition denies that any single feature is shared by all.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

A personal creator is sufficient for many religions but not necessary for religion as such: what cannot be removed without conceptual cost is not the deity but the sacred order, the disciplined practice and the transformation they organise.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

substantive definition · functional definition · multidimensional definition · family resemblance · Ninian Smart · ultimate concern · necessity claim · question-begging

How to use them: the first three lines of every answer in this clause must name the definition you are using. If you adopt the substantive definition you have conceded the question; if you adopt an unrestricted functional definition you have emptied it. Announce the middle position and then keep to it - inconsistency here is the commonest cause of a mediocre mark.

VISUAL - THE FOUR DEFINITIONS, AND WHERE EACH ONE BREAKS

"WHAT IS A RELIGION?"		
SUBSTANTIVE by its OBJECT God / gods / sacred beings	FUNCTIONAL by what it DOES ultimacy, practice, community, meaning, liberation	MULTIDIMENSIONAL by a CLUSTER (Smart) doctrinal · mythic · ethical · ritual · experiential · social · material
↓	↓	↓
TOO NARROW excludes Buddhism by stipulation = QUESTION-BEGGING	TOO BROAD admits nationalism, art, political cause = EMPTY CATEGORY	THE WORKABLE MIDDLE creator-belief is NOT on the essential list

FAMILY RESEMBLANCE: no single feature is shared by every member;
"religion" names a family of historically varied practices,
not one essence. <-- this is what licenses the cluster test.

Read the top row for the three live definitions, the bottom row for the failure each incurs. The whole clause is decided in the gap between "too narrow" and "too broad".

TEACHING

[FACT] The printed clause owns the necessity question, not the existence question. Nothing in it turns on whether God exists; everything turns on whether *religion* can be constituted without one. That is why an answer that spends its length arguing against theism has answered a different paper.

[FACT] Smart's dimensions. Ninian Smart's multidimensional analysis lists the doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social and material dimensions of religion. **Belief in a creator God is not on the essential list.** This is not a rhetorical convenience: it is a comparative finding drawn from traditions that plainly possess the seven dimensions while lacking a maker of the world.

[FACT] The functional definition. On the functional account, religion is a way of life orienting a person toward ultimate meaning, liberation and the transcendent or absolute - and none of those three requires a personal God. Hence "religion without God" is coherent from the start: the **sacred or ultimate is not necessarily a deity.**

[INFERENCE] Why the family-resemblance point matters. "Religion" names a family of historically varied practices rather than one essence. Once that is granted, the demand for a single necessary feature is itself suspect, and the burden shifts to the theist to show why *this* feature, rather than ritual or community or soteriology, is the indispensable one.

Objection. The substantive definition is not arbitrary: it is the definition every major theistic tradition uses of itself, and it protects the category from dissolving into ethics or sentiment. **Reply.** **[INFERENCE]** Conceded that it protects the category - that is its real strength and it must be granted before it is answered. But a tradition's account of *itself* is not automatically a cross-cultural definition of the genus. If creator-belief is made necessary **by definition**, Buddhism is excluded by stipulation rather than by evidence, and a definition that decides a comparative question before looking at the comparanda is question-begging.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Whether religion without God is possible is settled by which definition of religion the answer adopts, so the definition must be stated and defended first. **Named evidence:** Ninian Smart's multidimensional analysis places doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social and material dimensions on the essential list and leaves creator-belief off it; John Hick's comparative treatment admits Theravāda Buddhism although it lacks worship of a creator. **Analysis:** A substantive definition therefore decides the question in advance, while an unrestricted functional definition decides it too cheaply by admitting any strong commitment; only a cluster definition tests the traditions rather than the vocabulary. **Qualification:** The cluster still has to be policed, because a definition broad enough to include nationalism explains nothing - which is why the sacred-order and soteriological conditions are added in the next paragraph.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not begin by listing godless schools. Begin by stating the definition of religion you will use; the schools are evidence *for* a definition, not a substitute for one.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not adopt a definition narrow enough to exclude Buddhism and then cite Buddhism as a counterexample. That is the commonest internal contradiction in this clause.
3. ANALYSIS: A multidimensional definition must not become so broad that every ideology counts as religion; the breadth has to be policed inside the same answer that introduces it.

MINI RECAP

Four definitions - substantive, functional, multidimensional, family-resemblance. Two failures - too narrow (question-begging) and too broad (empty). One habit - name your definition in sentence one and never drift from it.

SESSION 2 - NECESSARY, SUFFICIENT AND OVER-BROAD: THE WORKING CLUSTER

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. The cluster test asks which features of religion are genuinely indispensable, which are merely widespread, and which are so common that they cannot mark religion off from anything else.

Technical definition. No single feature below is uncontroversially **necessary** for every religion; a defensible examination definition therefore uses a **sufficient cluster** rather than a single necessary condition.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Religion is a socially embodied and disciplined orientation to an ultimate or sacred order, expressed through doctrine, ritual, ethical formation, experience, community and a transformative goal; belief in a personal creator is one historically powerful way of organising that orientation, not a condition of it.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

necessary condition · sufficient cluster · sacred order · ultimate concern · soteriology · disciplined practice · over-breadth · discriminator

How to use them: the examiner is buying the word **discriminator**. Say which feature does the discriminating work in your definition - the owner's answer is *diagnosis-and-liberation* joined to *disciplined relation to a sacred order* - and then show that it admits Buddhism and excludes a football crowd.

VISUAL - THE SEVEN CANDIDATE FEATURES, GRADED

Candidate feature	Necessary?	Why it is not sufficient on its own
Personal creator God	No - Buddhism, Jainism and classical Mīmāṃsā are counterexamples	It defines theism, not religion as such
Sacred or ultimate concern	Strong candidate, but very broad	Nations, art or political causes can become ultimate concerns
Ritual and disciplined practice	Widespread, but not universal in one form	Secular ceremonies also have ritual
Ethical orientation	Common	Ethical philosophies are not automatically religions
Community and tradition	Common	Clubs and nations also organise community
Diagnosis and liberation/salvation	Strong discriminator	Some traditions stress worship or belonging more than liberation
Myth, doctrine and experience	Family features	Each may be thin or absent in a particular strand

THE WORKING SUFFICIENT CLUSTER

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+-----+
| a SOCIALLY EMBODIED and DISCIPLINED orientation |
| to an ULTIMATE / SACRED ORDER,                   |
| expressed through some combination of              |
|   doctrine · ritual · ethical formation · experience · community |
| and a TRANSFORMATIVE or SOTERIOLOGICAL goal.      |
+-----+
ADMITS: Buddhism · Jainism · Mīmāṃsā · Sāṃkhya-Yoga
EXCLUDES: any strong commitment as such (nationalism, ideology, fandom)
AND EXCLUDES: Cārvāka - no sacred order, no soteriology, no path

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Read the table for the grading of each candidate; read the box for the cluster you will actually write. The cluster is a sufficient condition, not a list of necessary ones - say so explicitly.

TEACHING

[FACT] The table's first row is the whole clause in miniature. A personal creator God is not necessary, because three established Indian traditions are counterexamples; and it is not what makes something a religion, because affirming it is precisely what makes something *theistic*. Necessity and definition are being conflated by the position under test.

[FACT] The over-breadth problem is real and must be conceded. Ultimate concern is a strong candidate but a very broad one: nations, art and political causes can all become ultimate concerns. Ritual is widespread but secular ceremonies have it. Ethical orientation is common but ethical philosophies are not religions. Community is common but so are clubs. Every single functional feature, taken alone, over-generates.

[FACT] The discriminator. What does the discriminating work is the pairing of a **sacred or ultimate order** with a **diagnosis-and-liberation structure**. That pairing is present in Buddhism (suffering and its cessation), Jainism (bondage by karmic matter and release into the perfected state), Mīmāṃsā (duty, merit and the promised fruit) and Sāṃkhya (entanglement and isolation), and absent from every secular analogue.

[INFERENCE] Why the cluster is stated as sufficient, not necessary. Listing necessary conditions invites a counterexample for each. Stating a sufficient cluster shifts the argument onto ground you can defend: you are not claiming that every religion has all of these, only that a tradition possessing this combination is a religion whatever it says about a creator.

Objection. A cluster with no necessary condition cannot exclude anything at all: any sufficiently determined movement could be described as possessing "some combination" of the listed features. **Reply. [INFERENCE]** The cluster is not a menu. Two elements are load-bearing and must both be present - a **disciplined relation to an ultimate or sacred order** and a **transformative or soteriological practice**. A political movement may have ritual, community, ethics and doctrine and still fail both, because its ultimate is not treated as sacred and it offers no release from a diagnosed predicament.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: The definition that survives both objections requires a disciplined relation to a sacred order together with a soteriological practice. **Named evidence:** Buddhism supplies the diagnosis of suffering and the path to its cessation; Jainism supplies bondage by karmic matter and release into the perfected state (*siddha*); Mīmāṃsā supplies injunction, merit and a promised fruit; classical Sāṃkhya supplies entanglement and isolation (*kaivalya*). **Analysis:** All four therefore satisfy the cluster while denying a creator, which shows the exclusion of a creator does not remove what makes a tradition religious. **Qualification:** Because the same test excludes Cārvāka, which has neither a sacred order nor a path, the cluster is not merely permissive - it does real classificatory work, and that is what answers the over-breadth charge.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not present the cluster as a list of necessary conditions. It is a sufficient combination, and saying so pre-empt the counterexample hunt.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not answer the nationalism objection by abandoning functionalism. Add the sacred-order and soteriological conditions instead.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the concession that every functional feature over-generates on its own. Making the concession is what earns the right to the repair.

MINI RECAP

Seven candidates, one strong discriminator - diagnosis and liberation. One cluster: sacred order plus disciplined transformative practice. Two things it must do - admit Buddhism, exclude both nationalism and Cārvāka.

SESSION 3 - WHICH RELIGIOUS FUNCTIONS ACTUALLY REQUIRE A DEITY

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Instead of asking whether religion needs God, this session asks the sharper question: which *particular jobs* inside religious life can only be done by a personal deity?

Technical definition. The functions of religion are separable. God is necessary for some **specifically theistic goods** - petition, grace, covenant, propositional revelation from a divine speaker - and not for the generic functions of worship, ritual efficacy, moral motivation or liberation.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

God is a prerequisite for *some* religious goods - petition, grace and covenant - but not for religion as such; the theist's strongest argument is therefore devotional rather than definitional, and it deserves to be met on that ground rather than dismissed.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

petitionary prayer · worship and veneration · propositional revelation · grace and providence · ritual efficacy · moral motivation · soteriology · separability

How to use them: run the function list as a **ledger**, marking each function "requires a responsive person" or "does not". The concession in the first column is what makes the denials in the second column credible.

VISUAL - THE FUNCTION LEDGER

Religious function	Personal deity required?	The non-theistic form it takes
Petitionary prayer	Yes, normally - a responsive addressee is built into petition	meditation, aspiration or recitation, which are not petition in the same sense
Worship / veneration	No	reverence for teaching (<i>Dharma</i>), liberated exemplars, scripture or sacred value
Propositional revelation from God	Yes, by definition	Mīmāṃsā has authorless scriptural authority, not creator-revelation
Grace and providence	Yes , in their personal-agency sense	self-effort, karmic law, disciplined path, communal support perform other functions
Ritual efficacy	No	Mīmāṃsā's unseen ritual potency (<i>apūrva</i>); Buddhist and Jain discipline
Moral motivation	No	compassion, non-injury (<i>ahiṃsā</i>), karma, vows, insight, human flourishing
Liberation / salvation	No, as a generic function	<i>nirvāṇa</i> , Jain liberation, Sāṃkhya-Yoga isolation (<i>kaivalya</i>)

THE SEPARABILITY RESULT

petition ----->	needs a hearer who can choose	theistic good
revelation ----->	needs a speaker	theistic good
grace ----->	needs a giver	theistic good

worship ----->	needs an object worthy of reverence	not a person
efficacy ----->	needs a law or a potency	not a person
motivation ----->	needs a reason and a discipline	not a person
liberation ----->	needs a diagnosis and a path	not a person

=====

WHAT MĪMĀṂSĀ PROVES: authority, efficacy and desert are each SEPARABLE and can each be secured otherwise.

Read the table as a ledger of concessions and denials, and the box as the single result it delivers: the functions God performs are separable from one another and from God.

TEACHING

[FACT] Petition is the honest concession. A responsive addressee who can hear, choose and grant is built into the very act of petition. Meditation, aspiration and recitation are religiously serious, but they are not petition in the same sense. An answer that denies this looks unargued; an answer that concedes it looks candid, and buys credit for everything else it says.

[FACT] Worship does not follow petition. Reverence can be directed to teaching, to liberated exemplars, to scripture or to sacred value. The Jain veneration of a passionless perfected being (*vītarāga*) is the sharpest case: nothing is asked of the object and nothing is granted by it, yet the practice is unmistakably religious.

[FACT] Revelation and grace stay on the theistic side. Propositional revelation *from God* requires a divine speaker by definition; grace and providence in their personal-agency sense require an agent who can give. Mīmāṃsā does not dispute this - it removes the need by making the Veda authorless, which is a different move from claiming a non-personal revealer.

[FACT] Efficacy, motivation and liberation cross over cleanly. Ritual efficacy is secured by Mīmāṃsā's unseen potency (*apūrva*) and by Buddhist and Jain discipline; moral motivation by compassion, non-injury, karma, vows, insight and human flourishing; liberation by *nirvāṇa*, Jain release and Sāṃkhya-Yoga isolation.

Objection. If the theistic goods are genuine goods, a religion that lacks them is thereby a worse religion, and the necessity claim survives in a weakened evaluative form. **Reply. [INFERENCE]** The evaluative point is fair and should be granted: non-theistic religion has a thinner personal structure, and there is a real cost in devotional texture. But "worse in one respect" is not "not a religion", and the printed stems ask about possibility and prerequisite, not about comparative richness.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: The necessity claim should be tested function by function rather than in the abstract. **Named evidence:** Petition requires a responsive addressee and propositional revelation requires a speaker, whereas Mīmāṃsā secures scriptural authority through authorlessness (*apauruṣeya*) and ritual efficacy through unseen potency (*apūrva*), and Buddhism secures liberation through the eightfold path. **Analysis:** The functions God performs - authority, efficacy and desert - are therefore separable from one another and can each be discharged otherwise, so the necessity claim holds only for the specifically relational goods. **Qualification:** That concession is not a retreat: it identifies exactly where the theist's real case lies, and an answer that meets the devotional argument rather than the definitional one is answering the strongest version of the objection.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not claim that God is required for nothing at all. Petition, grace and covenant are genuine theistic goods, and conceding them strengthens the rest of the answer.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not treat "worship" and "prayer" as a single function. Veneration survives the removal of a hearer; petition does not.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not say that non-theistic religions "replace" grace with self-effort. Say that they do not require the function, which is a different and stronger claim.

MINI RECAP

Seven functions, three of them genuinely theistic - petition, revelation, grace. Four of them separable - worship, efficacy, motivation, liberation. The result: what God does is separable, and Mīmāṃsā proves it in a single system.

SESSION 4 - FOUR NEGATIVE POSITIONS: NON-THEISM, ATHEISM, AGNOSTICISM, INDIFFERENCE

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Four different things can be meant by saying that someone "does not believe in God", and they have four different consequences for whether a religion is possible.

Technical definition. **Non-theism** is the absence of a creator from a tradition's diagnosis and path; **atheism** is the positive denial that God exists; **agnosticism** is suspension of judgement, either because the matter is not known (weak) or because it is unknowable (strong); **indifference** is the absence of the question rather than of the answer.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Non-theism is a claim about what a path requires, atheism a claim about what exists, agnosticism a claim about what can be known, and indifference no claim at all: only the first is compatible with a fully constituted religion, and confusing them is what makes a strong case sound like a weak one.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

non-theism · atheism · weak agnosticism · strong agnosticism · indifference · practical atheism · anti-theism · creator-denial

How to use them: decide, for each tradition you cite, which of the four positions it occupies, and say so. Buddhism is non-theistic; Cārvāka is atheistic and more; Huxley is agnostic; the merely unreligious are indifferent. That single sorting sentence signals control of the clause.

VISUAL - THE FOUR POSITIONS, AND WHAT EACH LEAVES STANDING

WHAT KIND OF CLAIM IS BEING MADE?			
NON-THEISM about the PATH	ATHEISM about what EXISTS	AGNOSTICISM about what can be KNOWN	INDIFFERENCE about what is ASKED
creator is absent from diagnosis and path	"God does not exist"	weak: "not known" strong: "un- knowable"	the question does not arise
LEAVES STANDING: lesser gods, devotion, sacred value soteriology	leaves the sacred order only if it is non-divine (Cārvāka does not)	leaves ethical and experien- tial religion available	leaves nothing in particular

RELATED BUT DISTINCT: anti-theism (God-belief is harmful as well as false) and practical atheism (a life organised without reference to God).

THE ONE RULE: religion survives non-theism; it does not survive the removal of every supersensible order.

Read the columns left to right as four increasingly destructive positions, and the bottom row for what each one permits a religion to retain.

TEACHING

[FACT] The firewall. Non-theistic is not identical with atheistic. Rejecting a creator does not entail denying every deity, sacred being, devotional act or transcendent value. Theravāda Buddhism is the canonical illustration: it permits cosmological gods (*devas*) while denying both their creatorhood and their salvific ultimacy.

[FACT] Agnosticism is epistemic. Its claim is about knowledge, not about existence. **T. H. Huxley coined the word in 1869.** The weak form says the matter is not known; the strong form says it is unknowable. An agnostic may continue to value religion's ethical and experiential dimensions while withholding assent on God - which is why agnosticism supports a **minimal or non-theistic religiosity** rather than a rejection of religion.

[FACT] Indifference is not a philosophical position. It is the absence of the question. It appears in the list only so that it can be kept out of the answer; treating a life lived without reference to God as a *theory* about God is a category error.

[INFERENCE] Why sorting matters for marks. The four positions have different burdens. The non-theist must show that a path can be complete; the atheist must defend a denial; the agnostic must explain how suspension coexists with practice. An answer that uses the words interchangeably has quietly taken on all three burdens and discharged none.

Objection. The distinction is verbal: a tradition that assigns a creator no role has effectively denied one, so non-theism collapses into atheism after all. **Reply. [FACT/INFERENCE]** It does not collapse, and the evidence is doctrinal. Buddhism explicitly retains impermanent divine beings inside the round of rebirth and later develops full devotional practice toward Buddhas and bodhisattvas; Jainism venerates liberated perfected beings. A denial of *creatorhood and salvific ultimacy* is compatible with all of that, whereas a denial of *existence* is not.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: The four negative positions must be separated before any tradition is classified. **Named evidence:** Theravāda Buddhism permits cosmological gods while denying their creatorhood and salvific ultimacy; Huxley, who coined "agnostic" in 1869, claims only that God's existence is unknown or unknowable; Cārvāka denies the whole supersensible order rather than a creator alone. **Analysis:** The three positions therefore differ in what they remove - a role, a knowledge claim and an entire ontological domain - and only the first leaves a religion standing. **Qualification:** The distinction is doctrinal rather than diplomatic, so it cannot be dismissed as politeness; it is what allows non-theistic religions to retain devotion without incoherence.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not call Buddhism simply "atheistic". "Non-theistic" is more precise, and the precision is worth marks in the first paragraph.

2. ANALYSIS: Do not say that Buddhism denies every deity. It denies creatorhood and salvific ultimacy, which is a narrower and stronger claim.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not merge agnosticism with atheism or with indifference. Suspension of judgement is an epistemic stance with reasons behind it.

MINI RECAP

Four positions - path, existence, knowledge, absence of question. One firewall - non-theistic ≠ atheistic. One coinage to date correctly - Huxley, 1869. One rule - religion survives non-theism, not the loss of every sacred order.

SESSION 5 - BUDDHISM I: THE DIAGNOSIS THAT NEEDS NO CREATOR

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Buddhism explains why life goes wrong and how it can be put right without any appeal to a being who made the world.

Technical definition. Early Buddhism does not make a creator God part of its diagnosis or its path. **Dependent origination** (*pratītyasamutpāda*) and **karma** explain conditioned arising, while gods and *Brahmā* figures remain impermanent beings inside the round of rebirth (*saṃsāra*) rather than creators or final saviours.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Buddhism does not refute a creator; it renders one idle - suffering arises dependently from craving and ignorance, and removing the conditions removes the suffering, so a maker adds no explanatory and no practical step to the sequence.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*) · **karma** · **Four Noble Truths** · **suffering** (*duḥkha*) · **craving** (*tṛṣṇā*) · **undeclared questions** (*avyākata*) · **deva** · **Brahmā***

How to use them: the phrase that earns the mark is **"explanatorily idle"**. Do not write that Buddhism disproves God; write that the creator hypothesis contributes no necessary step to the causal-soteriological sequence, and then show the sequence.

VISUAL - THE CAUSAL-SOTERIOLOGICAL SEQUENCE, WITH THE VACANT SLOT

THE FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS AS A DIAGNOSIS

1 THERE IS SUFFERING (<i>duḥkha</i>)	<- the datum
2 IT HAS AN ORIGIN: craving + ignorance	<- the cause
3 THE ORIGIN CAN CEASE	<- the possibility
4 THERE IS A PATH TO ITS CESSATION	<- the prescription

↓

DEPENDENT ORIGINATION (*pratītyasamutpāda*)
 "this being, that becomes" - conditions arise, conditions cease

WHERE WOULD A CREATOR GO?	WHAT ABOUT THE GODS?
[vacant slot] no step of the diagnosis, the cause, the cessation or the path requires one	devas and Brahmā figures exist in the cosmology, but they are IMPERMANENT beings inside saṃsāra: neither creators nor final saviours

TEXT ANCHORS: Brahmajāla Sutta (DN 1) · Aggañña Sutta (DN 27)
 SCOPE CONTROL: the undeclared questions (*avyākata*) concern SPECIFIC speculative issues; they are not the whole Buddhist case.

Read the top block as the argument, the left box for the vacancy that is the whole point, and the right box for what Buddhism does not deny.

TEACHING

[FACT] The structure of the argument. Suffering arises dependently from craving and ignorance; removing the conditions removes the suffering. A creator adds no explanatory and no practical step to this causal-soteriological sequence. The claim is one of **redundancy**, not of refutation, and the difference is examinable: the printed stems ask whether religion is possible without God, not whether God has been disproved.

[FACT] The presupposition, stated honestly. The Buddhist case presupposes that **dependent causation is explanatorily sufficient for the religious problem Buddhism addresses**. It does not claim to have shown that dependent causation explains everything whatever. Stating the presupposition is what distinguishes an exposition from a slogan.

[FACT] The undeclared questions, at their real scope. The Buddha's refusal to centre certain speculative questions (*avyākata*) is not a blanket claim that no divine beings exist. It concerns specific issues whose settlement does not advance the path. The **poisoned-arrow parable** prioritises removal of suffering over metaphysical delay; use it as a practical illustration of urgency, not as a proof of atheism.

[FACT] The gods are inside the system, not above it. Where cosmological gods are accepted, they remain impermanent beings within the round of rebirth. The *Brahmajāla Sutta* (DN 1) and the *Aggañña Sutta* (DN 27) are the standard text anchors for the non-creator position, and they work by relocating the would-be creator inside the conditioned order rather than by denying that he exists.

Objection. Karma and the moral order function exactly as providence functions: they guarantee that deeds meet their deserts, so a hidden divine administration has merely been renamed. **Reply. [INFERENCE]** The reply is the same one that answers the hidden-God objection generally. Causal-moral regularity is impersonal: nothing selects, forgives, rewards out of love, or answers. An omnipotent allocator would add features - intention, discretion, responsiveness - that the Buddhist account not only lacks but positively excludes.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Buddhism is a religion without God because its diagnosis and its cure are complete without one. **Named evidence:** The Four Noble Truths identify suffering, its origin in craving and ignorance, its cessation and the path; dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*) supplies the causal machinery; the *Brahmajāla* (DN 1) and *Aggañña* (DN 27) Suttas place *Brahmā* figures inside the conditioned order. **Analysis:** The creator hypothesis therefore contributes no step to either the explanation or the therapy, which is a claim of redundancy rather than of refutation and is correspondingly easier to defend. **Qualification:** The argument presupposes that dependent causation suffices for the specific problem Buddhism addresses, and that presupposition - not a demonstration of God's non-existence - is what the theist must contest.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not present the undeclared questions as the whole Buddhist case. They have a restricted scope, and over-reading them turns a strong position into an evasion.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not use the poisoned-arrow parable as proof of atheism. It illustrates urgency and the priority of the cure.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not write that Buddhism "disproves" a creator. Write that it makes one explanatorily idle, and then show the sequence that does the work.

MINI RECAP

Four truths, one causal engine - dependent origination. One vacancy - no step needs a maker. One scope control - the undeclared questions are narrow. Two text anchors - DN 1 and DN 27.

SESSION 6 - BUDDHISM II: A COMPLETE RELIGION, AND THE DEVOTIONAL COMPLICATION

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Having shown that Buddhism needs no creator, this session shows that what remains is not a philosophy but a full religion - and then deals honestly with the fact that Buddhists worship.

Technical definition. Buddhism possesses the **Four Noble Truths**, the **Noble Eightfold Path**, moral discipline (*śīla*), meditation, the **community** (*Saṅgha*) and a soteriology (*nirvāṇa*, liberation from suffering). Teaching (*Dharma*), community and liberation organise doctrine, practice and value **without functioning as one-for-one substitutes for a personal creator**.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Buddhism is a strong actual counterexample to the claim that a personal creator is necessary - provided religion is defined multidimensionally rather than stipulated as God-relation - because it supplies a complete diagnosis, a disciplined path, an ethic, a community and a final goal.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Noble Eightfold Path · moral discipline (śīla) · meditation · community (Saṅgha) · nirvāṇa · teaching (Dharma) · bodhisattva · devotional Mahāyāna

How to use them: run the cluster from Session 2 against Buddhism item by item - doctrine, ritual, ethics, experience, community, soteriology - and tick each one. That is the 20-mark structure for the 2024 stem, and it converts a list of names into an argument.

VISUAL - THE CLUSTER TEST APPLIED TO BUDDHISM

Cluster element	What Buddhism supplies	Does it need a creator?
Doctrine	Four Noble Truths; dependent origination; impermanence and non-self	No
Ritual and practice	meditation; recitation; monastic observance; later devotional (<i>pūjā</i>) forms	No
Ethical formation	moral discipline (<i>śīla</i>); right speech, action and livelihood	No
Experience	staged meditative attainment; insight	No
Community	the <i>Saṅgha</i> , with rule, ordination and transmission	No
Soteriological goal	<i>nirvāṇa</i> - liberation from suffering	No
Sacred order	<i>Dharma</i> as the order that the path discloses and conforms to	No

THE DEVOTIONAL COMPLICATION - HOW TO HANDLE IT

Later MAHĀYĀNA devotion to Buddhas and bodhisattvas is real, widespread and religiously serious. Two temptations, both wrong:

- "so Buddhism became theistic" (function mistaken for ontology)
- "so it must be a later corruption" (an evidential claim you cannot support)

THE CORRECT LINE:

Buddhas and bodhisattvas may perform religious FUNCTIONS - refuge, gratitude, aspiration, even grace-like assistance - WITHOUT thereby becoming an omnipotent creator.
Non-theistic does NOT mean devotion-free. That single sentence disarms the objection instead of conceding it.

Read the table as the cluster test being discharged row by row, and the box for the one complication that every good answer on this stem must meet.

TEACHING

[FACT] What Buddhism has. It has the Four Noble Truths, the Eightfold Path, ethics (*śīla*), meditation, the *Saṅgha* and a soteriology in *nirvāṇa* - liberation from suffering (*duḥkha*). Every element of the working cluster is present, and none of them is borrowed from theism.

[FACT] What organises it. Teaching (*Dharma*), the community (*Saṅgha*) and liberation (*nirvāṇa*) organise doctrine, practice and value. The owner's qualification is essential and must be reproduced: they do **not** function as one-for-one substitutes for a personal creator. Saying that *Dharma* "takes the place of God" is precisely the sentence the hidden-God objection needs.

[FACT] The devotional development. Later Mahāyāna devotion to Buddhas and bodhisattvas confirms that non-theistic does not mean devotion-free. The reply to the theist is not to deny the devotion but to deny the inference: performing a religious function is not the same as occupying the creator role.

[INFERENCE] The 20-mark shape. For the 2024 stem - *state and evaluate* - the statement must be complete before the evaluation begins. State the non-creator diagnosis (Session 5) and the complete religious structure (this session); then evaluate by conceding the devotional complication and the petition cost, and close with a graded verdict. Evaluating a caricature is the standing fault on "state and evaluate" stems.

Objection. If Buddhas can be prayed to, sacrificed to and relied on for assistance, the tradition has readmitted through practice precisely what it excluded in doctrine, and the counterexample is compromised. **Reply.**

[INFERENCE] The doctrinal exclusion was specific: no maker of the world, no indispensable saviour, no omnipotent allocator. Devotional practice adds none of those. What it does show is that religion needs an **object of reverence**, and that a non-theistic tradition supplies one - which supports the cluster definition rather than undermining it.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Buddhism is not merely compatible with the definition of religion; it satisfies every element of it. **Named evidence:** The Four Noble Truths supply doctrine, the Eightfold Path supplies disciplined practice, moral discipline (*śīla*) supplies ethical formation, meditation supplies experience, the *Saṅgha* supplies community, and *nirvāṇa* supplies the soteriological goal. **Analysis:** Since the cluster is discharged without a creator at any point, the necessity claim fails against an actual and historically continuous tradition rather than against a hypothetical one. **Qualification:** Later devotional Mahāyāna shows that this is not a religion stripped of reverence, but the reverence is directed to awakened exemplars rather than to a maker, so the counterexample survives with its devotional texture intact.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not say that *Dharma*, *Saṅgha* and *nirvāṇa* "replace" God one for one. Say what work each does and what work it does not do.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not treat devotional Mahāyāna as either an embarrassment or a refutation. It is evidence that non-theism is compatible with devotion.
3. ANALYSIS: On a "state and evaluate" stem, do not begin evaluating before the statement is complete. Half the marks are in the exposition.

MINI RECAP

Seven cluster elements, all discharged. One qualification - not one-for-one substitutes. One complication met head-on - devotional Mahāyāna performs functions without installing a creator.

SESSION 7 - JAINISM: CREATOR-DENIAL, AND AN ACHIEVED RATHER THAN A GOVERNING DIVINITY

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Jainism rejects a creator outright, yet keeps liberated perfected beings whom it venerates - which makes it the sharpest test of whether "worship" requires a God.

Technical definition. Jainism accepts **perfected liberated beings** but **no creator**. Souls (*jīva*) are eternal and innumerable; bondage is by **karmic matter**; release is achieved through vows and asceticism into the state of the perfected (*siddha*).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The Jain liberated being is an *achieved* perfection, not a *governing* one: it is venerated as an exemplar of what a soul may become, and precisely because it neither creates nor grants, it shows that veneration is separable from petition.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

soul (*jīva*) · non-soul (*ajīva*) · karmic matter · vows · ford-maker (*tīrthaṅkara*) · perfected being (*siddha*) · passionless (*vītarāga*) · motive argument · embodiment argument

How to use them: the two arguments - **motive** and **embodiment** - are the examinable core. Name them as arguments, not as opinions, and note that the same argument-family recurs in Kumārila's *Ślokavārttika* against a bodiless agent acting on matter.

VISUAL - THE TWO ARGUMENTS, AND THE STATUS OF THE LIBERATED BEING

THE JAIN CASE AGAINST A CREATOR

1. THE MOTIVE ARGUMENT	2. THE EMBODIMENT ARGUMENT
A perfect being lacks any unfulfilled desire.	Action on matter requires a body or instrument.
Creation would answer a need.	A body is itself made and limited.
A perfect being has no need.	an embodied creator is not the unlimited creator claimed.
no motive to create.	

SAME ARGUMENT FAMILY: Kumārila's *Ślokavārttika* against a bodiless agent acting upon matter.

WHAT REPLACES THE CREATOR

eternal souls (<i>jīva</i>)
+ non-soul (<i>ajīva</i>)
+ KARMIC MATTER that binds and is shed
+ VOWS and asceticism
+ liberation as release

WHAT IS VENERATED

<i>tīrthaṅkara</i> - the ford-maker who TEACHES the path
<i>siddha</i> - the perfected soul, passionless (<i>vītarāga</i>): grants nothing, hears nothing

----->

THE DECISIVE LINE: an ACHIEVED divinity, never a GOVERNING one.

Read the top pair as the two arguments; read the bottom pair for the machinery that replaces a creator and the object that survives as worshipful.

TEACHING

[FACT] The doctrine. Jainism accepts perfected liberated beings but no creator. The Jain argument presses both pressures at once: **a perfect being lacks the motive to create**, and **an embodied creator would be limited** by the very embodiment that action on matter requires. These are arguments with premises, and they should be written as such.

[FACT] The replacement machinery. Order and moral consequence are carried by **karmic matter** binding the soul (*jīva*), by the vows that arrest the inflow, and by asceticism that sheds what is already bound. Liberation is the soul's own achievement. Nothing in the sequence requires a supervising intelligence.

[FACT] The status of the venerated object. The ford-maker (*tirthankara*) teaches the path; the perfected being (*siddha*) has completed it. Neither creates, governs, hears or grants. This is exactly why Jainism is the sharpest case in the clause: it retains full-blooded veneration while removing every relational function that veneration is usually assumed to require.

[INFERENCE] Why the theist's best objection lands here. A theist will say that Jain veneration of a passionless liberated being is "really commemoration, not worship", and therefore that Jainism is a philosophy with ceremonies. The reply is that commemoration of a human exemplar does not carry vows, ritual calendars, temple practice, ascetic discipline and a soteriological goal; a category that excludes this is tracking theism rather than religion.

Objection. Jain liberated beings are simply a plurality of gods, so Jainism is polytheistic rather than non-theistic and cannot serve as a counterexample. **Reply. [FACT/INFERENCE]** The objection mistakes perfection for divinity in the relevant sense. A *siddha* has no world-making function, no providential function, no capacity to alter another soul's karma and no responsiveness. What is denied in this clause is a **creator**, and the Jain position denies one explicitly and argues for the denial.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Jainism rejects a creator by argument rather than by silence, and remains a complete religion afterwards.

Named evidence: The motive argument holds that a perfect being has no unfulfilled desire that creating could satisfy; the embodiment argument holds that acting on matter requires a body, which is itself limited; the same argument-family appears in Kumāṛila's *Ślokavārttika*. **Analysis:** Because bondage by karmic matter, the vows and ascetic discipline carry the whole moral-causal and soteriological load, the removal of a creator leaves the religious structure intact. **Qualification:** The liberated perfected being (*siddha*) must be described as an achieved and not a governing perfection, since treating it as a substitute deity would concede exactly the hidden-God objection the Jain case is best placed to defeat.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not conflate Jain liberated beings with a creator God. The difference between an achieved and a governing perfection is the whole point.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not state the Jain position as a bare denial. Give the motive argument and the embodiment argument, with their premises.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not concede that Jain veneration is "merely commemoration". Answer by pointing to vows, ritual, asceticism and the soteriological goal.

MINI RECAP

Two arguments - motive and embodiment. One replacement machinery - souls, karmic matter, vows, asceticism. One decisive formula - achieved divinity, never governing divinity.

SESSION 8 - MĪMĀṂSĀ I: AUTHORLESS SCRIPTURE, INJUNCTION AND INTRINSIC VALIDITY

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Classical Mīmāṃsā keeps scripture, ritual, duty and merit - and removes the author of the scripture, so that no divine speaker is needed to make it authoritative.

Technical definition. The Veda is **authorless** (*apauruṣeya*) - hence eternal, hence not dependent on any speaker's reliability. Its injunctions (*codanā*) are **self-validating** (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*), and dharma is defined by injunction alone.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Mīmāṃsā removes God not by denying him but by making him unnecessary: an authorless scripture needs no speaker whose trustworthiness must first be established, so the entire argument from the reliability of a divine author has nothing left to work on.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

authorless (apauruṣeya) · injunction (codanā) · intrinsic validity (svataḥ-prāmāṇya) · dharma · Jaimini · Mīmāṃsā-sūtra 1.1.2 · eternal word-referent relation · deity as ritual element

How to use them: the sentence that separates a top script is "**apauruṣeya is not revelation**". Write it, explain why, and the Mīmāṃsā counterexample becomes unanswerable at the definitional level.

VISUAL - THE THREE THINGS AN AUTHOR WOULD HAVE BEEN NEEDED FOR

IF SCRIPTURE HAD AN AUTHOR, YOU WOULD NEED ...	MĪMĀMSĀ'S REMOVAL
(a) a speaker whose reliability can be established	APĀURUṢEYA: no author at all, so no reliability question
(b) an external validator of the text's authority	SVATAḤ-PRĀMĀṆYA: injunctions are intrinsically valid
(c) a convention fixing what the words mean	the word-referent relation is ETERNAL

JAIMINI, MĪMĀMSĀ-SŪTRA 1.1.2

"codanā-lakṣaṇo 'rtho dharmah"

dharma = that which is characterised by (Vedic) INJUNCTION and is beneficial

=> dharma is known ONLY from injunction - not from perception, not from inference, and not from any deity's command.

AND THE DEITIES IN THE MANTRAS?

they are ELEMENTS WITHIN THE RITUAL STRUCTURE - the dative to which the oblation is offered - not agents who hear, choose and grant.

Read the left column for the three jobs an author performs, the right column for the device that removes each job, and the sūtra box for the definition you will actually quote.

TEACHING

[FACT] The strongest ritual counterexample. Classical Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā is a **ritual and scriptural religious order in which no creator God performs the main explanatory work**. It keeps scripture, ritual, duty, merit and a soteriological promise, and relocates authority and efficacy elsewhere.

[FACT] The definition of dharma. Jaimini's *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra* 1.1.2 defines dharma as *codanā-lakṣaṇo 'rtho dharmah* - that which is **characterised by injunction** and is beneficial. The epistemic consequence is the reason for citing it: dharma is known **only** from injunction, not from perception, inference or any deity's command. Quoting the sūtra without that consequence earns nothing.

[FACT] Why this removes God, part one. No author is needed for the Veda, so Udayana's arguments from the fact that it is a sentence (*vākyāt*), from its being believed (*pratyayataḥ*) and from its being scripture (*śruteḥ*) have no purchase. The theistic proof-strategy is not refuted point by point; its premise is withdrawn.

[FACT] The deities are not agents. Deities named in the mantras function as **elements within the ritual structure** - the dative to which the oblation is offered - not as beings who hear, choose and grant. This is the point at which a careless script surrenders the counterexample by describing Vedic religion as worship of gods who answer.

[FACT] Kumārila argues the negative case explicitly. The *Ślokavārttika* contains sustained arguments against a creator God, including the **motive problem** and the **impossibility of a bodiless agent acting on matter** - the same argument-family as the Jain arguments of Session 7.

Objection. How can a beginningless, authorless text have determinate meaning at all? Meaning is conventional, and conventions are instituted by speakers. **Reply.** **[FACT/INFERENCE]** Mīmāṃsā answers that meaning is carried by the **eternal relation of word and referent** (*śabdārtha-sambandha-nityatva*), which Nyāya denies as conventional. The dispute is genuine and should be stated as a dispute, not decided by assertion; but it shows the school has an answer rather than an oversight.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Mīmāṃsā secures scriptural authority without a divine speaker. **Named evidence:** The Veda is authorless (*apauruṣeya*) and its injunctions are intrinsically valid (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*); Jaimini's *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra* 1.1.2 defines dharma as what is characterised by injunction and is beneficial; the deities named in mantras are the dative of the offering rather than agents who respond. **Analysis:** Every function a divine author would have discharged - guaranteeing reliability, validating authority and fixing meaning - is therefore reassigned inside the system, so the theistic argument loses its premise rather than its conclusion. **Qualification:** The meaning problem remains a live dispute with Nyāya, and the honest form of the claim is that Mīmāṃsā has a determinate answer to it, not that the answer is uncontested.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not describe the Mīmāṃsā Veda as "revelation". It is **authorless**, therefore not the speech of any God, and the word "revelation" reinstates the speaker the school has removed.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not present the mantra-deities as recipients who answer. They are structural elements of the rite.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not quote *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra* 1.1.2 as decoration. Quote it for the epistemic consequence that dharma is knowable only from injunction.

MINI RECAP

Three jobs an author would do - reliability, validation, meaning. Three devices that retire them - authorlessness, intrinsic validity, eternal word-referent relation. One sūtra, quoted for its consequence: 1.1.2.

SESSION 9 - MĪMĀṂSĀ II: UNSEEN POTENCY, THE TWO SCHOOLS, AND THE NYĀYA OBJECTIONS

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. If a ritual performed today produces a result years later or after death, something must carry the connection - and Mīmāṃsā says that something is a potency generated by the act, not a god keeping accounts.

Technical definition. Unseen potency (*apūrva*, "the not-before") is a **postulate** (*arthāpatti*) introduced to explain the delayed fruit of an injunction. Kumārila Bhaṭṭa treats it as a **power** (*śakti*) residing in the act or agent; Prabhākara Miśra reframes the matter around the **ought-to-be-done** (*niyoga/kārya*) disclosed by the injunction.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Mīmāṃsā shows that the functions God performs - authority, efficacy and desert - are separable and can each be secured otherwise: authority by an authorless Veda, efficacy and desert by a postulated potency that operates as law rather than as administration.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

unseen potency (*apūrva*) · **postulation** (*arthāpatti*) · **power** (*śakti*) · **ought-to-be-done** (*niyoga/kārya*) · **Kumārila Bhaṭṭa** · **Prabhākara Miśra** · **superintendent of karma** (*karmādhyaṅkṣa*) · **law-like versus deliberative**

How to use them: state the five steps of the argument, then the two-school split, then the Nyāya objection and its reply. A named potency without the perished-cause problem behind it reads as vocabulary rather than argument.

VISUAL - THE FIVE-STEP ARGUMENT, THE SPLIT, AND THE THREE OBJECTIONS

THE ARGUMENT FOR APŪRVA - five steps, all of them examinable

- 1 a Vedic injunction PROMISES a result (heaven from the jyotiṣṭoma)
- 2 the result does NOT follow immediately upon the act
- 3 the act is momentary and PERISHES
- 4 a perished cause cannot produce a later effect
- 5 the act must generate an UNSEEN POTENCY that persists until the result matures = APŪRVA, "the not-before"

EPISTEMIC STATUS: a POSTULATE (*arthāpatti*), never a perceived entity.

Mīmāṃsā's own epistemology licenses postulation to explain an otherwise inexplicable fact - so this is a sanctioned move, not an invention.

THE TWO-SCHOOL SPLIT - and why it matters ethically

[-----]	
KUMĀRILA BHATṬA	PRABHĀKARA MIŚRA
apūrva = a POWER (śakti) in	recentres on NIYOGA / KĀRYA - the
the act or the agent, linking	sheer "ought-to-be-done" disclosed
deed to fruit	by the injunction
=> a consequential mechanism	=> a DEONTOLOGY of the injunction:
of DESERT	the fruit is not the primary
	content of the motivation
+-----	

THREE OBJECTIONS, THREE REPLIES

O1 (Nyāya) an unconscious potency cannot SELECT the right fruit for the right agent at the right time; only an intelligent superintendent (*karmādhyaṅśa*) can.

R1 the relation is LAW-LIKE, not deliberative; the objection assumes that only agents produce determinate outcomes - which begs the question against natural law.

O2 how can a beginningless authorless text have determinate meaning?

R2 the word-referent relation is eternal (Nyāya denies this: dispute noted).

O3 is this religion, or bureaucracy?

R3 it has a sacred order, a soteriological promise, a disciplined practice and a community - exactly what a functional definition requires.

CAUTION: HONEST NOTE: later Mīmāṃsā authors drift toward theism; the atheistic reading is of the CLASSICAL system.

Read the five steps as the argument, the split for the ethical payoff, and the three objections as the evaluation section of any 15-mark answer on this school.

TEACHING

[FACT] The argument. A Vedic injunction promises a result that does not follow immediately upon the act; the act is momentary and perishes; a perished cause cannot produce a later effect; therefore the act must generate an unseen potency that persists until the result matures. That potency is *apūrva* - "the not-before", something new that did not previously exist.

[FACT] Its epistemic status. It is a **postulate** (*arthāpatti*), not a perceived entity. Mīmāṃsā's own epistemology licenses postulation to explain an otherwise inexplicable fact. Treating it as something observed is a listed trap, and treating it as an arbitrary invention ignores that the school has a sanctioned method for introducing it.

[FACT] The two schools, and why the split matters. Kumārila treats the potency as a **power** (*śakti*) residing in the act or the agent and linking act to fruit. Prabhākara reframes the whole matter around **the ought-to-be-done** (*niyoga/kārya*) - the sheer imperative disclosed by the injunction, which motivates action without needing a promised fruit as its primary content. Prabhākara's ethics is therefore closer to a **deontology of the injunction**; Kumārila's to a **consequential mechanism of desert**.

[FACT] Why this removes God, part two. No dispenser of karmic fruit is needed, since the potency does that work - so the Nyāya argument that a superintendent of karma (*karmādhyaṅśa*) is required is answered directly rather than ignored.

[FACT] The three objections and replies are set out in the visual and must be reproduced in a 15-mark answer. The third is the one candidates omit: the charge that this is administration rather than religion is answered by the cluster from Session 2 - sacred order, soteriological promise, disciplined practice, community.

CAUTION: Honest qualification. Later Mīmāṃsā authors drift toward theism. The atheistic reading defended here is of the **classical** system, and saying so protects the answer from an easy correction.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Mīmāṃsā answers the desert argument that is usually thought to require a divine administrator. **Named evidence:** The unseen potency (*apūrva*) is postulated because a perished momentary act cannot produce a fruit that matures much later, often after death; Kumāṛila treats it as a power in the act, Prabhākara recentres the analysis on the ought-to-be-done; Nyāya replies that only an intelligent superintendent can allocate fruits. **Analysis:** The Mīmāṃsā answer is that the relation is law-like rather than deliberative, so the Nyāya objection presupposes what it needs to prove - that determinate outcomes require a selecting mind. **Qualification:** The atheistic reading holds of the classical system, since later authors of the school drift toward theism, and the argument should be advanced with that restriction stated.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not treat *apūrva* as an observed entity. It is a postulate (*arthāpatti*) introduced to explain a delayed fruit.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not merge Kumāṛila's power (*śakti*) version with Prabhākara's *niyoga/kārya* version. The split has a real ethical payoff.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not leave the Nyāya allocation objection unanswered. The reply is that law-like relations produce determinate outcomes without deliberation.

MINI RECAP

Five steps to a postulate. Two schools - power versus imperative, desert versus duty. Three objections answered - allocation, meaning, bureaucracy. One honest limit - the classical system only.

SESSION 10 - SĀṂKHYA AND YOGA: A COSMOS WITHOUT A MAKER

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Classical Sāṃkhya explains the whole evolving world from unconscious nature working in the presence of conscious selves, and seeks release by discrimination rather than by rescue.

Technical definition. Classical Sāṃkhya explains the cosmos through **primordial nature** (*prakṛti*) evolving through its constituent strands (*guṇa*) in proximity to plural conscious selves (*puruṣa*), with liberation as **isolation** (*kaivalya*) attained through discriminative knowledge (*viveka-khyāti*). Yoga retains a **special self** (*Īśvara*) who is **not straightforwardly a creator** in the classical Sāṃkhya sense.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

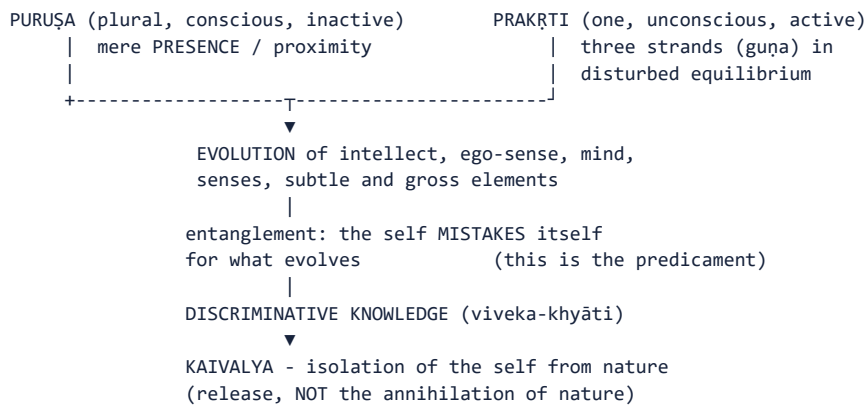
Sāṃkhya shows that a complete cosmology and a complete soteriology can be built from an unconscious principle and a plurality of conscious selves, so that the demand for a maker is a demand for an extra term the system never needed.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

primordial nature (*prakṛti*) · **self** (*puruṣa*) · **strands** (*guṇa*) · **isolation** (*kaivalya*) · **discriminative knowledge** (*viveka-khyāti*) · **special self** (*Īśvara*) · **non-conscious purposiveness** · **milk-and-calf analogy**

How to use them: keep Sāṃkhya and Yoga in separate sentences. The single most damaging error here is importing Yoga's *Īśvara* into classical Sāṃkhya, which destroys the counterexample you have just offered.

VISUAL - TWO PRINCIPLES, ONE EVOLUTION, ONE RELEASE



WHERE IS THE CREATOR? -- nowhere; nothing in the sequence requires one.
 YOGA'S ĪŚVARA: a SPECIAL self, untouched by affliction and action -
 NOT straightforwardly a creator in the classical Sāṃkhya sense.
 => do not read Yoga's Īśvara back into Sāṃkhya.

THE NYĀYA PRESSURE AND THE REPLY

Nyāya: an unconscious principle cannot organise ENDS.
 Reply: observed regularity need not be modelled on artefact production.
 Standard illustration: milk seeming to nourish the calf -
 non-conscious purposiveness, no deliberating maker.

Read the two columns as the two principles, the vertical spine as the process, and the bottom pair as the objection every examiner expects you to have met.

TEACHING

[FACT] The doctrine. Classical Sāṃkhya explains the cosmos through nature (*prakṛti*) for the sake of the selves (*puruṣa*), without a creator. Unconscious nature evolves through the strands (*guṇa*) in proximity to the conscious self, and the goal is isolation (*kaivalya*) reached by discriminative knowledge.

[FACT] The presupposition. Impersonal law or dual principles can explain order and liberation. That is a substantive philosophical commitment, not a neutral observation, and an answer that states it as a presupposition rather than smuggling it in reads as controlled.

[FACT] The Yoga distinction. Yoga's special self (*Īśvara*) is **not straightforwardly a creator** in the classical Sāṃkhya sense. It is a self distinguished by freedom from affliction, action and their residues, not a maker of the world; and importing it into Sāṃkhya converts a non-theistic system into a theistic one by editorial accident.

[FACT] The canonical examples. Karmic matter binding the soul is Jain; the Vedic injunction is Mīmāṃsā; for Sāṃkhya the standard illustration is **milk seeming to nourish the calf** - an analogy used in the discussions for non-conscious purposiveness, where an end is served without anything deliberating about it.

[FACT] The Nyāya objection and the reply. Nyāya argues that unconscious principles cannot organise ends. The non-theistic schools reply that **observed regularity need not be modelled on artefact production**. That reply is the general form of the answer to design arguments inside this clause, and it also serves Buddhism and Mīmāṃsā.

Objection. Sāṃkhya's nature acts "for the sake of" the self, which is teleological language; teleology without a mind is either incoherent or a disguised creator. **Reply. [INFERENCE]** The reply is the milk analogy generalised: purposive-looking regularity is observed in cases where no deliberation occurs, so the inference from apparent purpose to a deliberating agent is not compulsory. The Sāṃkhya position is that this is the primitive fact about nature; the theist is free to deny it, but must then argue for the artefact model rather than assume it.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Classical Sāṃkhya supplies a complete non-theistic cosmology and soteriology. **Named evidence:** Nature (*prakṛti*) evolves through its three strands in proximity to plural conscious selves (*puruṣa*); the predicament is misidentification; the release is isolation (*kaivalya*) attained by discriminative knowledge; Yoga adds a special self (*Īśvara*) who is not a creator in the Sāṃkhya sense. **Analysis:** Because both the world-process and the release are accounted for without a maker, the demand for one is a demand for an additional term with no explanatory work to do. **Qualification:** Nyāya's objection that unconscious principles cannot organise ends is genuine, and the reply - that observed regularity need not be modelled on artefact production - is a rejection of the design model rather than a refutation of it.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not import Yoga's *Īśvara* into classical Sāṃkhya. Yoga's special self is not straightforwardly a creator, and Sāṃkhya has none at all.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not describe isolation (*kaivalya*) as the destruction of nature. It is the self's release from entanglement with it.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not leave the Nyāya design pressure unanswered; the artefact-model reply is what converts exposition into evaluation.

MINI RECAP

Two principles, one evolution, one release. One distinction to protect - Yoga's special self is not Sāṃkhya's creator, because Sāṃkhya has none. One reply to design - regularity is not artefact production.

SESSION 11 - CĀRVĀKA I: PERCEPTION ALONE, AND THE ATTACK ON CONCOMITANCE

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Cārvāka holds that the only reliable way of knowing anything is seeing it, and then argues that reasoning from what we see to what we cannot see never delivers certainty.

Technical definition. Cārvāka (Lokāyata) holds that **perception** (*pratyakṣa*) is the only valid means of knowledge (*pramāṇa*). Consequently nothing supersensible can be known. Reality is the **four gross elements** (*bhūtacatuṣṭaya*: earth, water, fire, air; ether is rejected as imperceptible), and the human ends reduce to pleasure (*kāma*) and wealth (*artha*).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The Cārvāka critique is epistemological before it is anything else: it is an argument about what a means of knowledge must deliver, and the hedonism that the tradition is remembered for is a consequence of that argument, not its substance.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

perception (*pratyakṣa*) · **means of knowledge** (*pramāṇa*) · **inference** (*anumāna*) · **concomitance** (*vyāpti*) · **mark** (*hetu*) · **inferred** (*sādhya*) · **conditioning factor** (*upādhi*) · **deviation** (*vyabhicāra*) · **four elements** (*bhūtacatuṣṭaya*)

How to use them: the examinable core is the **concomitance problem**, and it has four moves - not by perception, not by inference, not by testimony, and the residual conditioning-factor problem. Give all four or the argument has not been given.

VISUAL - THE FOUR CLOSED ROUTES TO CONCOMITANCE

WHY ONLY PERCEPTION?

- 1 a means of knowledge must yield CERTAINTY about its object
- 2 perception is self-evident and immediately certain
- 3 every other candidate - inference, comparison, testimony, postulation - is either reducible to perception or depends on a general rule that perception cannot certify
- 4 perception alone is a pramāṇa, and knowledge does not extend beyond the perceptible

THE ATTACK ON INFERENCE

inference (anumāna) depends on VYĀPTI - an INVARIABLE, UNCONDITIONAL concomitance between the mark (hetu: smoke) and the inferred (sādhya: fire).
CĀRVĀKA'S QUESTION: by what means is vyāpti ITSELF known?

- (1) NOT BY PERCEPTION - perception grasps only particular co-presences, here and now. Vyāpti is UNIVERSAL, covering unobserved past, future and remote cases. No perception reaches those.

(2) NOT BY INFERENCE - that inference needs its own vyāpti: INFINITE REGRESS or CIRCULARITY.

(3) NOT BY TESTIMONY - testimony's authority would itself have to be established, and for the Cārvāka it is not a pramāṇa at all.

(4) THE UPĀDHI PROBLEM - even repeated observation cannot rule out an unnoticed CONDITIONING FACTOR making the concomitance hold only contingently. Standard example: fire is accompanied by smoke ONLY WHEN THE FUEL IS WET. Unless every possible upādhi is excluded - and that exclusion is itself unverifiable - the concomitance remains merely PROBABLE: vyabhicāra stays possible.

CONCLUSION: inference cannot deliver certainty. Where it works in daily life it works by luck or habit; and in the supersensible domain - God, soul, karma, afterlife - no perceptual check is EVER available, so there inference is worthless.

Read the top block for why perception alone, the boxed block for the four closed routes, and the closing lines for the domain-restricted conclusion that is the school's real thesis.

TEACHING

[FACT] The ontology. Reality is the four gross elements - earth, water, fire and air. **Ether is rejected because it is imperceptible**, which is not an arbitrary omission but a direct consequence of the epistemology. The four human ends reduce to pleasure (*kāma*) and wealth (*artha*), because the other two require a supersensible order to be intelligible.

[FACT] Why only perception. The argument runs in four steps, given in the visual. Its force is that it does not merely assert a preference for the senses: it sets a **certainty condition** on what counts as a means of knowledge and then argues that only perception meets it.

[FACT] The concomitance problem is the examinable core. Inference depends on an invariable, unconditional concomitance between the mark and the inferred. The Cārvāka asks how that concomitance is itself known, and closes the three obvious routes in turn. This is the passage a 10-mark answer on the 2025 stem must contain.

[FACT] The conditioning-factor residue. Even repeated observation cannot exclude an unnoticed conditioning factor (*upādhi*) that makes the concomitance hold only contingently - the standard example being that fire is accompanied by smoke only when the fuel is wet. Unless every possible conditioning factor is excluded, and that exclusion is itself unverifiable, deviation (*vyabhicāra*) remains possible and the concomitance remains merely probable.

[INFERENCE] The shape of the conclusion. Notice that the conclusion is domain-restricted in its own statement: inference "works by luck or habit" in daily life, and is worthless precisely where no perceptual check is available. That restriction is what makes the moderate reading of the school available in Session 12.

Objection. The certainty condition is too strong. No source of knowledge, including perception, delivers indubitable certainty, so the argument proves too much. **Reply. [FACT/INFERENCE]** This is the **parity argument**, and it is one of the standard replies: perception itself faces illusion, dream and defective organs, and is corrected only by further cognition. The Cārvāka must either weaken the certainty condition - in which case inference re-enters - or accept that perception fails its own test. That dilemma is the cleanest single criticism of the strong thesis.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: The Cārvāka critique of belief in suprasensible entities is an argument about the means of knowledge, not a set of slogans about pleasure. **Named evidence:** Perception (*pratyakṣa*) is held to be the only means of knowledge; inference depends on an invariable concomitance (*vyāpti*) between mark and inferred; that concomitance cannot be reached by perception, since it is universal, nor by inference, on pain of regress or circularity, nor by testimony; and an unnoticed conditioning factor (*upādhi*), such as wet fuel, can never be conclusively excluded. **Analysis:** The conclusion is therefore that inference yields probability rather than certainty, and that in the supersensible domain, where no perceptual check exists, it yields nothing at all. **Qualification:** The certainty condition on which the argument rests is contestable, since perception is itself corrigible, and the parity objection is the point at which the strong version of the thesis begins to fail.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not state the Cārvāka position on inference without the concomitance problem. The argument is the four closed routes, not the conclusion.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the conditioning factor. Repeated observation without the exclusion problem is not the Cārvāka case.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not make hedonism the substance of a 2025-style answer. The exam wants the epistemology; the ethics is a consequence.

MINI RECAP

One certainty condition, four closed routes, one residue. The conclusion is domain-restricted in its own wording. The parity objection is where the strong thesis first cracks.

SESSION 12 - CĀRVĀKA II: THE APPLICATION TO RELIGION, THE REPLIES, AND THE LIMITING-CASE VERDICT

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Once nothing beyond the senses can be known, everything religion trades in goes: God, soul, karma, heaven, rebirth, ritual merit, liberation and the authority of scripture.

Technical definition. The epistemology is applied to remove God, the immaterial soul, unseen merit (*adrṣṭa*), heaven and hell, rebirth, ritual potency (*apūrva*), liberation and Vedic authority. Consciousness becomes an **emergent property of the body** (*dehātmavāda*), and order is explained by things acting according to **their own nature** (*svabhāva-vāda*).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Cārvāka is not a godless religion but the closure of the epistemic route to any supersensible object - which is why it ends not in religion without God but in no religion at all, and why it shows what the non-theistic religions actually retain.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

emergent consciousness (*dehātmavāda*) · intoxicating power (*madaśakti*) analogy · own-nature (*svabhāva-vāda*) · unseen merit (*adrṣṭa*) · self-refutation · dialectical reductio (*prasaṅga*) · ordinary (*laukika*) · beyond-the-senses (*atīndriya*) · Purandara · Mādhava's *Sarvadarśanaśaṅkha**

How to use them: the mark-earning move is the **classification verdict**. Say explicitly that Cārvāka is *not* an instance of religion without God, and use it as the limiting case that reveals what Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā keep.

VISUAL - THE APPLICATION, THE FIVE REPLIES, AND THE VERDICT

THE APPLICATION TO RELIGION

- (a) GOD never perceived => the inference from world-as-effect to an intelligent maker is doubly worthless
- (b) THE SOUL not a separate substance: consciousness is an EMERGENT property of the body (dehātma-vāda). Standard analogy: the intoxicating power (madaśakti) arising when fermenting ingredients are combined, though present in none singly.
=> no survival, no transmigration, no liberation
- (c) KARMA and unseen merit (adṛṣṭa) - imperceptible postulates invented to prop up ritual
- (d) THE VEDA authority denied; the verses transmitted in Mādhava's Sarvadarśanasamgraha, attributed there to Bṛhaspati, mock the fire-sacrifice, the three Vedas and asceticism
CAUTION: these survive ONLY as quotations in opponents' works:
report them as doxographic, never as primary text; and
never build an answer on the hedonist couplet
- (e) ORDER svabhāva-vāda - things behave according to their own nature; the thorn's sharpness and the peacock's colour need no maker

THE FIVE REPLIES - and the Cārvāka rejoinders

- 1 SELF-REFUTATION "no inference is valid" is itself a universal claim, unperceivable, hence inferred. => REJOINER: advance it DIALECTICALLY, as a prasaṅga internal to the opponent's commitments, asserting no positive universal.
- 2 PRAGMATIC no one can eat, speak, teach or argue without inference.
- 3 NYĀYA'S DEFENCE concomitance is established by repeated uncontradicted co-observation (bhūyodarśana), non-observation of a counter-instance (vyabhicāra-adarśana) and hypothetical reasoning (tarka); with the technical device of sāmānya-lakṣaṇa-pratyāsatti for cognising universals.
- 4 PARITY perception errs too - illusion, dream, defective organs.
- 5 THE MODERATE STRAND ANALYSIS: CAUTION: the fragmentary PURANDARA is reported as accepting inference for ORDINARY matters (laukika) while rejecting it for the SUPERSENSIBLE (atindriya). On this reading the school is not committed to self-refuting global scepticism; its thesis is that inference cannot be extended beyond the domain in which concomitance can be perceptually checked - a classical Indian anticipation of the empiricist critique of metaphysics.

===== THE CLASSIFICATION VERDICT =====

Is Cārvāka a "religion without God"? NO.
no soteriology · no sacred · no community of practice · no ultimate concern
Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā show religion can survive the LOSS OF GOD.
Cārvāka shows what happens when the EPISTEMIC ROUTE to any supersensible object is closed: not a godless religion, but no religion at all.
=> what non-theistic religions retain is not a substitute deity but an
ACCEPTED SUPERSENSIBLE ORDER - dharma, karma, nirvāṇa, apūrva.

Read the first block for the application, the second for the evaluation section of any Cārvāka answer, and the framed verdict for the sentence that distinguishes a top script.

TEACHING

[FACT] The emergence thesis and its analogy. Consciousness is an emergent property of the body. The standard analogy is the intoxicating power (*madaśakti*) that arises when fermenting ingredients are combined although present in none of them singly. Because there is no separate conscious substance, there is no survival, no transmigration and no liberation - the soteriological apparatus is removed in one step.

[FACT] Order without design. Things behave according to their own nature (*svabhāva-vāda*): the sharpness of a thorn and the colour of a peacock require no maker. This is the Cārvāka counterpart of the Sāṃkhya reply to design, and it is stronger because it declines the supersensible altogether.

CAUTION: Attribution discipline. The verses attributed to Bṛhaspati survive only as quotations in the works of opponents, chiefly Mādhava's *Sarvadarśanasamgraha*. Treat them as **reported Cārvāka positions**, not as verified primary text, and never present the popular hedonist couplet as anything more than a doxographic quotation.

[FACT] The five replies must all appear in an evaluation. Self-refutation, the pragmatic argument, Nyāya's positive defence of concomitance, parity, and the reported moderate strand. Leaving the self-refutation charge unanswered forfeits the evaluation marks; the two rejoinders are the dialectical reading and the Purandara strand.

[FACT] The verdict formula. "Cārvāka's critique succeeds exactly as far as its epistemology does. If the strong thesis is held - perception alone - it is self-refuting and pragmatically unliveable. If the moderate thesis is held - inference is admissible only where its concomitance can in principle be perceptually checked - the critique is powerful, unrefuted, and fatal to every inference-based natural theology, including Udayana's."

[INFERENCE] Why the classification matters so much here. Candidates reach for Cārvāka as the most obvious "godless Indian school" and thereby lose the clause, because absence of God is not by itself the criterion of anything. Placing Cārvāka correctly is the fastest available demonstration that you know what the criterion is.

Objection. If the moderate reading is adopted, Cārvāka is no longer radical: it becomes ordinary empiricism, and the school's distinctive place in the clause disappears. **Reply. [INFERENCE]** The moderate reading is *more* damaging, not less. Ordinary empiricism plus a domain restriction is exactly what closes every inference-based natural theology, and it does so without the self-refutation that makes the strong thesis easy to dismiss. The radicalism migrates from the epistemology to its consequences.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Cārvāka marks the boundary of this clause rather than supplying an instance of it. **Named evidence:** Consciousness is treated as an emergent property of the body (*dehātmavāda*), illustrated by the intoxicating power arising from combined ingredients; order is explained by own-nature (*svabhāva-vāda*); the school has no soteriology, no sacred, no community of practice and no ultimate concern. **Analysis:** Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā therefore show that religion survives the loss of God, while Cārvāka shows that it does not survive the closure of the route to every supersensible object. **Qualification:** On the reported moderate strand associated with Purandara the school admits ordinary inference and denies it only for what lies beyond the senses; the evidence for that strand is fragmentary and reported by opponents, so it must be flagged as a reported reading rather than the settled position.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not call Cārvāka a "religion without God". It has no soteriology, no sacred and no practice; it is the limiting case.
2. CAUTION: Do not quote the Bṛhaspati verses or the hedonist couplet as primary text. They survive only in opponents' doxographies.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not leave the self-refutation objection standing. Give the dialectical reading and the reported Purandara strand, with the evidence flagged.

MINI RECAP

Five applications, five replies, one verdict formula. The strong thesis is self-refuting; the moderate thesis is unrefuted and fatal to natural theology. And Cārvāka is the limit, not the example.

SESSION 13 - WESTERN CRITIQUES OF THEISTIC RELIGION: FEUERBACH, MARX, FREUD, COMTE

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. A family of nineteenth- and twentieth-century critics argued that religion is not about God at all - it is about human beings, and it can be explained by what humans want, fear or suffer.

Technical definition. These are **explanatory critiques** of theistic religion: Feuerbach's **projection** thesis, Marx's account of religion as consolation masking exploitation, Freud's account of it as **illusion** and wish-fulfilment, and Comte's proposal of a positive **religion of humanity** to occupy the vacated place.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The projection critiques do not prove that God does not exist; they claim that belief in God can be fully explained without him - and it is that explanatory claim, not an atheistic conclusion, which they must be assessed for.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

projection · "theology is anthropology" · "the opium of the people" · illusion · wish-fulfilment · cosmic father-projection · religion of humanity · secular humanism

How to use them: cite each by work, never by an invented year, and mark each as a **genetic** explanation. Then say what a genetic explanation can and cannot establish - that is the analytical move the examiner is buying.

VISUAL - FOUR CRITIQUES, ONE STRUCTURE, ONE LIMIT

Critic	The claim	What it explains religion by	Named source
Feuerbach	"Theology is anthropology" - God is the projection of humanity's own idealised essence	human self-alienation	<i>The Essence of Christianity</i>
Marx	religion is "the opium of the people ", a consoling illusion masking economic exploitation; it dissolves with a just society	material conditions	Introduction to <i>A Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right</i> , 1843-44
Freud	religion is an illusion , a wish-fulfilment and cosmic father-projection	infantile helplessness and desire	Freud's writings on religion as illusion
Comte	replace the object: a positive religion of humanity - devotion to human values without a deity	the need religion answers, retained	Comte's Religion of Humanity

THE SHARED STRUCTURE - and the shared limit

- 1 identify a HUMAN need, fear, want or condition
- 2 show that belief in God would be produced by it ANYWAY
- 3 conclude that the belief is fully EXPLAINED without the object



WHAT THIS ESTABLISHES: the belief is not self-authenticating; the inference "people believe, therefore there is something to believe in" is blocked.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT ESTABLISH: that the object does not exist. A true belief can also have a psychological or economic cause.

=> THE GENETIC FALLACY LINE: origin does not settle truth. Say it, and you have both used the critiques and priced them correctly.

WHERE THEY LEAD IN THIS CLAUSE: toward SECULAR HUMANISM and Comte's "religion of humanity" - which is why the clause routes them onward to the Humanism, Secularism and Multiculturalism owner rather than developing them for their own sake.

Read the table for the four positions and their named sources, and the box for the single evaluative move that must accompany all four.

TEACHING

[FACT] Feuerbach. "Theology is anthropology" - God is the projection of humanity's own idealised essence. The predicates traditionally assigned to God - love, wisdom, power - are human predicates, magnified and then set over against their owners. The critique is therefore an account of **self-alienation** as much as of belief.

[FACT] Marx. Religion is "the opium of the people": a consoling illusion masking economic exploitation, which will dissolve with a just society. If the fuller sentence is quoted it is markedly more sympathetic than the slogan, and the source is the Introduction to *A Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right* (1843-44).

[FACT] Freud. Religion is an illusion - a wish-fulfilment and a cosmic father-projection. "Illusion" in his technical use marks a belief held because it is wished for, which is a claim about its motivation rather than a direct verdict on its truth.

[FACT] Comte. These critiques lead toward secular humanism and a "religion of humanity": devotion to human values without a deity. Comte is the bridge from critique to construction, and he is the reason this session belongs in a clause about religion *without* God rather than in a clause about arguments against theism.

[INFERENCE] The evaluative move. All four share one structure and one limit. They are **genetic** explanations: they explain why the belief arises. Origin does not settle truth - a true belief may also have a psychological or economic cause. What the critiques do establish is narrower and still important: the belief is not self-authenticating, so the move from widespread belief to a real object is blocked.

Objection. If the projection thesis is right, then Comte's religion of humanity is equally a projection, and merely relocating devotion from God to humanity is no gain. **Reply. [INFERENCE]** The reply available to Comte is that a projection becomes pathological only when its human origin is concealed; a religion of humanity is transparent about its object, so the self-alienation Feuerbach diagnoses is precisely what it removes. Whether the result is still *religion* is the question this clause then hands to Sessions 16 and 17.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: The nineteenth-century critiques explain theistic belief without appealing to its object. **Named evidence:** Feuerbach's *The Essence of Christianity* treats God as the projected essence of humanity; Marx's 1843–44 Introduction calls religion the opium of the people; Freud treats it as illusion and cosmic father-projection; Comte proposes a religion of humanity in the space that is left. **Analysis:** Each therefore offers a genetic account, and a genetic account blocks the inference from belief to object without establishing that the object is absent. **Qualification:** Origin does not settle truth, so these critiques belong in this clause as evidence that religious functions are detachable from theism, not as arguments that no deity exists.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not present these as proofs of atheism. They are explanatory critiques, and their limit is the genetic fallacy.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not quote "opium of the people" as though it were a sneer. The fuller sentence is more sympathetic, and quoting it accurately signals control.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not let secular humanism crowd out the Indian cases. Comte belongs here as a bridge, and the Humanism owner develops him further.

MINI RECAP

Four critics, one structure - identify a need, derive the belief, dispense with the object. One limit - origin does not settle truth. One destination - Comte's religion of humanity, and the modern debate of Sessions 16 and 17.

SESSION 14 - NIETZSCHE: DIAGNOSIS, GENEALOGY, AND WHO OWNS THE QUESTION

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Nietzsche's famous declaration is a claim about a culture, not a claim about a cosmos: the framework that made belief credible has collapsed, and the values that leaned on it are now unsupported.

Technical definition. "God is dead" diagnoses the collapse of the **Christian-metaphysical horizon** and the resulting danger of **nihilism**; genealogy exposes ascetic and slave-moral valuations; the response demanded is **revaluation of all values** and self-creation (the *Übermensch*).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Nietzsche is not an argument for atheism but a diagnosis of what happens after theism: he describes a culture whose values were underwritten by a framework it no longer believes, and demands that the values be remade rather than inherited.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

"God is dead" · Christian-metaphysical horizon · nihilism · genealogy · resentment (ressentiment) · slave morality · revaluation of all values · *Übermensch* · post-theism

How to use them: state the four-step argument, then the ownership routing. An answer that reproduces the full genealogical dossier in *this* clause has answered the neighbouring clause's question.

VISUAL - THE FOUR-STEP ARGUMENT, AND THE OWNERSHIP GATE

THE ARGUMENT IN FOUR STEPS

- 1 modern truthfulness and science ERODE traditional belief
- 2 inherited values DEPENDED on that framework
- 3 their collapse creates NIHILISM
- 4 overcoming it requires REVALUATION and self-creation



THE PRESUPPOSITION: values have GENEALOGIES tied to forms of life, and can be assessed as life-enhancing or life-denying.

THE CANONICAL EXAMPLE: ressentiment reverses aristocratic value terms and converts weakness into moral superiority.

THE DISTINCTION THAT MUST BE MADE: the phrase is a CULTURAL DIAGNOSIS, not a syllogism proving that God does not exist.

OBJECTION -> REPLY: revaluation risks elitism and arbitrary power.

=> the Nietzschean reply appeals to creative self-overcoming, though a universal normative standard remains difficult.

THE OWNERSHIP GATE

The printed 2025 question - "Present an account of Nietzsche's criticism of religion and morality" - couples religion WITH morality and is owned by the RELIGION AND MORALITY clause. The full genealogical dossier (slave revolt, ascetic ideal, Beyond Good and Evil, the criticisms and the Indian comparison) lives there.

THIS clause retains Nietzsche as: (a) a critique of THEISTIC religion, and (b) the BRIDGE to post-theistic value - what value-creation looks like once the theistic horizon is withdrawn.

ANALYSIS: AND THE COMPARATIVE POINT THAT EARNS THE MARK: that is precisely how post-theism DIFFERS from Buddhist and Jain non-theism, which never had the horizon Nietzsche is mourning.

Read the numbered steps as the argument, the middle block as the evaluation, and the framed gate as the routing rule that keeps this answer inside its own clause.

TEACHING

[FACT] The doctrine. "God is dead" diagnoses the collapse of the Christian-metaphysical horizon and the resulting danger of nihilism; genealogy exposes ascetic and slave-moral valuations. His critique targets **religion and its morality together**, which is exactly why the printed 2025 stem belongs to the neighbouring owner.

[FACT] The argument. Four steps: modern truthfulness and science erode traditional belief; inherited values depended on that framework; their collapse creates nihilism; overcoming requires revaluation and self-creation. Written as four steps it is an argument; written as a slogan it is decoration.

[FACT] The distinction that must be made. The phrase is a **cultural diagnosis**, not a simple syllogistic proof that God does not exist. Presenting it as an empirical event, or as a bare atheist slogan, is a listed trap and is the single commonest error in Nietzsche paragraphs.

[FACT] The canonical example. *Ressentiment* reverses aristocratic value terms and converts weakness into moral superiority. One worked example of the genealogical method is worth more than a list of Nietzschean vocabulary.

[FACT] Objection and reply. Revaluation risks elitism and arbitrary power. The Nietzschean reply appeals to creative self-overcoming, though a universal normative standard remains difficult. State the difficulty; do not resolve it by assertion.

[INFERENCE] The comparative payoff for this clause. Nietzsche is mourning a horizon that Buddhism and Jainism never possessed. Post-theism is a condition of loss; non-theism is a structure that was never built around what is lost. Keeping the two in separate paragraphs is what prevents an answer from treating "religion without God" as a modern Western predicament.

Objection. If values are genealogically conditioned, Nietzsche's own valuation of life-enhancement is equally conditioned, and the critique undercuts itself. **Reply.** **[INFERENCE]** The Nietzschean answer is that he does not claim a view from nowhere: the revaluation is offered as an act of creation whose warrant is its capacity to affirm life, not its derivation from an external standard. The self-reference is acknowledged rather than escaped, and whether that is a defence or a concession is exactly the contested point.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Nietzsche belongs in this clause as the bridge to post-theistic value, not as an argument against God's existence. **Named evidence:** *The Gay Science*, section 125, presents the declaration through the madman; the genealogical method exposes *ressentiment* as a reversal of aristocratic valuation; the demand that follows is a revaluation of all values. **Analysis:** The claim is therefore about the credibility and consequences of a framework, so it establishes a cultural predicament rather than a metaphysical conclusion. **Qualification:** That predicament is specific to a culture that once possessed the theistic horizon, which is why Buddhist and Jain non-theism cannot be assimilated to it and must be argued separately.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not present "God is dead" as an empirical event or a bare atheist slogan. It is a cultural diagnosis with a four-step argument behind it.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not import the full genealogical dossier here. The printed stem coupling religion with morality is owned by the Religion and Morality clause.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not use Nietzsche as the general spokesman for religion without God. Post-theism and non-theism are different conditions.

MINI RECAP

Four steps, one presupposition, one worked example. One distinction - diagnosis, not proof. One gate - the coupled stem belongs to the neighbouring owner. One comparison - a horizon lost is not a horizon never had.

SESSION 15 - AGNOSTICISM: HUXLEY, THE TWO STRENGTHS, AND THE PRINTED DOUBLE DELIVERABLE

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Agnosticism is not a weak atheism. It is a claim about what can be known, and it leaves a surprising amount of religious life available.

Technical definition. Agnosticism is the claim that the existence of God is **unknown or unknowable**, so judgement should be suspended. **Weak agnosticism** says the matter is *not known*; **strong agnosticism** says it is *unknowable*. It is distinct from atheism, which *denies* God.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

For the agnostic, religion and God come apart: the ethical and experiential dimensions of religious life can be affirmed while assent on the existence of God is withheld, which supports a minimal or non-theistic religiosity rather than a rejection of religion.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

agnosticism · T. H. Huxley (1869) · weak agnosticism · strong agnosticism · suspension of judgement · practical faith · the Unknowable · graded religiosity

How to use them: the printed 2023 stem has **two** deliverables - *what is agnosticism* and *how do agnostics conceptualise the relation between religion and God*. Answer both, in that order, and signpost the transition.

VISUAL - THE DEFINITION, THE SUBDIVISION, AND THE RELATION

PART ONE - WHAT AGNOSTICISM IS

the existence of God is UNKNOWN or UNKNOWABLE => suspend judgement
distinct from ATHEISM, which DENIES.

WEAK AGNOSTICISM	STRONG AGNOSTICISM
"not known"	"unknowable"
contingent: evidence may underdetermine the question	principled: the question exceeds the reach of human knowledge
=> open to future evidence	=> closed in principle

COINAGE: "agnostic" was coined by T. H. HUXLEY in 1869.

ADJACENT POSITIONS: Kant's practical faith; Spencer's "Unknowable".

PART TWO - HOW AGNOSTICS RELATE RELIGION AND GOD

the two are SEPARABLE. An agnostic may:	
• affirm religion's ETHICAL dimension	(conduct, compassion)
• affirm its EXPERIENTIAL dimension	(contemplation, awe)
• affirm its COMMUNAL and RITUAL dimensions	(belonging, practice)
• withhold assent on the EXISTENCE of God	
=> this supports a NON-THEISTIC or MINIMAL religiosity	
THE PRESUPPOSITION, stated honestly: religious commitment can be	
GRADED and need not include metaphysical certainty.	
CANONICAL CASE: a person may participate in Buddhist ethical and	
meditative practice while withholding creator claims.	

OBJECTION -> REPLY

O: this reduces religion to ethics or aesthetics.

R: community, ritual, transformation and orientation to ultimacy exceed
ordinary morality - the reduction charge under-describes what remains.

Read Part One for the first printed deliverable and Part Two for the second. Both boxes must appear in a 10-mark answer on the 2023 stem.

TEACHING

[FACT] The definition and the coinage. Agnosticism is the claim that the existence of God is unknown or unknowable, so judgement should be suspended. The word was coined by **T. H. Huxley in 1869**. It is distinct from atheism, which denies God's existence.

[FACT] The subdivision. Weak agnosticism ("not known") differs from strong agnosticism ("unknowable"). The difference is not verbal: the weak form is hostage to future evidence, the strong form is a claim about the limits of human knowledge and is therefore itself a substantial epistemological thesis needing defence.

[FACT] The relation between religion and God. An agnostic may still value religion's ethical and experiential dimensions while withholding assent on God - supporting a non-theistic or minimal religiosity. The **presupposition** must be stated: religious commitment can be **graded** and need not include metaphysical certainty.

[FACT] Adjacent positions. Kant's practical faith and Spencer's "Unknowable" are agnostic-adjacent. Naming them shows that suspension of theoretical judgement has a philosophical pedigree and is not merely indecision.

[FACT] The canonical example. A person may participate in Buddhist ethical and meditative practice while withholding creator claims. This example does double duty: it illustrates graded religiosity and it links the modern Western position back to the Indian material that carries the weight of this clause.

[FACT] Objection and reply. The objection is that this reduces religion to ethics or aesthetics. The reply is that community, ritual, transformation and orientation to ultimacy exceed ordinary morality.

Objection. Strong agnosticism is self-undermining: to know that something is unknowable is already to know a great deal about it. **Reply. [INFERENCE]** The strong agnostic replies that the claim is about the *reach of our faculties*, not about the object - an argument of the same family as Kant's restriction of theoretical knowledge to possible experience. That reply is available, but it converts strong agnosticism into a positive epistemology that must then be defended, which is why the weak form is the safer one to attribute in an answer unless the stem asks otherwise.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Agnosticism separates the question of God from the practice of religion instead of abolishing both. **Named evidence:** T. H. Huxley coined the term in 1869 for the view that God's existence is unknown or unknowable; the weak form claims only that it is not known while the strong form claims that it is unknowable; Kant's practical faith and Spencer's Unknowable are adjacent positions. **Analysis:** Because the suspension is epistemic, the ethical, experiential, ritual and communal dimensions of religion remain available, which is why agnosticism supports a minimal or non-theistic religiosity rather than a rejection of religion. **Qualification:** The reduction objection - that what survives is ethics or aesthetics - is met by pointing to community, ritual, transformation and orientation to ultimacy, though the resulting religiosity is admittedly thinner than a fully theistic one.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Distinguish agnosticism from atheism and from indifference. Suspension, denial and absence of the question are three different things.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not answer only the first half of the 2023 stem. The relation between religion and God is a separate printed deliverable.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute strong agnosticism where weak agnosticism will do. The strong form is a substantial epistemological claim that needs its own defence.

MINI RECAP

One definition, one coinage (1869), two strengths. Two deliverables in the printed stem. One presupposition - commitment can be graded. One canonical case - practice without creator claims.

SESSION 16 - RELIGIOUS NATURALISM: FROM DEWEY'S "THE RELIGIOUS" TO DWORKIN'S RELIGIOUS ATHEISM

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Religious naturalists say that awe, reverence, ultimacy and commitment can be directed at nature and at value, without a supernatural person anywhere in the account.

Technical definition. Thesis: ultimacy, reverence and the religious response are located **within nature**; there is no supernatural person, but nature itself sustains genuinely religious attitudes of awe, gratitude, humility and commitment.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Religious naturalism asks the sharper modern form of the question: not whether a classical tradition can do without a creator, but whether someone who accepts a fully naturalistic ontology can still be religious - and it answers by relocating ultimacy rather than abolishing it.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

religious naturalism · "religion" versus "the religious" · ideal ends · the ideal-actual relation · religious atheism · objective intrinsic meaning · the sublime universe · value realism

How to use them: attach each thesis to its named work and year. This is the part of the clause where undated name-dropping is most tempting and most visible.

VISUAL - THE NATURALIST BENCH

Thinker	Named work	The thesis in one line
John Dewey	<i>A Common Faith</i> , 1934	distinguishes "religion" (an institution with supernatural claims) from " the religious " (a quality of experience that unifies the self and orients it to inclusive ideal ends); proposes using "God" for the active relation between the ideal and the actual - not a being
Ronald Dworkin	<i>Religion without God</i> , 2013	" religious atheism ": one may reject a personal God while holding that human life has objective intrinsic meaning and that the universe is sublime and intrinsically beautiful - value realism, not theism, is the core
Ursula Goodenough	<i>The Sacred Depths of Nature</i> , 1998	the religious response to the depth of the natural world
Julian Huxley	evolutionary humanism	religious attitude within an evolutionary naturalist frame
Donald Crosby; Loyal Rue	their work on nature as ground	nature as the ground of ultimacy
Spinoza	<i>Deus sive Natura</i>	the historical ancestor of the whole family

THE OBJECTION EVERY EXAMINER EXPECTS

O: this is ethics and aesthetics wearing religious vocabulary; nothing is worshipped, nothing saves.

R: ultimacy, reverence, communal practice and self-transformation are all present; and demanding a supernatural PERSON simply restates the theistic definition that was under test in the first place.

ANALYSIS: THE HONEST CONCESSION: this answer is strongest where actual practices and communities accompany the philosophy. Otherwise "religious" survives chiefly as an ADJECTIVE for a quality of experience.

ANALYSIS: BOUNDED MODERN CAUTION: civil religion and secular spirituality may show ritual, sacred symbols, community and ultimate concern - but WITHOUT a transformative/soteriological discipline the category becomes too broad. They are useful boundary tests, not additional syllabus owners, and never substitutes for the Indian cases.

Read the table for the six named positions and the box for the objection, the reply and the two cautions that keep the section proportionate.

TEACHING

[FACT] Why the module exists. Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā show religion without God in **classical** forms. The modern Western debate asks a sharper question: can someone who accepts a **naturalistic ontology** nonetheless be religious? Religious naturalism answers yes by locating ultimacy within nature.

[FACT] Dewey. *A Common Faith* (1934) distinguishes "religion" - an institution with supernatural claims - from "the religious", a *quality of experience* that unifies the self and orients it to inclusive ideal ends. Dewey proposes using the word "God" to denote the **active relation between the ideal and the actual**, and explicitly not a being.

[FACT] Dworkin. *Religion without God* (2013) - the book that literally names this clause - argues for "**religious atheism**": one can reject a personal God while holding that (i) human life has **objective intrinsic** meaning and (ii) the universe is **sublime and intrinsically beautiful**, and that these two value-commitments are what is *religious* about religion. Dworkin's move is to make **value realism**, not theism, the core.

[FACT] The wider family. Julian Huxley's evolutionary humanism; Ursula Goodenough's *The Sacred Depths of Nature* (1998) on the religious response to the natural world's depth; Donald Crosby and Loyal Rue on nature as the ground of ultimacy; Spinoza as the historical ancestor via *Deus sive Natura*.

[FACT] Objection and reply. The objection is that this is aesthetics and ethics wearing religious vocabulary - nothing is worshipped, nothing saves. The naturalist replies that ultimacy, reverence, communal practice and self-transformation are all present, and that demanding a supernatural person simply restates the theistic definition.

[INFERENCE] The honest concession. Religion has never been exhausted by petition to a supernatural person, and orientation to ultimacy, ritualised attention, community and self-transformation can be religious even when their object is immanent. But this answer is strongest where actual practices and communities accompany the philosophy; otherwise "religious" survives chiefly as an adjective for a quality of experience.

ANALYSIS: Bounded modern caution. Civil religion and secular spirituality may display ritual, sacred symbols, community and ultimate concern, but without a transformative or soteriological discipline the category becomes too broad. They are useful boundary tests, not additional syllabus owners or substitutes for the Indian cases.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Religious naturalism relocates ultimacy within nature rather than abandoning it. **Named evidence:** Dewey's *A Common Faith* (1934) separates "religion" from "the religious" and redefines "God" as the active relation between the ideal and the actual; Dworkin's *Religion without God* (2013) defends religious atheism on objective life-meaning and cosmic sublimity; Goodenough's *The Sacred Depths of Nature* (1998) develops the religious response to natural depth. **Analysis:** Each therefore preserves reverence, ultimacy and orientation while removing supernatural ontology, which shows that the religious functions are detachable from theism rather than parasitic on it. **Qualification:** The position is thinner than the classical Indian cases, because it must reconstruct ultimacy after inherited metaphysics has weakened, and it is strongest where a real community and practice accompany the philosophy.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not merge religious naturalism with fictionalism. The naturalist **asserts** her claims about ultimacy within nature; the fictionalist declines to assert.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not let "spiritual but not religious" discourse crowd out Buddhism, Jainism and the Indian anti-creator arguments. The classical cases carry the clause.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not cite Dewey, Dworkin or Goodenough without their works. This is the part of the answer where an invented attribution is most visible.

MINI RECAP

One thesis - ultimacy inside nature. Two anchors - Dewey 1934, Dworkin 2013. One objection, one reply, one honest concession. And one caution: boundary tests are not owners.

SESSION 17 - RELIGIOUS FICTIONALISM AND NON-REALISM, AND THE INDIAN GRADED-TRUTH CONTROL

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Fictionalists keep going to the temple or church without asserting that the claims are true - they participate in the practice as one enters a story, seriously but without belief.

Technical definition. Thesis: religious sentences are (or may be) **literally false or unwarranted**, yet participation in religious practice - taking the claims in a *fictional*, non-assertoric spirit - is rationally permissible and even valuable.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Fictionalism is defined not by a verdict on truth but by a refusal to assert: it grants that religious claims have truth-conditions, declines to affirm them, and continues in the practice - which is why it is distinct from error theory, from non-cognitivism, and from Advaita's graded truth.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

religious fictionalism · non-realism · "Sea of Faith" · error theory · non-cognitivism · assertion · everyday level (vyāvahārika) · ultimate level (pāramārthika) · sublation · two truths (saṃvṛti/paramārtha)

How to use them: the discriminations are the marks. Write the three-way distinction (fictionalism / error theory / non-cognitivism) and then the Indian control, and the paragraph is complete.

VISUAL - THREE POSITIONS, AND THE INDIAN CONTROL

THREE MODERN POSITIONS - the dividing line is ASSERTION

ERROR THEORY	NON-COGNITIVISM	FICTIONALISM
the claims are	the claims never	the claims DO have truth-
FALSE	had truth-	conditions - and are simply
=> STOP	conditions	NOT ASSERTED
	=> they never	=> ACCEPTED WITHIN the practice
	asserted	

NAMED POSITIONS: Don Cupitt, *Taking Leave of God* (1980) - non-realism; God as the personification of the religious ideal; "Sea of Faith" theology. Robin Le Poidevin, *Arguing for Atheism* (1996) - explicit religious fictionalism. Andrew Eshleman on the fictionalist's participation. Howard Wettstein on the significance of religious experience without metaphysical commitment.

THREE OBJECTIONS -> THREE REPLIES

- (i) INSINCERITY / SELF-DECEPTION: worship presupposes belief; make-believe worship is either dishonest or hollow.
R: immersion in a fiction is a familiar, non-deceptive human capacity - literature, ritual drama.
- (ii) MOTIVATIONAL: the practice's power derives from believing it true; remove that and it hollows out.
R: fictionalists appeal to the sustained efficacy of narrative and ritual - an empirical claim that remains CONTESTED.
- (iii) INTERNAL: believers themselves reject the description, so the account is REVISIONARY of the very thing it purports to save.

===== THE INDIAN COMPARISON - DO NOT OMIT =====

ADVAITA already contains a TWO-LEVEL apparatus doing structurally similar work WITHOUT fictionalism: worship of the qualified absolute (*saguna*) is genuinely efficacious at the everyday level (*vyāvahārika*) and is **SUBLATED**, not exposed as fiction, at the ultimate level (*pāramārthika*).
=> **SUBLATION IS NOT FALSIFICATION**.
BUDDHISM's TWO TRUTHS (*saṃvṛti* / *paramārtha*) permit full participation in conventional religious practice while denying ultimate substantial reference.
ANALYSIS: THE COMPARATIVE POINT THAT EARNS MARKS: Indian systems offer GRADED TRUTH where Western fictionalism offers PRETENCE - the Indian device preserves the practitioner's SINCERITY in a way fictionalism struggles to.

Read the three-column box for the discriminations, the middle block for the objections, and the framed Indian comparison for the paragraph that lifts the answer.

TEACHING

[FACT] The thesis. Religious sentences are, or may be, literally false or unwarranted, yet participation in religious practice - taking the claims in a fictive, non-assertoric spirit - is rationally permissible and even valuable.

[FACT] The named positions. Don Cupitt's non-realism in *Taking Leave of God* (1980) treats God not as an objective being but as the personification of the religious ideal - a "Sea of Faith" theology. Robin Le Poidevin's *Arguing for Atheism* (1996) develops explicit religious fictionalism. Andrew Eshleman writes on the fictionalist's participation, and Howard Wettstein on the significance of religious experience without metaphysical commitment.

[FACT] The distinctions that matter. Fictionalism is **not error theory**: the error theorist says the claims are false and we should stop, while the fictionalist says they are not to be *asserted* but can be *accepted* within the practice. Fictionalism is **not non-cognitivism**: the non-cognitivist says religious sentences never had truth-conditions, while the fictionalist grants that they do and declines to assert them.

[FACT] Objections and replies. Three objections - insincerity, motivation and the internal objection - with the replies set out in the visual. The motivational reply rests on an empirical claim about the sustained efficacy of narrative and ritual that remains contested, and saying so is more honest than asserting it.

[FACT] The Indian comparison, which must not be omitted. Advaita already contains a two-level apparatus doing structurally similar work without fictionalism: worship of the qualified absolute is genuinely efficacious at the everyday level and is **sublated**, not exposed as fiction, at the ultimate level - and **sublation is not falsification**. Buddhism's two truths permit full participation in conventional religious practice while denying ultimate substantial reference.

[INFERENCE] The verdict formula. Naturalism and fictionalism both show that the *functions* of religion - reverence, community, ritual, orientation to ultimacy, self-transformation - are detachable from theistic belief. Whether what

survives is still *religion* depends on the definition adopted at the start, which is why this clause always returns to the substantive-versus-functional question.

Objection. If sublation is not falsification, then Advaita is simply a two-tier realism, and comparing it with fictionalism is a category mistake that flatters the Indian material. **Reply. [INFERENCE]** The comparison is not an identification. What is being compared is the *problem* both address - how to participate wholeheartedly in a practice whose object one does not affirm at the highest level of analysis - and the observation is that the Indian device solves the sincerity problem while the Western one inherits it. That is a comparison of adequacy, and it is precisely the kind of controlled comparison this clause rewards.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Fictionalism is a distinct position defined by the refusal to assert, not by a verdict on truth or meaning. **Named evidence:** Cupitt's *Taking Leave of God* (1980) treats God as the personification of the religious ideal; Le Poidevin's *Arguing for Atheism* (1996) develops explicit religious fictionalism; the error theorist by contrast abandons the discourse and the non-cognitivist denies it ever had truth-conditions. **Analysis:** The sincerity objection therefore bites hardest here, because the fictionalist participates in acts - prayer above all - whose intelligibility seems to presuppose the belief she withholds. **Qualification:** Advaita's everyday level is not fictionalism, since sublation is not falsification, and the comparative point is that Indian systems offer graded truth where Western fictionalism offers pretence.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not merge religious naturalism, fictionalism and error theory. Assertion, abandonment and meaning are three different dividing lines.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not present Advaita's everyday level as fictionalism. Sublation is not falsification, and the two-level device preserves sincerity.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not assert that fictionalist practice sustains motivation. The claim is empirical and contested; say so.

MINI RECAP

Three positions, one dividing line - assertion. Two dated anchors - Cupitt 1980, Le Poidevin 1996. Three objections, three replies. One comparison - graded truth against pretence.

SESSION 18 - THE THEIST'S DENIAL, THE PARITY BENCH, AND THE GRADED VERDICT

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. This session builds the opposing case properly, sets all the routes side by side, and then teaches the exact shape of a 10-, 15- and 20-mark answer.

Technical definition. The 2019 stem asks the candidate to **argue the theist's case first** and only then assess it. The theist's denial has five arguments - definitional, devotional, moral, cosmic-order and soteriological - and the rebuttal, the comparison bench, the directive decoder and the verdict ladder complete the clause.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Religion without God is not merely conceivable but actual: Mīmāṃsā secures authority, efficacy and desert without a deity, and Buddhism supplies a complete diagnosis-and-path structure; what is *not* possible is religion without a sacred order - which is why Cārvāka ends in no religion at all.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

category mistake · worship requires a recipient · divine command · grace requires a giver · superintendent of karma (karmādhyaṅṣa) · question-begging · graded verdict · defeater

How to use them: on the 2019 stem, half the marks are in constructing the theist's argument properly. Do not begin rebutting in paragraph two.

VISUAL - THE THEIST'S FIVE ARGUMENTS, AND THE FIVE REBUTTALS

THE THEIST'S DENIAL

```

[-----]
| 1 DEFINITIONAL: religion IS |
| relation to a personal |
| transcendent => "religion without |
| God" is a CATEGORY ERROR |
+-----+
| 2 DEVOTIONAL: worship requires a |
| recipient; Jain vītarāga worship |
| is "really commemoration" |
+-----+
| 3 MORAL: obligation requires a |
| COMMANDER (divine command) |
+-----+
| 4 COSMIC ORDER: purposive order |
| and karmic allotment require |
| intelligence (Nyāya's Īśvara as |
| karmādhyaṅga) |
+-----+
| 5 SOTERIOLOGICAL: grace/salvation |
| require an AGENT who can give |
+-----+
  
```

THE REBUTTAL

```

[-----]
| ----> | Smart's dimensions; definition |
| by stipulation is question- |
| begging |
+-----+
| ----> | Jain siddha as an ACHIEVED, not |
| a governing, divinity; vows, |
| ritual, asceticism, soteriology |
+-----+
| ----> | compassion, non-injury, karma, |
| vows, insight, flourishing |
+-----+
| ----> | MĪMĀṂSĀ: apauruṣeya Veda + |
| apūrva secure authority, |
| efficacy AND desert; law-like ≠ |
| deliberative |
+-----+
| ----> | Buddhism's complete diagnosis- |
| and-path structure |
+-----+
  
```

ANALYSIS: THE ASSESSMENT THAT EARNS THE MARK: the theist's strongest surviving point is (2) WORSHIP/GRACE, not (1) the definition. Petition and grace genuinely require a responsive God, and non-theistic religions do without them AT A REAL COST IN DEVOTIONAL STRUCTURE.

CONCLUSION: religion without God is possible; religion without a SACRED ORDER is not.

VISUAL - THE SIX ROUTES: WHAT IS REMOVED, WHAT REPLACES IT

Route	What is removed	What replaces it	Still a religion?	Live PYQ use
Buddhism	creator and permanent self	dependent origination, <i>Dharma, Saṅgha, nirvāṇa</i>	Yes, fully	2024 Q7(a)
Jainism	creator only	karmic matter, vows, the perfected <i>siddha</i>	Yes, fully	2018 Q5(c)
Mīmāṃsā	author of the Veda and dispenser of fruit	authorless (<i>apauruṣeya</i>) authority + unseen potency (<i>apūrva</i>)	Strong case under ritual/functional definitions	2020 Q6(c)
Sāṃkhya / Yoga	creator (Yoga keeps a non-creating <i>Īśvara</i>)	nature's evolution; discriminative knowledge; <i>kaivalya</i>	Yes	2021 Q5(d)
Modern naturalism / fictionalism	supernatural ontology, or assertion itself	nature as locus of ultimacy; practice without assertion	Only on a functional definition	2018 Q5(c)
Cārvāka	the whole supersensible order	nothing - own-nature and this-worldly ends	No - the limiting case	2025 Q5(a)

VISUAL - THE NINE-ROW INTER-SCHOOL BENCH

View	Creator God	Ultimate / goal	Moral-causal order	Why religious?
Buddhism	not required	<i>nirvāṇa</i>	karma / dependent origination	path, <i>Śaṅgha</i> , liberation
Jainism	rejected	liberated soul / <i>siddha</i>	karmic matter	vows, asceticism, liberation
Mīmāṃsā	unnecessary	dharma; heaven in classical ritual theory	unseen potency (<i>apūrva</i>)	Vedic injunction and ritual
Sāṃkhya	unnecessary	<i>kaivalya</i>	nature-self process	discriminative liberation
Nietzsche	cultural belief overcome	self-overcoming	genealogical value creation	CAUTION: critique / post-religious spirituality
Humanism	absent	human flourishing	autonomous ethics	ANALYSIS: religious only under a broad function
Cārvāka	rejected - and so is every supersensible entity	pleasure and wealth in this life	WRONG: none; own-nature replaces it	WRONG: not a religion - the limiting case
Religious naturalism	absent	ideal ends within nature (Dewey); sublime value (Dworkin)	immanent value-realism	ANALYSIS: reverence, community, ultimacy - nothing supernatural
Religious fictionalism	not asserted	whatever the practice delivers	practice-internal	ANALYSIS: participation without assertion

VISUAL - THE DIRECTIVE DECODER, KEYED TO THE SEVEN PRINTED STEMS

Directive	What the examiner is buying	Structural consequence	Live stem
Can you justify X? Support your answer	a defended affirmative or negative, with the criterion stated	announce the definition of religion first ; the whole answer follows from it	2018 Q5(c)
How would [an opponent] deny...? Discuss	the opponent's case, argued sympathetically, then assessed	half the marks are in constructing the theist's argument properly	2019 Q6(c)
Critically examine X as a prerequisite for Y	a test of a necessity claim	find one clear counterexample and defend it against reinterpretation	2020 Q6(c)
Is X possible? Discuss	a possibility claim, established by an actual case	one case done in depth beats four mentioned	2021 Q5(d)
What is X? How do X-ists conceptualise...?	a definition plus a positional account	define, sub-divide (weak/strong), then give the position	2023 Q5(e)
State and evaluate X as a religion without God	both halves: the <i>statement</i> and the <i>evaluation</i>	state the doctrine fully before assessing; do not evaluate a caricature	2024 Q7(a)
Discuss X's critique of belief in Y	the argument of the critique, not its conclusions	give the epistemology (concomitance), not the slogans	2025 Q5(a)

MEMORY: **Rule:** every question in this clause is decided by the **definition of religion** you adopt in the first three lines. State it, defend it briefly, then apply it consistently - inconsistency here is the commonest cause of a mediocre mark.

VISUAL - THE GRADED VERDICT LADDER

Band	What the script contains	Typical fault
Weak (≈40%)	"Buddhism has no God but is a religion"	no definition of religion; "atheistic" used loosely
Average (≈50%)	functional definition; Buddhism and Jainism outlined	theist's counter-case not constructed; Mīmāṃsā missing
Good (≈60%)	definition defended; one case in depth; one objection answered	over-broad functionalism not policed; devotional Mahāyāna ignored
Strong (≈65-70%)	substantive/functional dispute explicit; two Indian cases; the worship/grace objection met	modern naturalism/fictionalism absent; Cārvāka misclassified
Top (≈70%+)	all the above + a discriminating distinction (non-theistic ≠ atheistic; authorless ≠ revelation; sublation ≠ fictionalism; Cārvāka as limiting case) + the concession that petition and grace genuinely require a responsive God	-

TEACHING - ANSWER ARCHITECTURE AND QUOTATION DISCIPLINE

[FACT] The three architectures.

- 10 MARKS define non-theism/agnosticism -> doctrine in four steps -> distinguish the nearest confusion -> one objection -> verdict on whether God is necessary
- 15 MARKS substantive vs functional frame -> one Indian case in depth -> canonical example -> theistic objection and reply -> comparison with another school
- 20 MARKS define criteria of religion -> full Buddhist/Jain/Mīmāṃsā case -> creator critique -> devotional complication -> Western post-theistic comparison -> graded conclusion avoiding an over-broad definition

[FACT] The four standing criticisms, with their replies.

- Definition objection** - religion necessarily means relation to God. *Reply*: this is tradition-specific and cannot accommodate established non-theistic religions.
- Hidden-God objection** - *Dharma*, *nirvāṇa* or humanity merely substitutes for God. *Reply*: functional similarity does not establish ontological identity.
- Motivation objection** - without divine reward, religious discipline weakens. *Reply*: compassion, insight, karma and communal vows supply non-theistic motivation.
- Nihilism objection** - removing God removes objective value. *Reply*: Buddhist ethics, Jain vows and humanist normativity show alternative grounds, though their objectivity still requires argument.

[FACT] Quotation and factual discipline.

Item	Status	Safe use
"God is dead... we have killed him"	FACT: Nietzsche, <i>The Gay Science</i> Section 125 (the madman); also Section 108 and Section 343	cultural diagnosis, not an argument for atheism; full dossier in Religion and Morality
"Opium of the people"	FACT: Marx, Introduction to <i>A Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right</i> (1843-44)	quote the fuller sentence if you use it - it is more sympathetic than the slogan
"Theology is anthropology"	FACT: standard summary of Feuerbach, <i>The Essence of Christianity</i>	the projection thesis
"Agnostic"	FACT: coined by T. H. Huxley (1869)	distinguish weak ("not known") from strong ("unknowable")
Smart's dimensions	FACT: Ninian Smart's multidimensional analysis	doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social, material
<i>Brahmajāla</i> / <i>Aggañña</i> Suttas	FACT: DN 1 / DN 27	for the Buddhist non-creator position
Cārvāka verses attributed to Bṛhaspati	CAUTION: preserved only in opponents' works, chiefly Mādhava's <i>Sarvadarśanasamgraha</i>	report as doxographic; never as primary text
"Yāvaj jīvet sukhaṃ jīvet..."	CAUTION: popular verse quoted in doxographies	do not build the answer on it - the exam wants the epistemology
Purandara's acceptance of ordinary inference	CAUTION: fragmentary, reported by opponents	present as a reported strand, clearly flagged
Jaimini, <i>Mīmāṃsā-sūtra</i> 1.1.2	FACT: verified sūtra	the definition of dharma by injunction
Kumāṛila's <i>Ślokavārttika</i> against a creator	FACT:	same argument-family as the Jain motive/bodiless-agent arguments
<i>A Common Faith</i>	FACT: John Dewey (1934)	"religion" vs "the religious"; God as the ideal-actual relation
<i>Religion without God</i>	FACT: Ronald Dworkin (2013)	"religious atheism": objective life-meaning + the sublimity of the universe
<i>Taking Leave of God</i>	FACT: Don Cupitt (1980)	non-realism, "Sea of Faith"
<i>Arguing for Atheism</i>	FACT: Robin Le Poidevin (1996)	religious fictionalism
<i>The Sacred Depths of Nature</i>	FACT: Ursula Goodenough (1998)	religious naturalism

[FACT] The three graded-verdict templates.

- *Possibility stem*: "Religion without God is not merely conceivable but actual: Mīmāṃsā secures authority, efficacy and desert without a deity, and Buddhism supplies a complete diagnosis-and-path structure. What is *not* possible is religion without a **sacred order** - which is why Cārvāka ends in no religion at all."
- *Prerequisite stem*: "God is a prerequisite for *some* religious goods - petition, grace, covenant - but not for religion as such. The theist's strongest argument is therefore devotional, not definitional, and it should be met on that ground rather than dismissed."
- *Definition stem*: "A definition narrow enough to exclude Buddhism is question-begging; a definition broad enough to include nationalism is empty. The workable middle requires a disciplined relation to an **ultimate/sacred order** together with a **soteriological practice**."

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: A religious person can coherently deny the possibility of religion without God only by defending a specifically theistic essence of religion. **Named evidence:** The denial rests on five arguments - the definitional category error, worship requiring a recipient, obligation requiring a commander, purposive order and karmic allotment requiring Nyāya's superintendent (*karmādhyaṣa*), and salvation requiring a giver of grace. **Analysis:** Mīmāṃsā answers the fourth directly through authorless scripture and unseen potency, Buddhism answers the fifth through a complete diagnosis-and-path structure, and the first is question-begging; so the denial survives only in its devotional form. **Qualification:** That surviving form is genuine - petition and grace do require a responsive God - so the correct verdict concedes a real cost in devotional structure while denying the necessity claim.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: On the 2019 stem, do not skip the construction of the theist's case. Half the marks are there, and a caricature costs the whole evaluation.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not end with an over-broad functional definition. Police it in the conclusion, or the examiner will.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not invent years for Smart, Feuerbach, Freud, Comte, Crosby, Rue, Eshleman or Wettstein. Cite them by work.

MINI RECAP

Five theist arguments, five rebuttals, one surviving point - worship and grace. Six routes on the bench, nine rows on the school grid, seven printed stems on the decoder, five bands on the ladder. And one closing formula: religion without God is possible; religion without a sacred order is not.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed **independently for each question** by a randomised, length-balanced assignment: there is no rotation, no repeating cycle and no adjacent repetition to exploit, and each of the four positions carries exactly eight answers across the thirty-two diagnostics. Every option carries a question-specific explanation, and every question carries a unique examiner trap.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 24

MCQ 1. The definition that decides the whole clause

Which kind of definition of religion, once adopted in an answer's opening lines, by itself settles whether religion without God is possible?

- A. A family-resemblance definition, which needs one feature that every member of the religious family must possess before it can classify at all.
- B. A substantive definition, which fixes religion by the kind of object affirmed and can therefore build a personal creator into the concept itself.
- C. A multidimensional definition, on which Smart's doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social and material dimensions are jointly compulsory.
- D. A functional definition, which fixes religion by orientation, practice, community and liberation and therefore rules non-theistic traditions out.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: a family-resemblance account expressly denies that any single feature must be shared by every member, which is precisely why it cannot make belief in a creator necessary.
- **B:** Correct: substantive definitions identify religion by its object, so a God- centred version makes theism analytically necessary and decides the clause by stipulation rather than by evidence drawn from actual traditions.
- **C:** Incorrect: Smart's dimensions are the standard argument against creator- necessity, and belief in a creator God does not appear on his essential list at all, so this reverses the point of citing him.

- **D:** Incorrect: functional definitions do the opposite work, since orientation, practice, community and liberation are all available to Buddhism, Jainism and classical Mimamsa without any creator.

Examiner trap 1: Scripts that never state which definition of religion they are using lose the clause in the first paragraph; announce the definition, defend it in one line, then apply it consistently to every case you cite.

MCQ 2. Repairing an over-broad functionalism

A functional definition is challenged on the ground that it makes nationalism a religion. Which repair keeps the Indian non-theistic cases in and ideology out?

- A. Add a disciplined, socially embodied relation to an ultimate or sacred order together with a transformative or soteriological practice.
- B. Add that any commitment demanding sacrifice, generating solidarity and organising collective observance already counts as religious.
- C. Add a historical restriction confining religion to traditions founded before the modern period and possessing continuous institutional life.
- D. Add a requirement of belief in miracles or supernatural intervention, while leaving the question of a personal creator open for each tradition.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: this is the owner's working sufficient cluster; the non-theistic traditions all possess a sacred order and a liberation-directed discipline, while commitments that merely supply meaning and belonging do not.
- **B:** Incorrect: this widens the definition further rather than narrowing it, because sacrifice, solidarity and a calendar of collective observance are exactly what nationalism already supplies.
- **C:** Incorrect: an age test tracks nothing conceptual, would admit ancient non-religious ideologies and would arbitrarily expel later religious movements that meet every substantive criterion.
- **D:** Incorrect: a miracle test is both too narrow, since Mimamsa's ritual efficacy is law-like rather than miraculous, and simply irrelevant to the over-breadth complaint that has been raised.

Examiner trap 2: Do not answer the nationalism objection by abandoning functionalism; the mark is earned by adding the sacred-order and soteriological conditions, not by retreating to a God-centred definition.

MCQ 3. The function that really does need a deity

On the owner's table of religious functions, which one most clearly does require a personal deity, so that a candid answer has to concede it?

- A. Liberation or salvation, since release from the human predicament must be bestowed by an agent who is genuinely able to grant it.
- B. Ritual efficacy, since an unseen potency released by correct performance cannot operate unless an intelligent agent supervises the sequence.
- C. Moral motivation, since obligation collapses into mere preference unless a commanding will attaches reward and punishment to conduct.
- D. Petitionary prayer, since a responsive addressee who can hear, choose and grant is built into the structure of petition itself.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: liberation as a generic function is exactly what nirvana, Jain liberation and Samkhya-Yoga isolation deliver without a creator; only grace in its personal-agency sense requires a giver.
- **B:** Incorrect: Mimamsa's unseen ritual potency (apurva) secures efficacy with no supervising agent at all, and Buddhist and Jain disciplines are held to be efficacious without one either.

- **C:** Incorrect: compassion, non-injury, karma, vows, insight and human flourishing all supply motivation here, and the full dependence question is routed to the Religion and Morality owner in any case.
- **D:** Correct: petition is relational by structure, so meditation, aspiration and recitation perform other work without being petition in the same sense; conceding this separates a strong script from a sweeping one.

Examiner trap 3: Answering that God is required for nothing whatever looks bolder but scores lower; name petition, grace and covenant as genuinely theistic goods and then show that religion as such does not depend on them.

MCQ 4. Non-theism, atheism and the firewall between them

Which statement draws the distinction between non-theism and atheism with the precision this clause demands?

- A. Non-theism denies every god, spirit and sacred being, while atheism denies only the single omnipotent creator of classical monotheistic religion.
- B. Non-theism means a creator is absent from a tradition's diagnosis and path, whereas atheism is the positive denial that God exists at all.
- C. Non-theism is a politer name for atheism, adopted so that Buddhism and Jainism can be described without giving needless offence to their living practitioners.
- D. Non-theism holds that God's existence is unknown or unknowable, while atheism merely suspends judgement until further evidence happens to arrive.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this inverts the scope of both terms, since the whole purpose of the non-theistic label is that it leaves lesser deities and devotional practice entirely untouched.
- **B:** Correct: the owner's firewall is that rejecting a creator does not entail denying every deity, sacred being, devotional act or transcendent value, so absence from the path and denial of existence are different claims.
- **C:** Incorrect: the distinction is doctrinal rather than diplomatic, since Theravada Buddhism admits cosmological gods while denying both their creatorhood and their salvific ultimacy.
- **D:** Incorrect: this swaps the standard definitions of agnosticism and atheism and then attaches the wrong one to non-theism, collapsing three separate positions into a single confusion.

Examiner trap 4: Writing 'Buddhism is atheistic' in the opening line concedes the theist's framing and invites the reply that a godless system cannot be a religion; write 'non-theistic' and state what the word leaves standing.

MCQ 5. Both deliverables of the agnosticism question

The 2023 question asks what agnosticism is and how agnostics conceptualise the relation between religion and God. Which answer supplies both halves?

- A. The claim that the word 'God' carries no determinate meaning, together with the view that the existence question cannot even be coherently formulated.
- B. Indifference to the question of God, together with the view that religion is an aesthetic preference comparable to a private taste in music or in painting.
- C. Suspension of judgement about God, subdivided into weak and strong forms, with continued valuing of religion's ethical and experiential dimensions.
- D. Denial of God's existence on evidential grounds, together with the view that religion is a purely social institution that carries no cognitive content whatever.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: that is the meaning-first position sometimes labelled ignosticism, whereas agnosticism accepts the question as intelligible and reports it to be unsettled or unsettleable.
- **B:** Incorrect: indifference is a fourth position that the owner tells you to keep apart from suspension of judgement, which is an epistemic stance held for stated reasons about evidence.

- **C:** Correct: the stem prints a definition task and a positional task, so the answer must define, sub-divide into 'not known' and 'unknowable', and then state the graded religiosity that withholds assent while retaining practice.
- **D:** Incorrect: denial is atheism rather than agnosticism, and the reduction of religion to a social institution is a further thesis that suspension of judgement does not by itself entail.

Examiner trap 5: Half-answers that define agnosticism and stop forfeit the second printed deliverable; the stem asks how agnostics relate religion and God, so the graded-religiosity paragraph is compulsory.

MCQ 6. Why the creator hypothesis is idle in Buddhism

In the Buddhist account, what makes the creator hypothesis explanatorily unnecessary for the problem the tradition sets itself?

- A. Dependent origination with karma explains how suffering arises from conditions and ceases when they go, so a maker adds no step to that sequence.
- B. The Buddha demonstrated by inference that no first cause of the world can exist, which closes the cosmological route to God permanently.
- C. The monastic community allocates karmic fruits to practitioners, taking over the task a divine superintendent would otherwise have to perform.
- D. Liberation itself functions as an impersonal first cause from which the conditioned world is derived, so the explanatory role is occupied.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: craving and ignorance condition suffering and the path removes the conditions, so a creator neither enters the diagnosis nor performs work in the cure, which makes the hypothesis idle rather than refuted.
- **B:** Incorrect: no such demonstration is claimed anywhere in the owner; the case is that the creator hypothesis is idle for the therapeutic problem, not that its impossibility has been proved.
- **C:** Incorrect: no community allocates karmic results in this account; the Sangha sustains practice and transmission, while the moral-causal order operates as law rather than as administration.
- **D:** Incorrect: nirvana is the goal of the path rather than a cosmological origin, and treating it as a first cause quietly reimports the very creator structure that Buddhism manages without.

Examiner trap 6: Do not argue that Buddhism disproves God; argue that it dispenses with God, since the printed stems ask whether religion is possible without God, not whether God has been refuted.

MCQ 7. The undeclared questions, used at their real scope

What is the correct examination use of the Buddha's undeclared questions (avyakata) in a religion-without-God answer?

- A. They show that the Buddha treated all religious language as meaningless, anticipating the verification principle by more than two millennia.
- B. They record the Buddha's own uncertainty, so Buddhism is best classified as a developed form of strong agnosticism about the divine.
- C. They concern particular speculative issues the path does not require, and must not be offered as the whole Buddhist case against a creator.
- D. They are a formal declaration that no divine being of any kind exists, which is why Buddhism is properly classified as an atheistic religion.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this smuggles in a semantic thesis owned by the Religious Language clause, whereas the undeclared questions concern profitability for the path rather than meaningfulness.
- **B:** Incorrect: the refusal is pedagogical and soteriological rather than a confession of ignorance, and importing the agnostic label blurs the four negative positions the clause asks you to separate.
- **C:** Correct: the owner restricts their scope deliberately, since setting certain metaphysical questions aside as unprofitable is a far narrower claim than a doctrinal denial that any divine being exists.
- **D:** Incorrect: silence about a question is not denial of its subject matter, and the atheistic label is exactly the imprecision this clause is designed to penalise in the opening paragraph.

Examiner trap 7: The poisoned-arrow parable illustrates the urgency of removing suffering, not the non-existence of gods; use it to explain why speculation is deferred, never as proof of atheism.

MCQ 8. Gods inside the cosmology, and devotional Mahayana

Which statement handles gods within Buddhism, and later devotional Mahayana, without conceding the theist's point?

- A. Devotional Mahayana shows that Buddhism became straightforwardly theistic, so only the earliest Buddhism can still count as evidence against creator-necessity.
- B. Because gods appear in the cosmology, Buddhism is covertly monotheistic and its non-theism is really a modern Western reconstruction of the living tradition.
- C. Buddhist teaching requires denial of every god, so any text that mentions them must be treated as a later devotional corruption of the original doctrine.
- D. Gods and Brahma figures remain impermanent beings inside rebirth, and Buddhas and bodhisattvas may carry devotional functions without becoming a creator.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: performing a religious function is not the same as occupying the creator role, so the concession is unnecessary and the counterexample survives the devotional development intact.
- **B:** Incorrect: a plurality of impermanent beings is not monotheism, and the reconstruction charge ignores the tradition's own doctrinal denial that any of those beings created or can finally save.
- **C:** Incorrect: the owner states plainly that Buddhism does not deny every deity, and the corruption move is a textual claim that none of the controlling sources here supports.
- **D:** Correct: this holds both lines at once, denying creatorhood and salvific ultimacy to the gods while conceding that being non-theistic does not make a tradition devotion-free.

Examiner trap 8: Examiners reward the sentence separating religious function from ontological status: devotion to a Buddha performs some of what worship performs without installing an omnipotent maker.

MCQ 9. What orients Buddhist religious life

Which formulation of what organises Buddhist religious life, in the absence of a creator, is the most defensible in an answer?

- A. Teaching, community and liberation organise doctrine, practice and value without working as one-for-one substitutes for a personal creator.
- B. Dharma occupies the place of God, the Sangha the place of the church and nirvana the place of heaven, so the two religious structures map onto each other one to one.
- C. Meditative attainment alone organises Buddhist life, since ethics and community are later cultural additions rather than constitutive parts of the path.
- D. The Four Noble Truths function as revealed propositions from an authority whose reliability has first to be accepted on faith before practice can begin.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the qualification does the work, because saying that these simply replace God invites the hidden-God objection that non-theistic religion is theism operating under other names.
- **B:** Incorrect: functional similarity does not establish ontological identity, and this neat mapping is exactly the concession that the hidden-God objection needs in order to succeed.
- **C:** Incorrect: moral discipline and the community are constitutive elements of the eightfold path and of its institutional form, not optional cultural accretions added afterwards.
- **D:** Incorrect: they are presented as a diagnosis to be tested in practice, and propositional revelation from a divine speaker is one of the functions this clause identifies as genuinely theistic.

Examiner trap 9: The examiner is watching for the phrase 'not a one-for-one substitute'; without it your own Buddhist paragraph hands the theist the reply he needs.

MCQ 10. The Jain case against a creator

Which pair of considerations captures the Jain argument against a creator God as the owner states it?

- A. Scripture is authorless and therefore needs no divine speaker, so the whole argument from the reliability of a speaker collapses at once.
- B. Only momentary events exist, so there is no persisting agent capable of performing a single sustained act of world-creation at any point whatever.
- C. The world is eternal and uncreated, and consciousness emerges from the body, so no soul survives that would require a maker to account for it.
- D. A perfect being has no unfulfilled motive that creating could satisfy, and an embodied creator would be limited by the embodiment that action requires.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: that is the Mimamsa route through the authorless Veda, which is a different counterexample resting on a different mechanism from the Jain motive and embodiment arguments.
- **B:** Incorrect: momentariness is a Buddhist thesis, while Jain metaphysics is explicitly substantialist about souls and matter and could not use this premise without abandoning its own ontology.
- **C:** Incorrect: the second half is Carvaka's materialist thesis, whereas Jainism affirms innumerable eternal souls and a genuine liberation, both of which materialism denies outright.
- **D:** Correct: motive and limitation are the two Jain pressures, and the same argument family reappears in Kumarila's attack on the possibility of a bodiless agent acting upon matter.

Examiner trap 10: Never describe the liberated Jain soul as a creator God under another name; it is an achieved perfection rather than a governing one, and that difference defeats the hidden-God objection.

MCQ 11. Authorless scripture is not revelation

Why must the Mimamsa Veda never be described in an answer as revelation?

- A. Because it was composed by human seers whose insight is treated as authoritative only within the boundaries of the ritual tradition.
- B. Because it is held to be authorless, so its authority does not depend on the reliability of any speaker, whether divine or human.
- C. Because revelation there is delivered through the deities named in the mantras, who dictate the injunctions to the priesthood.
- D. Because Mimamsa treats the Veda as literally false yet pragmatically useful for organising the ritual life of a community.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: human composition is exactly what the doctrine denies, since a composed text would inherit its author's fallibility and the school's whole case rests on avoiding that.
- **B:** Correct: revelation presupposes a revealer, and the Mimamsa claim is that eternal, unauthored injunction needs no speaker whose trustworthiness would first have to be established by some further argument.
- **C:** Incorrect: those deities function as elements within the ritual structure, the dative to which the oblation is offered, and are not agents who hear, choose, dictate or grant anything.
- **D:** Incorrect: this imports modern fictionalism into a school whose injunctions are held to be intrinsically valid, and intrinsic validity is incompatible with treating them as useful falsehoods.

Examiner trap 11: One careless sentence calling the Veda 'revealed' surrenders the whole Mimamsa counterexample, because revelation reinstates the divine speaker the school has just removed.

MCQ 12. How Mimamsa defines what it studies

Jaimini's Mimamsa-sutra 1.1.2 defines dharma. Which reading of that definition is accurate and examinable?

- A. Dharma is what is characterised by Vedic injunction and is beneficial, so it is known from injunction alone and never from perception or inference.
- B. Dharma is the eternal moral law inscribed in the nature of things and therefore knowable by unaided human reason working from the observed order of things.
- C. Dharma is whatever produces the greatest welfare, so injunctions may be revised whenever their consequences turn out on inspection to be harmful in ordinary ritual practice.
- D. Dharma is the command of a supreme being, transmitted through the Veda and enforced by the fruits that are assigned to agents in a life after death.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the sutra reads *codana-laksano 'rtho dharmah*, and the epistemic consequence is the reason for citing it, since injunction is made the sole source of the knowledge of dharma.
- **B:** Incorrect: natural-law knowability is exactly what Mimamsa denies, because perception and inference are held to be incapable of reaching dharma at all, which is why injunction is required.
- **C:** Incorrect: this converts a scriptural criterion into a consequentialist one and loses the school's distinctive claim that injunction is epistemically prior to any assessment of outcomes.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is divine-command theory, and it reinstates both the divine speaker and the divine dispenser that classical Mimamsa argues at length are entirely unnecessary.

Examiner trap 12: If you cite the sutra, cite it for the epistemic point that dharma is knowable only from injunction; quoting it as decoration without that consequence earns no marks at all.

MCQ 13. The argument that generates apurva

Which reconstruction of the Mimamsa argument for the unseen potency (apurva) is correct in both its structure and its epistemic status?

- A. The promised fruit is purely psychological, consisting in the confidence the performer gains from having discharged the standing injunction properly and in order.
- B. Ritual acts are observed to generate a subtle physical residue in the performer, and that residue is then directly perceived by sufficiently advanced practitioners.
- C. A momentary act cannot produce a much later fruit, so a persisting potency is postulated to bridge them and admitted as a postulate, not as something observed.
- D. A supervising deity records each performance and assigns the promised fruit at the appropriate time, and the technical term simply names the record that is kept in this way.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the promised results are objective states of affairs in the school's own account, and a psychological reading dissolves the very problem that the postulate was introduced to solve.
- **B:** Incorrect: nothing whatever is claimed to be perceived here, and treating the potency as an observed entity is a listed trap that misstates the school's own account of how it is known.
- **C:** Correct: the injunction promises a delayed result, the act perishes, a perished cause cannot produce a later effect, and the school's own epistemology licenses postulation to explain an otherwise inexplicable fact.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is the Nyaya superintendent that the postulate exists to make unnecessary, so the reading inverts the argument and hands the theist back the function Mimamsa has removed.

Examiner trap 13: State all five steps or none; a bare assertion that ritual generates apurva, without the perished-cause problem, reads as vocabulary rather than as argument.

MCQ 14. Kumarila against Prabhakara

How do the two classical Mimamsa schools differ in their treatment of the injunction and its fruit?

- A. Kumarila accepts a creator God as the guarantor of ritual efficacy, whereas Prabhakara rejects any such divine guarantor of the system entirely.
- B. Kumarila treats the unseen potency as a power in the act or agent linking deed to fruit; Prabhakara recentres the analysis on the sheer ought-to-be- done.
- C. Kumarila regards ritual as symbolic self-expression, while Prabhakara regards the ritual act itself as genuinely and causally efficacious.
- D. Kumarila holds that the Veda has a divine author while Prabhakara holds that it is authorless, which is why only the second of the two schools genuinely avoids theism.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Kumarila's Slokavarttika contains sustained arguments against a creator, including the motive problem and the impossibility of a bodiless agent acting upon matter.
- **B:** Correct: the difference carries an ethical payoff, since Prabhakara's account is closer to a deontology of the injunction and Kumarila's to a consequential mechanism of desert.
- **C:** Incorrect: neither treats ritual as symbolic self-expression and the efficacy claim is shared, so the disagreement has to be located in what the injunction primarily discloses.
- **D:** Incorrect: authorlessness is common ground for classical Mimamsa, and the dispute between the two concerns the analysis of injunction and fruit rather than the origin of the text.

Examiner trap 14: Naming Kumarila and Prabhakara without stating the deontology-versus- desert consequence is name-dropping; the distinction earns marks only when the ethical payoff is spelt out.

MCQ 15. Answering Nyaya's superintendent argument

Nyaya objects that an unconscious potency cannot select the right fruit for the right agent at the right time. What is the Mimamsa reply?

- A. That the question of allocation is unanswerable and should be set aside in the manner of the questions the Buddha left formally undeclared.
- B. That fruits are allotted by liberated souls who have completed the ritual path and and who now supervise the operation of that path on behalf of others.
- C. That the relation is law-like rather than deliberative, and that the objection begs the question by assuming only agents can produce determinate outcomes.
- D. That the deities named in the mantras perform the selection, so an intelligent allocator is quietly retained within the ritual system after all.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the undeclared questions belong to the Buddhist material, and Mimamsa offers a positive account of how act and fruit are connected rather than a refusal to answer.
- **B:** Incorrect: this borrows Jain vocabulary and installs a governing agency that both schools deny, since liberated beings on either account do not administer the world or its rewards.
- **C:** Correct: the exchange turns on whether determinate results require deliberation, and Mimamsa holds that regular natural law delivers determinate outcomes without any selecting mind supervising them.
- **D:** Incorrect: those deities are elements within the ritual structure rather than agents who hear, choose and grant, so this concedes precisely the objection it was supposed to answer.

Examiner trap 15: Do not answer Nyaya by attacking theism in general; answer the specific allocation argument, because that is where a fifteen-mark script separates itself from a ten-mark one.

MCQ 16. Samkhya, Yoga and the non-creating Isvara

Which statement handles classical Samkhya and Yoga correctly inside a religion-without-God answer?

- A. Both reduce liberation to the cessation of the material world itself, so the stated goal is cosmic dissolution rather than any individual release at all.
- B. Samkhya treats consciousness as a product of material evolution, which is why it needs no creator at all to explain the first arising of conscious awareness.
- C. Both systems posit a creator who superintends the evolution of nature, so neither of the two can serve as a genuine case of religion without God.
- D. Samkhya derives evolution from nature in proximity to plural selves and seeks isolation, while Yoga's special self is not straightforwardly a creator.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: isolation is the discriminative release of the self from entanglement with evolving nature, and it neither requires nor asserts the annihilation of nature as such.
- **B:** Incorrect: that is the materialist thesis, whereas Samkhya holds consciousness to be an irreducible principle wholly distinct from the evolving material order it illuminates.
- **C:** Incorrect: classical Samkhya is a standard non-theistic case in the owner, and even Yoga's Isvara is a special self rather than a maker or governor of the world process.
- **D:** Correct: keeping the two systems apart on this point prevents the common error of importing Yoga's Isvara into classical Samkhya and thereby destroying the counterexample being offered.

Examiner trap 16: The objection that unconscious principles cannot organise ends is answered by denying that observed regularity must be modelled on artefact production; the milk-and-calf analogy does exactly that work.

MCQ 17. The route the 2025 directive is buying

The 2025 question asks for Carvaka's critique of belief in suprasensible entities. Which route through the material does the directive actually buy?

- A. The linguistic route: terms for suprasensible entities fail a criterion of meaning, so claims that involve them turn out to be neither true nor false.
- B. The epistemological route: perception alone is a means of knowledge, and inference fails because invariable concomitance cannot itself be established.
- C. The historical route: the school documents that religious institutions arose to secure ritual income, which explains belief in unseen entities.
- D. The ethical route: since pleasure and wealth are the only real human ends, religious goods stand exposed as fabrications serving established priestly interests.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: that is verificationism, owned by the Religious Language clause, whereas Carvaka grants that the claims are meaningful and denies only that they can ever be known.
- **B:** Correct: the directive asks for the argument of the critique rather than its conclusions, so the analysis of the means of knowledge, not the hedonist slogans, is what the examiner is paying for.
- **C:** Incorrect: a sociological genealogy is not what the reported Carvaka argument offers, and the surviving verses are doxographic quotations rather than historical evidence of any kind.
- **D:** Incorrect: the reduction of human ends is a consequence of the epistemology, so an answer built on hedonism misses the printed demand for the argument of the critique itself.

Examiner trap 17: The hedonist couplet and the verses attributed to Brhaspati survive only in opponents' doxographies, chiefly Madhava's Sarvadarsanasamgraha; report them as such, and never build the answer on them.

MCQ 18. The concomitance problem, stated in full

Which statement gives the Carvaka attack on inference completely, including the residue that survives however often the concomitance is observed?

- A. Concomitance is known by repeated observation, but observation is unreliable because the senses are frequently deceived by illusion, by dream and by defect.
- B. Inference is valid for the supersensible but invalid for ordinary matters, since everyday judgements are contaminated by practical interest.
- C. Inference is invalid because the mark and the inferred object are never once present together within any one single and complete act of perception.
- D. Concomitance is unreachable by perception, by inference and by testimony, and an unnoticed conditioning factor can never be conclusively excluded.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is the parity argument used by critics against Carvaka rather than the Carvaka case, and it concedes at the outset that concomitance can in fact be known.
- **B:** Incorrect: this exactly reverses the reported Purandara position, which admits ordinary inference while denying it for what lies beyond the reach of the senses altogether.
- **C:** Incorrect: co-presence in particular cases is exactly what the argument grants; the difficulty lies in the leap from observed particulars to an unrestricted universal covering unobserved cases.
- **D:** Correct: the three closed routes plus the conditioning-factor residue constitute the whole argument, and it is the residue that reduces inference from certainty to mere probability.

Examiner trap 18: An answer saying only that 'Carvaka rejects inference', without the concomitance analysis and the conditioning-factor residue, has stated a conclusion and omitted the argument the directive demanded.

MCQ 19. Self-refutation, and the two replies that are required

The claim that no inference is valid looks self-refuting. Which pair of replies does the owner require an answer to supply?

- A. The appeal to scriptural silence, since no accepted text asserts the validity of inference anywhere in so many words, or in any equivalent formula.
- B. The appeal to practical success, since the school's followers manifestly survive and prosper in daily life while relying upon perception alone.
- C. The dialectical reading, on which the denial is pressed from inside the opponent's own commitments, and the reported strand admitting ordinary inference only.
- D. The appeal to Nyaya's devices, since repeated uncontradicted observation and hypothetical reasoning are conceded by both parties to the dispute.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Carvaka rejects scriptural authority outright, so an argument resting on what scripture does or does not assert is simply unavailable to the school in the first place.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is the pragmatic argument used against Carvaka, because no one, including a Carvaka, can eat, speak, teach or argue without relying on inference constantly.
- **C:** Correct: these are the two moves that rescue the school from a self- defeating universal claim, and the second yields the far more defensible thesis about the limits of inference.
- **D:** Incorrect: those are Nyaya's positive defence of concomitance and are precisely what Carvaka contests, so they cannot be pressed into service as a Carvaka reply at all.

Examiner trap 19: Leaving the self-refutation charge unanswered forfeits the evaluation marks; give the dialectical reading and the reported moderate strand, and flag that the evidence for the latter is fragmentary.

MCQ 20. Consciousness, order and the four elements

Which set of Carvaka applications to religion is correctly matched to the device that supports it?

- A. Consciousness emerges from the body, illustrated by intoxicating power arising from combined ingredients, and order follows from things acting by their own nature.
- B. Consciousness is a mode of one single substance, nature, and order follows from the necessity with which that single substance's own attributes unfold.
- C. Consciousness is a stream of momentary events, and order is explained by dependent conditioning that holds among those very momentary events themselves.
- D. Consciousness is an eternal substance temporarily housed in the body, and cosmic order is explained by the slow and gradual ripening of deeds performed in past lives.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: emergence removes survival, transmigration and liberation together, while the own-nature explanation removes any need for a designer of the thorn's sharpness or the peacock's colour.
- **B:** Incorrect: that is Spinoza's apparatus, which the owner names as the historical ancestor of religious naturalism rather than as anything belonging to Carvaka materialism.
- **C:** Incorrect: momentariness and dependent conditioning are Buddhist doctrines, and Buddhism retains exactly the supersensible order that Carvaka's epistemology closes off completely.
- **D:** Incorrect: both halves are exactly what Carvaka denies, since an eternal conscious substance and karmic ripening are among the supersensible postulates directly under attack.

Examiner trap 20: The four gross elements exhaust reality on this view and ether is rejected as imperceptible; getting that list wrong signals that the epistemology behind it has not been understood.

MCQ 21. Why Carvaka is the limiting case

Why is it a mark-earning move to deny that Carvaka is itself an instance of religion without God?

- A. Because its texts survive only in the works of opponents, and a tradition without its own surviving scripture cannot properly be counted as a religion.
- B. Because it denies rebirth, and any system without rebirth falls outside the recognised Indian category of religion altogether and at once.
- C. Because it is a school of philosophy rather than a tradition, and philosophy is never counted as religion within the classical Indian doxographic context.
- D. Because it has no soteriology, sacred order, community of practice or ultimate concern, and so shows what non-theistic religions actually retain.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the transmission problem is a source-discipline point governing how the verses may be quoted, and it is not a criterion of religious status at all.
- **B:** Incorrect: rebirth is not the criterion in play here, and adopting it would wrongly expel non-Indian non-theistic positions by applying a purely local test to them.
- **C:** Incorrect: Samkhya and Mimamsa are also philosophical schools yet function as religious systems in this clause, so the philosophy label does not settle the classification question.
- **D:** Correct: the contrast is the point, since Buddhism, Jainism and Mimamsa survive the loss of God while Carvaka closes the epistemic route to any supersensible object and ends in no religion at all.

Examiner trap 21: The verdict formula is that the critique succeeds exactly as far as its epistemology does: the strong thesis is self-refuting and unliveable, the moderate thesis is unrefuted and fatal to inference-based natural theology.

MCQ 22. Nietzsche's diagnosis, and who owns the question

Which handling of Nietzsche is correct both philosophically and in terms of syllabus ownership?

- A. It is a historical report of declining church attendance in nineteenth-century Europe, and it therefore belongs to sociology rather than to philosophy proper.
- B. It is a theological thesis about divine self-emptying, so Nietzsche's target turns out to be only one particular Christian doctrine of God among many.
- C. It is a cultural diagnosis of a collapsed value horizon, and the printed question coupling religion with morality belongs to the Religion and Morality owner.
- D. It is a compressed argument for atheism, establishing by inference from the problem of evil that no deity of the traditional theistic kind exists at all.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: reducing the declaration to an empirical event is a listed trap, since the claim concerns the unbelievability of an entire framework rather than attendance statistics.
- **B:** Incorrect: no source in this clause supports that reading, and it dissolves a cultural diagnosis into a theological doctrine that Nietzsche is certainly not defending.
- **C:** Correct: this clause keeps Nietzsche as a critique of theistic religion and as the bridge to post-theistic value, while the full genealogical dossier is routed to the neighbouring owner file.
- **D:** Incorrect: it is not an existence proof at all, and attaching it to the problem of evil confuses two separate clauses with two quite different owners and demands.

Examiner trap 22: Nietzsche mourns a horizon that Buddhism and Jainism never possessed; using him as a general spokesman for religion without God confuses post-theism with non-theism.

MCQ 23. Dewey and Dworkin on religion within nature

Which pairing of thinker and thesis in religious naturalism is accurate as the owner states it?

- A. Dewey separates religion as institution from the religious as a unifying quality of experience; Dworkin rests religious atheism on value and cosmic sublimity.
- B. Dewey argues that religious language is non-assertoric make-believe, while Dworkin defends a personal God stripped of the attribute of omnipotence.
- C. Dewey identifies God with the natural universe taken as a single substance, while Dworkin identifies God with humanity's own idealised and projected essence.
- D. Both hold that religious naturalism requires abandoning ritual and community, since both of these are held to be inseparable from supernatural belief.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Dewey proposes using the word God for the active relation between the ideal and the actual, and Dworkin makes value realism rather than theism the core of what is religious about religion.
- **B:** Incorrect: non-assertoric participation is fictionalism rather than naturalism, and Dworkin's position is explicitly atheistic about any personal God whatever.
- **C:** Incorrect: the first formula is Spinoza's and the second is Feuerbach's projection thesis, so neither belongs to the thinker to whom it has here been attached.
- **D:** Incorrect: naturalists defend themselves precisely by pointing to reverence, communal practice and self-transformation as the religious elements that survive the loss of supernatural ontology.

Examiner trap 23: The objection that this is ethics and aesthetics in religious vocabulary is met by naming ultimacy, reverence, community and transformation, and by noting that demanding a supernatural person merely restates theism.

MCQ 24. Fictionalism, error theory and non-cognitivism

Which set of distinctions among the modern non-theistic positions is correct?

- A. All three are versions of religious naturalism, differing only in how much reverence each of them recommends towards the natural world as it stands.
- B. Error theory calls the claims false and abandons them, non-cognitivism denies they have truth-conditions, and fictionalism grants these and declines to assert.
- C. Non-cognitivism and fictionalism agree that religious sentences lack truth-conditions and differ only over which of the inherited rituals ought to be retained.
- D. Fictionalism and error theory agree that the claims are false and differ only over whether that falsity ought in honesty to be publicised to ordinary worshippers.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: naturalism asserts its claims about ultimacy within nature and therefore stands apart from all three, and merging the four is expressly listed among the clause's traps.
- **B:** Correct: fictionalism is defined by the refusal to assert rather than by a verdict on meaning or by abandonment of the practice, which is why it stands as a genuinely distinct third position.
- **C:** Incorrect: the fictionalist grants that religious sentences have truth-conditions, which is the entire point of declining to assert them rather than denying that they mean anything.
- **D:** Incorrect: the difference has nothing to do with publicity and everything to do with whether the practice is abandoned or accepted and continued in a non-assertoric spirit.

Examiner trap 24: Advaita's everyday level is not fictionalism: sublation is not falsification, and the two-level device preserves the practitioner's sincerity in a way explicit make-believe cannot.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 8

MCQ 25. Remedial - "Buddhism is an atheistic religion"

Which correction is best?

- A. It is atheistic in the strict sense, since the undeclared questions amount to a formal doctrinal denial that any divine being whatever exists at all.
- B. It is agnostic rather than atheistic, since the Buddha suspended judgement on a creator for want of sufficient evidence pointing decisively in either direction.
- C. It is better described as non-theistic, since a creator is absent from the diagnosis and path while impermanent gods and devotional practice are not denied.
- D. It is theistic in its later forms, so no single label applies and the classification question should simply be left open for each separate school.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: silence about a set of speculative questions is not denial of their subject matter, and the undeclared questions have a deliberately restricted scope.
- **B:** Incorrect: agnosticism is an epistemic verdict about evidence, whereas the Buddhist point is that the creator question is idle for the therapeutic path being prescribed.
- **C:** Correct: it repairs the label and states what the label leaves standing, which is exactly what the owner's firewall between non-theism and atheism requires of a script.
- **D:** Incorrect: devotional development does not install an omnipotent creator, and refusing any label evades the very discrimination the examiner is testing in this clause.

Examiner trap 25: Correcting the label without saying what non-theism permits leaves half the error standing; name the impermanent gods and the devotional practice in the same sentence.

MCQ 26. Remedial - "Carvaka is the clearest religion without God"

Which correction is best?

- A. It cannot be classified either way, because its own texts survive only inside the summaries written by its philosophical opponents.
- B. It is the limiting case, not an instance, since it lacks soteriology, sacred order, community of practice and ultimate concern, and ends in no religion at all.
- C. It is an instance, since rejecting God is the only condition that a religion without God has to satisfy before it can qualify in the first place.
- D. It is an instance, because its this-worldly ends function as a soteriology aimed at securing ordinary human flourishing within the limits of the present life.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the transmission problem constrains how the verses may be quoted rather than whether the doctrines can be classified, and the reported positions are determinate enough.
- **B:** Correct: it converts a misclassification into the contrast that shows what the non-theistic religions actually retain once a creator has been given up.
- **C:** Incorrect: this makes the absence of one belief sufficient for membership and silently abandons every positive criterion of religion the clause has been building.
- **D:** Incorrect: pleasure and wealth in this life are not a diagnosis of a fundamental predicament together with a disciplined path leading out of it, which is what soteriology means.

Examiner trap 26: The reward here is the sentence that religion can survive the loss of God but not the loss of a sacred order; write it explicitly rather than leaving it implied.

MCQ 27. Remedial - "the Mimamsa Veda is divine revelation"

Which correction is best?

- A. The Veda is authorless and therefore not the speech of any God, which is why arguments from the reliability of a divine speaker get no purchase on it.
- B. It is revelation given to the seers, whose authority the school then treats as intrinsically valid and therefore immune from any further external challenge.
- C. It is a human composition whose authority rests on long communal acceptance rather than on the personal standing of any one particular speaker or author.
- D. It is revelation, but of an impersonal rather than a personal deity, so the school remains theistic in at least a weak, indirect and heavily attenuated sense.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: it names the doctrine, draws the consequence and shows exactly why the counterexample to creator-necessity survives the objection being pressed.
- **B:** Incorrect: intrinsic validity attaches to the injunction itself and not to the reliability of any recipient, transmitter or inspired individual seer.
- **C:** Incorrect: human composition is denied as firmly as divine authorship, because a composed text would inherit the fallibility of whoever composed it.
- **D:** Incorrect: an impersonal revealer is still a revealer, whereas the doctrine denies that there is any author whatsoever standing behind the text.

Examiner trap 27: Watch your own vocabulary: 'revealed', 'scripture given by God' and 'divine word' all silently reinstate the speaker the school has just removed.

MCQ 28. Remedial - "apurva is an unseen force we observe in ritual"

Which correction is best?

- A. It is directly perceived by the officiating priest, which is why only properly qualified performers are permitted to conduct the rite on another's behalf.
- B. It is a postulate introduced to explain a delayed fruit, and the two schools differ over whether it is a power in the act or the sheer ought-to-be-done.
- C. It is a metaphor for the psychological confidence produced by having properly discharged a standing duty, and it therefore carries no ontological weight at all.
- D. It is inferred from repeated observation of ritual outcomes, in the same way that the presence of fire is regularly inferred from the observation of rising smoke.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: nothing is perceived on this account, and the qualification rules concern ritual competence rather than any privileged perceptual access to a potency.
- **B:** Correct: it corrects the epistemic status and adds the Kumarila-Prabhakara discrimination that a strong script carries into the objection-and-reply stage.
- **C:** Incorrect: it is introduced precisely to do ontological work, bridging a perished act and a much later fruit, so a metaphorical reading dissolves the problem it answers.
- **D:** Incorrect: the promised results typically mature long after the act and often after death, so the observational base such an inference would require simply does not exist.

Examiner trap 28: A postulate explaining an otherwise inexplicable fact is a licensed move in this school's own epistemology; say so, or the charge of arbitrary invention goes unanswered.

MCQ 29. Remedial - "Nietzsche proved that God does not exist"

Which correction is best?

- A. It is a proof, though an inductive rather than a deductive one, resting on the observed historical failure of the great religious institutions.
- B. It is a report that the deity of Christianity once existed in fact and has at some later point in European history ceased to exist altogether.
- C. It is a claim that the word 'God' is meaningless, so that the question of existence never actually arises for serious philosophical discussion.
- D. The declaration diagnoses that belief has become unbelievable and that dependent values now face nihilism; it is not a demonstration of non-existence.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: recasting a cultural diagnosis as an induction still treats it as an argument about existence, which is exactly the misreading being corrected.
- **B:** Incorrect: reading the declaration as an empirical event is a listed trap and makes nonsense of the genealogical project it introduces in Nietzsche's own writing.
- **C:** Incorrect: that is a semantic thesis owned by another clause entirely, whereas Nietzsche's concern is the collapse of a framework of values and what follows from it.
- **D:** Correct: it identifies the kind of claim being made and names its consequence, which is the demand for revaluation rather than any inference to a metaphysical conclusion.

Examiner trap 29: Follow the diagnosis with its consequence: inherited values depended on the framework, its collapse threatens nihilism, and overcoming it requires revaluation and self-creation.

MCQ 30. Remedial - "agnosticism is a hesitant form of atheism"

Which correction is best?

- A. Agnosticism holds that religious statements are neither true nor false, so belief and disbelief turn out to be equally confused responses to them.
- B. Agnosticism denies God's existence but withholds public assertion of that denial for broadly social, professional and prudential reasons of an entirely personal kind.
- C. Agnosticism suspends judgement rather than denying, and subdivides into the weak claim that the matter is not known and the strong claim that it is unknowable.
- D. Agnosticism is indifference to religious questions and therefore has no bearing on the separate question of whether religion without God is possible.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: that is non-cognitivism about religious language, which is a claim about meaning rather than a claim about what can or cannot be known.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is atheism with a communication strategy attached, and it erases the epistemic content that makes agnosticism a distinct position at all.
- **C:** Correct: it separates suspension from denial and supplies the weak-strong subdivision that the printed question expects an answer to provide.
- **D:** Incorrect: indifference is a fourth position, and agnostics may value religion's ethical and experiential dimensions while still withholding assent on the existence of God.

Examiner trap 30: Kant's practical faith and Spencer's Unknowable are agnostic-adjacent and show that suspending theoretical judgement is compatible with a continuing religious life.

MCQ 31. Remedial - "dharma and nirvana are God under other names"

Which correction is best?

- A. The objection fails because every religion, theistic or not, ultimately refers to to one and the same finally indeterminate ultimate reality.
- B. The objection is correct, and non-theistic religions are therefore covert theisms that have simply changed their working vocabulary over the intervening centuries.
- C. The objection fails because dharma and nirvana perform no religious functions whatever, being purely philosophical categories of a technical kind.
- D. Functional replacement does not establish ontological identity: impersonal law is not an omniscient person, and liberation by insight is not grace bestowed.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: that is a pluralist thesis owned by another clause, and it answers a quite different question from the one the hidden-God objection actually raises.
- **B:** Incorrect: this concedes an inference from similar role to identical entity, which is exactly the step the owner rejects when it answers the hidden-God objection.
- **C:** Incorrect: they plainly do organise doctrine, practice and value, and denying that would abandon the very case for calling these traditions religions in the first place.
- **D:** Correct: it names the fallacy inside the hidden-God objection and supplies the two discriminations that are needed to defeat it in a single sentence.

Examiner trap 31: Do not let your own exposition invite this objection: avoid saying that dharma 'takes the place of' God, and state instead what work it does and does not do.

MCQ 32. Remedial - "naturalism and fictionalism are one position"

Which correction is best?

- A. The naturalist asserts that ultimacy and reverence lie within nature; the fictionalist declines to assert the claims and participates non- assertorically.
- B. Both are versions of the two-level Indian device, and differ only over which of the two levels ought in the end to be described as the ultimate one.
- C. Both accept that religious claims are false, and differ only over whether ritual practice should nevertheless be retained by the community afterwards.
- D. Both hold that religious language lacks truth-conditions, and differ only over the role that a community ought to play in a continuing religious life.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: assertion is the dividing line, and stating it also keeps error theory, which abandons the discourse altogether, separate from both of the other positions.
- **B:** Incorrect: the Indian device sublates rather than falsifies, which is precisely why it preserves the practitioner's sincerity in a way that fictionalism struggles to do.
- **C:** Incorrect: the naturalist asserts claims she takes to be true about value and about nature, so the shared-falsity premise is mistaken from the very beginning.
- **D:** Incorrect: the missing-truth-conditions thesis is non-cognitivism, and neither religious naturalism nor religious fictionalism is defined by holding it.

Examiner trap 32: The comparative sentence worth writing is that Indian systems offer graded truth where Western fictionalism offers pretence, which is why sincerity is easier to preserve on the Indian model.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified previous-year questions - 7 complete solutions

Word bands used throughout. 10 marks ≈ 150 words · 15 marks ≈ 250 words · 20 marks ≈ 350 words. Every question below is reproduced in its **exact printed wording** from the audited Philosophy of Religion previous-year ledger, 2018-2025, in which this clause owns seven question-parts and is absent as a primary owner only in 2022.

The model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.

Timing skeleton. 10 marks - 1 minute to decode, 1 to outline, 6 to write, 1 to check. 15 marks - 1 / 2 / 10 / 2. 20 marks - 2 / 3 / 13 / 2. **Standing penalties in this clause:** an answer with no stated definition of religion; "atheistic" used where "non-theistic" is meant; Cārvāka offered as an instance rather than as the limit; the Mīmāṃsā Veda called revelation; and any invented year for Smart, Feuerbach, Freud or Comte.

PYQ 1 - 2018, Q5(c), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Can you justify religion without God? Support your answer.

Demand decoding: "Justify" requires a defended position with the criterion stated, not a catalogue of godless schools. Announce the definition of religion first; the whole answer follows from it.

Model solution: Yes - provided religion is defined not substantively, by the kind of object affirmed, but multidimensionally. Ninian Smart's dimensions are doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social and material; belief in a creator is not among them.

Buddhism satisfies every dimension. Dependent origination and karma explain conditioned arising; the Four Noble Truths diagnose; the Eightfold Path disciplines; the *Śaṅgha* sustains; *nirvāṇa* completes. Jainism rejects a creator on the motive and embodiment arguments while retaining vows and the perfected *siddha*. Mīmāṃsā is sharper still: the Veda is authorless (*apauruṣeya*), so no divine speaker is required, and unseen potency (*apūrva*) links act to delayed fruit without a divine dispenser.

The justification must be bounded. A definition broad enough to admit any strong commitment is empty, so the sacred-order and soteriological conditions are added - which is exactly why Cārvāka, having closed the route to every supersensible object, is the limiting case rather than an instance.

Religion without God is therefore justified; religion without a sacred order is not.

Why this earns marks:

- Opens with a defended criterion instead of a list of schools.
- Uses three Indian traditions with their distinct mechanisms, not their names.
- Polices the over-breadth of its own definition inside the answer.
- Classifies Cārvāka correctly as the limit, which is the clause's signature discrimination.
- Closes with a decided verdict in the exact form the directive requested.

PYQ 2 - 2019, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: How would a religious person deny the possibility of a religion without God? Discuss.

Demand decoding: The stem asks you to argue the theist's case first, sympathetically and in its strongest form, and only then assess it. Half the marks are in the construction.

Model solution: A religious theist would deny the possibility on five grounds. **Definitional:** religion is a living relation between finite persons and a personal transcendent, so "religion without God" is a category error rather than an unusual species. **Devotional:** worship requires a recipient; praise, petition and surrender are relational acts, and Jain veneration of a passionless perfected being would then be commemoration rather than worship. **Moral:** unconditional obligation requires a commander whose will binds. **Cosmic-order:** purposive order and the exact allotment of karmic fruit require intelligence, which is why Nyāya posits *Īśvara* as creator and superintendent of karma (*karmādhyaṅśa*). **Soteriological:** forgiveness, grace and covenant require a responsive agent who can bestow them.

The denial nevertheless assumes its conclusion at the first step. Smart's dimensions show that doctrine, ritual, ethics, experience, narrative and community exist without a creator. Buddhism supplies a complete diagnosis of suffering, dependent origination, the path, the *Saṅgha* and *nirvāṇa*. Mīmāṃsā answers the third and fourth arguments directly: the authorless Veda secures authority without a speaker, and unseen potency (*apūrva*) secures desert without a dispenser, the relation being law-like rather than deliberative. Jainism's *siddha* is an achieved, not a governing, divinity.

The theist may reply that *Dharma*, *nirvāṇa* and *apūrva* are hidden substitutes; but functional similarity does not establish ontological identity. The strongest surviving point is therefore devotional, not definitional: petition and grace genuinely require a responsive God, and non-theistic religions do without them at a real cost in devotional structure.

Religion without God is possible; religion without a sacred order is not.

Why this earns marks:

- Obeys the unusual directive by giving the theist's five arguments priority and philosophical force.
- Names Nyāya's superintendent of karma and then answers it with the correct Mīmāṃsā mechanism.
- Distinguishes achieved from governing divinity in the Jain case.
- Refuses the hidden-God inference explicitly rather than ignoring it.
- Concedes the devotional cost, which is what a graded verdict requires.

PYQ 3 - 2020, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Critically examine the concept of God as prerequisite for a religion.

Demand decoding: "Prerequisite" is a necessity claim. Give the substantive definition its strongest defence, produce counterinstances, then state the limited functions for which a personal God really is indispensable.

Model solution: To call God a prerequisite is to claim that nothing counts as religion unless it includes belief in a divine being, usually a personal creator, moral governor and saviour.

The claim has genuine force. A substantive definition captures prayer, worship, revelation, covenant and grace precisely, and it guards against an over-broad functionalism under which nationalism or ideology becomes a religion merely by supplying meaning and community. The theist adds that worship requires one who is worshipped, unconditional obligation a supreme commander, and karmic order an intelligent administrator.

A prerequisite is nevertheless a necessary condition, and established traditions defeat it. Buddhism has doctrine, ethical discipline, meditation, monastic community and liberation without a creator; where gods occur they are impermanent beings within rebirth, neither makers nor indispensable saviours. Jainism rejects creation while affirming eternal souls, karmic matter, vows and the perfected *siddha*. Mīmāṃsā is the sharpest counterexample: dharma is known only from injunction - Jaimini's *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra* 1.1.2 - the Veda is authorless rather than revealed, and unseen potency (*apūrva*) explains the delayed fruit without a dispenser. Classical Sāṃkhya derives evolution from nature in proximity to plural selves and seeks isolation (*kaivalya*); Yoga's *Īśvara* is a special self and must not be read back into Sāṃkhya.

Modern positions extend the case while complicating it: Dewey's "the religious", Dworkin's religious atheism and religious fictionalism all detach religious functions from theistic belief, though critics reasonably ask whether what survives is religion or only spirituality.

God is therefore indispensable for petition, covenant, propositional revelation and grace - but not for religion as such. The concept of God is one powerful way of integrating religious functions, not their universal prerequisite.

Why this earns marks:

- Treats "prerequisite" as a necessity claim rather than describing non-theism generally.
- Defends the substantive definition before dismantling it.
- Uses four Indian counterexamples with doctrine-specific mechanisms, and protects the Sāṃkhya-Yoga distinction.
- Integrates the modern positions without equating them with classical soteriology.
- Ends with a bounded, function-by-function necessity verdict.

PYQ 4 - 2021, Q5(d), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Is religious life possible without the belief in God? Discuss.

Demand decoding: A possibility claim is established by one actual case done in depth, not by four cases mentioned. "Religious life" shifts the emphasis from doctrine to lived practice.

Model solution: It is possible, and the proof is actual rather than hypothetical.

Religious life consists in disciplined orientation to a sacred order, ritual and ethical formation, community and a transformative goal. Buddhism supplies all four without a creator: the Four Noble Truths diagnose the predicament, the Eightfold Path prescribes conduct, meditation and understanding, moral discipline (*śīla*) shapes daily action, the *Śaṅgha* transmits and sustains, and *nirvāṇa* is the goal. Where gods appear they are impermanent beings within rebirth, not saviours.

Mīmāṃsā shows the same for a ritual rather than a meditative life: injunction defines duty, and unseen potency (*apūrva*) connects the act to its fruit without a divine dispenser. Jain vows and asceticism organise a whole life around release.

Two limits should be conceded. Petition and grace do require a responsive God, so the personal texture of non-theistic religious life is different and arguably thinner. And religious life is not possible where every supersensible order has been closed off - which is why Cārvāka has an ethic but no religious life.

Belief in God is therefore sufficient for religious life in many traditions, but not necessary for it.

Why this earns marks:

- Answers the possibility question with one tradition treated in depth.
- Reads "religious life" as practice and answers on that register.
- Adds a second and third case briefly to show the result is not idiosyncratic.
- Concedes the devotional limit instead of overclaiming.
- Uses the Cārvāka boundary to show what "religious life" positively requires.

PYQ 5 - 2023, Q5(e), 10 marks

Exact verified question: What is Agnosticism? How do agnostics conceptualize the relation between religion and God? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Two printed deliverables - a definition and a positional account. Define, sub-divide into weak and strong, then give the relation. Answering only the first half forfeits half the marks.

Model solution: Agnosticism is the claim that the existence of God is unknown or unknowable, so that judgement should be suspended. The word was coined by T. H. Huxley in 1869. It is distinct from atheism, which denies God, and from indifference, which does not raise the question. **Weak agnosticism** holds that the matter is not known and remains open to evidence; **strong agnosticism** holds that it is unknowable in principle, which is itself a substantial epistemological thesis. Kant's practical faith and Spencer's "Unknowable" are adjacent positions.

On the relation between religion and God, agnostics treat the two as separable. Religious commitment can be graded, and need not include metaphysical certainty. An agnostic may therefore affirm religion's ethical dimension, its experiential and contemplative dimension, and its ritual and communal life, while withholding assent on the existence of God - a minimal or non-theistic religiosity. A person may, for instance, participate fully in Buddhist ethical and meditative practice while withholding creator claims.

The objection is that this reduces religion to ethics or aesthetics. The reply is that community, ritual, transformation and orientation to ultimacy exceed ordinary morality - although what remains is admittedly thinner than a fully theistic religious life.

Why this earns marks:

- Answers both printed deliverables, in the printed order, with a visible transition.
- Dates the coinage correctly and distinguishes agnosticism from atheism and indifference.
- Sub-divides into weak and strong and notes the cost of the strong form.
- States the presupposition - graded commitment - instead of assuming it.

- Meets the reduction objection and concedes what it should.

PYQ 6 - 2024, Q7(a), 20 marks

Exact verified question: State and evaluate Buddhism as a religion without God.

Demand decoding: Two halves. State the doctrine fully before assessing it; do not evaluate a caricature. The evaluation must include the devotional complication and a graded verdict.

Model solution: Statement. Buddhism is non-theistic rather than atheistic: a creator is absent from its diagnosis and its path, though impermanent gods and later devotional practice are not denied. Dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*) and karma explain conditioned arising; gods and *Brahmā* figures remain beings inside rebirth rather than creators or final saviours, as the *Brahmajāla* (DN 1) and *Aggañña* (DN 27) Suttas indicate. The Buddha's undeclared questions (*avyākata*) concern specific speculative issues that the path does not require, and must not be presented as the whole case.

What remains is a complete religion on a multidimensional definition. Doctrine: the Four Noble Truths, impermanence and non-self. Practice: the Noble Eightfold Path, meditation and monastic observance. Ethics: moral discipline (*śīla*). Community: the *Saṅgha*, with rule, ordination and transmission. Goal: *nirvāṇa*, liberation from suffering. Sacred order: *Dharma*, the order the path discloses. Teaching, community and liberation organise all of this without functioning as one-for-one substitutes for a personal creator.

Evaluation. The argument is one of redundancy, not refutation: a creator adds no explanatory or practical step to the causal-soteriological sequence. Its presupposition - that dependent causation suffices for the problem Buddhism addresses - is where a theist should press.

Three objections deserve answers. That karma is providence renamed: causal-moral regularity is impersonal, with nothing that selects, forgives or answers. That devotional Mahāyāna makes Buddhism theistic: Buddhas and bodhisattvas may perform religious functions without becoming an omnipotent creator, which shows that non-theistic does not mean devotion-free. That *Dharma* is God renamed: functional similarity does not establish ontological identity.

The cost must be conceded. Petition, covenant and grace require a responsive God, and Buddhism does without them; its devotional structure is therefore differently shaped.

Verdict. Buddhism is a strong actual counterexample to the claim that a personal creator is necessary - provided religion is defined multidimensionally rather than stipulated as God-relation, in which case the counterexample would have been excluded before it was examined.

Why this earns marks:

- Completes the statement before beginning the evaluation, as the directive demands.
- Runs the multidimensional cluster explicitly, element by element.
- Restricts the undeclared questions to their real scope and cites the text anchors.
- Answers the three standing objections rather than the easiest one.
- Concedes the devotional cost and closes with a conditional, graded verdict.

PYQ 7 - 2025, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss Cārvāka's critique of the belief in the existence of suprasensible entities.

Demand decoding: The directive buys the **argument** of the critique, not its conclusions. Give the epistemology - the concomitance problem - not the hedonist slogans.

Model solution: The critique is epistemological. Cārvāka holds that perception (*pratyakṣa*) alone is a means of knowledge, because a means of knowledge must yield certainty and every other candidate depends on a general rule that perception cannot certify.

The argument turns on inference. Inference depends on invariable, unconditional concomitance (*vyāpti*) between mark and inferred. How is that concomitance known? Not by perception, which grasps only particular co-presences while concomitance is universal. Not by inference, which would need its own concomitance, generating regress or circularity. Not by testimony, which is not a means of knowledge at all here. And even repeated observation cannot exclude an unnoticed conditioning factor (*upādhi*) - fire is accompanied by smoke only when the fuel is wet - so deviation remains possible and the concomitance remains merely probable.

Applied to religion: God is never perceived; consciousness is emergent from the body (*dehātmavāda*), illustrated by the intoxicating power arising from combined ingredients; karma and unseen merit are imperceptible postulates; order needs no maker, since things act by their own nature (*svabhāva-vāda*).

Two replies are required. The charge of self-refutation is met by reading the denial dialectically, and by the reported Purandara strand admitting ordinary inference while denying it for what lies beyond the senses. On that moderate reading the critique is unrefuted and fatal to every inference-based natural theology.

Why this earns marks:

- Gives the argument rather than the conclusions, as the directive requires.
- States all four moves of the concomitance problem, including the conditioning-factor residue.
- Applies the epistemology to the specific religious postulates.
- Supplies both replies to self-refutation and flags the reported strand as reported.
- Ends with the verdict formula tying the critique's success to its epistemology.

Original solved Mains practice - 6 models

The following are original, independently prepared practice questions and model answers, not previous-year questions or official solutions.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: "Non-theistic is not identical with atheistic." Examine the significance of this distinction for the possibility of religion without God.

Model solution: The distinction decides the clause. Atheism denies that God exists; non-theism reports that a creator is absent from a tradition's diagnosis and path. The first is a claim about what exists, the second about what a path requires.

Its significance is that non-theism leaves standing everything a religion needs. Theravāda Buddhism permits cosmological gods while denying their creatorhood and salvific ultimacy; later Mahāyāna develops full devotion to Buddhas and bodhisattvas; Jainism venerates the perfected *siddha*. None of that would be available to a tradition committed to denying every deity and every sacred being.

The distinction also redistributes the burden of proof. The non-theist need only show that a complete religious structure exists without a creator, which is a claim about actual traditions. The atheist must additionally defend a universal negative.

The objection is that a creator assigned no role has effectively been denied. The reply is doctrinal: what Buddhism denies is creatorhood and final salvific power, not existence, and the surviving devotional practice is evidence that the narrower denial is the real one.

Loose use of "atheistic" therefore concedes the theist's framing in the first line and makes a strong case sound like a weak one.

Why this earns marks: States the distinction precisely; shows what it preserves; identifies the shift in burden of proof; answers the collapse objection with doctrinal evidence; ends with the examination consequence.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Explain why classical Mīmāṃsā is often regarded as the sharpest counterexample to the claim that religion requires God.

Model solution: Because it removes God from a tradition that keeps everything else religion is usually thought to need: scripture, ritual, duty, merit and a promised fruit.

Three functions a deity normally performs are reassigned. Authority: the Veda is authorless (*apauruṣeya*), so no speaker's reliability needs establishing, and the theistic arguments from the text's status lose their premise. Duty: Jaimini's *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra* 1.1.2 defines dharma as what is characterised by injunction and is beneficial, so dharma is known from injunction alone, not from any deity's command. Desert: unseen potency (*apūrva*) is postulated to connect a perished momentary act with a much later fruit, answering the Nyāya demand for a superintendent of karma.

The deities named in the mantras are elements within the ritual structure - the dative of the offering - rather than agents who hear and grant.

Two qualifications are owed. Nyāya objects that an unconscious potency cannot select the right fruit for the right agent; Mīmāṃsā replies that the relation is law-like rather than deliberative, which the objector must then argue against. And later authors of the school drift toward theism, so the atheistic reading is of the classical system.

Mīmāṃsā thus shows that the functions God performs are separable, which is a stronger result than any single tradition's silence about a creator.

Why this earns marks: Identifies the three reassigned functions; quotes the sūtra for its epistemic consequence; states the postulate's status correctly; answers Nyāya; restricts the claim to the classical system.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "Functional definitions of religion purchase the possibility of religion without God at the price of admitting anything." Critically discuss.

Model solution: The charge is serious and half true, and the correct answer concedes the half before repairing it.

It is true that every functional feature over-generates on its own. Ultimate concern is a strong candidate but nations, art and political causes can become ultimate concerns. Ritual is widespread but secular ceremonies have it. Ethical orientation is common but ethical philosophies are not religions. Community is common but so are clubs. A definition assembled from these alone would indeed admit almost anything with sufficient intensity.

It is false that this is the only functional definition available. The working repair is a **cluster with two load-bearing conditions**: a disciplined and socially embodied relation to an ultimate or sacred order, together with a transformative or soteriological practice. Both must be present. A political movement may have ritual, doctrine, ethics and community and still fail both, because its ultimate is not treated as sacred and it offers no release from a diagnosed predicament.

The repair earns its keep by doing real classificatory work in both directions. It admits Buddhism, whose diagnosis of suffering and path to its cessation satisfy the soteriological condition exactly; Jainism, with bondage by karmic matter and release into the perfected state; Mīmāṃsā, with injunction, merit and a promised fruit; and Sāṃkhya, with entanglement and isolation. And it **excludes Cārvāka**, which denies the whole supersensible order and offers no path - an exclusion that shows the criterion is not merely permissive.

The alternative to functionalism is worse. A substantive definition centred on a personal creator settles a comparative question by stipulation, excluding Buddhism before examining it; and it cannot explain why traditions that lack a creator nonetheless possess doctrine, ritual, ethics, experience, narrative and institution in the pattern Smart identified.

A residual concession remains. Civil religion and secular spirituality sit uncomfortably close to the boundary, and the cluster classifies them only after asking whether a transformative discipline is present. That is a real cost of any functional account, but it is the cost of a working definition rather than of an empty one.

The charge therefore fails against the cluster while succeeding against unrestricted functionalism, which is precisely why the definition must be stated with its restrictions in the opening paragraph.

Why this earns marks: Concedes the true half explicitly; states the two load-bearing conditions; demonstrates classification in both directions; shows the substantive alternative is worse; ends with a residual concession rather than a clean sweep.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Assess the claim that dharma, *nirvāṇa* and *apūrva* are simply God under other names.

Model solution: This is the hidden-God objection, and it is the most persistent challenge to the whole clause. It infers, from the fact that a non-theistic concept performs a function God performs, that the concept is a disguised deity.

The inference is invalid, and the reply must say why rather than merely deny it. Functional similarity does not establish ontological identity. An impersonal law is not an omniscient person. Liberation reached by insight is not grace bestowed by an agent. A potency postulated to connect act and fruit does not select, forgive, respond or love. Each of these differences is not a matter of degree but of kind.

Take the three concepts in turn. *Dharma* in Buddhism is the order the path discloses and conforms to; it issues no commands, hears no petitions and grants no pardons. *Nirvāṇa* is the cessation of the conditions of suffering; it is a goal, not an agent, and it plays no cosmological role - treating it as a first cause reimports precisely the structure Buddhism dispenses with. *Apūrva* is explicitly a postulate introduced to bridge a perished act and a later fruit, and the Mīmāṃsā reply to Nyāya is that the connection is law-like rather than deliberative.

The objector has a comeback worth stating. If these concepts are doing the work God did, the tradition has acknowledged that the work must be done, so the theist's diagnosis of what religion requires was correct even if his ontology was not. That is a fair point and should be conceded: religion does require a sacred order, an account of moral consequence and a goal. What it does not require is that these be unified in a single responsive person.

Two disciplinary consequences follow for an answer. First, avoid writing that *Dharma* "takes the place of" God; describe instead what work it does and what work it does not do. Second, notice that the objection is strongest exactly where the theistic goods are relational - petition and grace - and weakest where they are structural.

The claim therefore fails as stated, while identifying correctly the functions any religion must discharge somehow.

Why this earns marks: Names the objection and its inference; refutes the inference with three kind-differences; treats the three concepts separately; concedes the objector's strongest comeback; converts the analysis into two writing rules.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "Religion can survive the loss of God, but not the loss of a sacred order." Critically examine with reference to both Indian and modern Western positions.

Model solution: The statement is defensible, and examining it requires a criterion, two bodies of evidence and a boundary case.

The criterion. Religion is a socially embodied and disciplined orientation to an ultimate or sacred order, expressed through some combination of doctrine, ritual, ethical formation, experience and community, and directed at a transformative or soteriological goal. Two conditions are load-bearing: the sacred order and the transformative practice. Creator-belief is one historically powerful way of organising the orientation, not a condition of it - and a definition that made it a condition would settle a comparative question by stipulation.

The Indian evidence: survival without God. Buddhism diagnoses suffering, explains its arising through dependent origination and karma, prescribes the Eightfold Path, sustains a community and completes in *nirvāṇa*. Jainism argues against a creator from motive and embodiment while retaining eternal souls, karmic matter, vows and the perfected *siddha* - an achieved rather than a governing divinity. Mīmāṃsā keeps scripture, ritual, duty and merit while making the Veda authorless and postulating unseen potency (*apūrva*) to connect act and fruit; Jaimini's *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra* 1.1.2 makes dharma knowable from injunction alone. Classical Sāṃkhya derives the world-process from nature in proximity to plural selves and seeks isolation; Yoga's special self is not a creator and must not be read back into Sāṃkhya.

In every case what survives the removal of God is precisely a sacred order plus a path.

The modern Western evidence: the thinner case. Religious naturalism relocates ultimacy inside nature. Dewey's *A Common Faith* (1934) distinguishes "religion" from "the religious" and redefines God as the active relation between the ideal and the actual; Dworkin's *Religion without God* (2013) defends religious atheism on objective life-meaning

and cosmic sublimity; Goodenough's *The Sacred Depths of Nature* (1998) develops reverence for natural depth. Religious fictionalism goes further, declining to assert the claims at all: Cupitt's non-realism (1980) and Le Poidevin's fictionalism (1996) retain narrative, liturgy and formation without metaphysical assent.

These are genuinely religious on the criterion where a community and a transformative practice accompany the philosophy; where they do not, "religious" survives chiefly as an adjective for a quality of experience. Fictionalism additionally faces the sincerity objection, since prayer seems directed to a believed hearer. Advaita's two levels supply the instructive contrast: worship of the qualified absolute is efficacious at the everyday level and is **sublated**, not falsified, at the ultimate level - graded truth rather than pretence.

The boundary case. Cārvāka closes the epistemic route to every supersensible object: perception alone is a means of knowledge, concomitance cannot be established, consciousness is emergent, and order follows from own-nature. It therefore has no soteriology, no sacred, no community of practice and no ultimate concern. What results is not a godless religion but no religion at all - which is the strongest single confirmation of the statement under examination.

The qualification. "Survive" understates a real cost. Petition, covenant and grace require a responsive God, and traditions without them have a differently shaped devotional life. And the sacred-order condition needs policing at the modern boundary, since civil religion and secular spirituality display ritual and ultimate concern without a transformative discipline.

The statement therefore holds: God is separable from religion, a sacred order is not.

Why this earns marks: States a criterion before assembling evidence; runs Indian and Western bodies of evidence separately and comparably; uses Cārvāka as the confirming boundary; names the defeater - the devotional cost - that qualifies the verdict; ends by deciding rather than summarising.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Compare the classical Indian non-theistic traditions with modern religious naturalism and fictionalism as answers to the question whether religion requires God.

Model solution: Both answer "no", but they arrive from opposite directions, and the comparison is decided by what each has to build and what each already possessed.

What is removed, and what replaces it. Buddhism removes creator and permanent self, replacing them with dependent origination, *Dharma*, *Śaṅgha* and *nirvāṇa*. Jainism removes only the creator, replacing it with karmic matter, vows and the perfected *siddha*. Mīmāṃsā removes both the author of the Veda and the dispenser of fruit, replacing them with authorless authority (*apauruṣeya*) and unseen potency (*apūrva*). Sāṃkhya removes the creator, replacing it with nature's evolution in proximity to plural selves and release as isolation. Religious naturalism removes supernatural ontology, replacing it with nature as the locus of ultimacy. Fictionalism removes assertion itself, replacing it with participation in a non-assertoric spirit.

The structural difference. The Indian systems are **positive** systems: they possess doctrines of causation, moral consequence, community and a final goal that were never derived from theism and therefore lose nothing when theism is withdrawn. Buddhism does not retain Christian forms after withdrawing belief; it has its own diagnosis, its own causal account and its own soteriology. The modern positions are **reconstructive**: they must build or re-motivate ultimacy after inherited metaphysics has weakened. That is why they are thinner, and the thinness is structural rather than accidental.

The sincerity test. Fictionalism's characteristic liability is sincerity: worship seems directed to a believed hearer, and make-believe worship risks being either dishonest or hollow. The fictionalist replies that transparent imaginative immersion is a familiar and non-deceptive human capacity, and that ritual can express commitment rather than report ontology; whether motivation survives over time is an unresolved empirical and existential issue. The comparative point that earns marks is that **Indian systems offer graded truth where Western fictionalism offers pretence**. Advaita treats worship of the qualified absolute as efficacious at the everyday level and sublated, not falsified, at the ultimate level; Buddhism's two truths permit serious conventional practice while denying ultimate substantial reference. Sublation is not falsification, and that difference preserves the practitioner's sincerity.

Where the modern positions are stronger. They address a question the classical traditions never faced: whether someone committed to a naturalistic ontology can be religious at all. Dewey's separation of "religion" from "the religious", Dworkin's religious atheism grounded in objective life-meaning and cosmic sublimity, and Goodenough's

reverence for natural depth are answers to that specific modern predicament, and the Indian systems have nothing to say to it directly.

The shared result, and the shared limit. Both families show that the *functions* of religion - reverence, community, ritual, orientation to ultimacy, self-transformation - are detachable from theistic belief. Both leave untouched the specifically relational goods: petition, covenant and grace still require a responsive God. And whether what survives counts as religion depends on the definition adopted at the start, which is why this clause always returns to the substantive-versus-functional question.

The classical traditions therefore give the stronger evidence that religion without God is actual; the modern positions give the sharper test of whether it remains possible under a naturalistic ontology.

Why this earns marks: Uses a removal-and-replacement bench for six routes; identifies the positive/reconstructive asymmetry as the structural difference; runs the sincerity test with the Indian graded-truth control; concedes where the modern positions are stronger; closes on the shared result and the shared limit.

Timed-paper compression plan

This clause owns seven parts across 2018-2025 and is absent as a primary owner only in 2022, so the compression problem is predictable and the plan below is question-shaped rather than generic.

If the stem is	Cut first	Never cut
a justification stem (2018)	the modern Western material; the second and third Indian cases down to a clause each	the stated definition; one Indian case with its mechanism; the boundary that excludes Cārvāka
an opponent-construction stem (2019)	your own preferred definition down to one sentence	the theist's five arguments; the Mīmāṃsā answer to allotment; the devotional concession
a necessity stem (2020)	Sāṃkhya; the naturalism/fictionalism paragraph	the substantive definition's best defence; one counterexample defended against reinterpretation
a possibility stem (2021)	comparative breadth; the Western comparison entirely	one tradition in depth as a <i>lived</i> practice; the concession about petition and grace
a definition-plus-position stem (2023)	adjacent positions (Kant, Spencer)	the weak/strong subdivision; the second printed deliverable; the reduction objection
a state-and-evaluate stem (2024)	the Jain and Mīmāṃsā parallels	the complete statement before evaluation; the devotional-Mahāyāna answer; the graded verdict
an argument-of-the-critique stem (2025)	the four-element ontology; the hedonist material entirely	the four moves of the concomitance problem; the conditioning-factor residue; both replies to self-refutation

The 60-second recovery drill. If time is collapsing, write four sentences in this order and stop: (1) the definition of religion you are using; (2) one tradition, with the mechanism that replaces the divine function; (3) the strongest theistic objection, named; (4) the graded verdict, with the cost you concede. Four correct sentences of this shape outscore two pages of school-listing.

What not to over-study. Do not let "spiritual but not religious" discourse, civil religion or the biography of the Western critics crowd out Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā and the Indian anti-creator arguments. Master the definition test, one concrete tradition in depth, the theist's best objection and the exact verdict.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Status. Everything below is **second-order enrichment**. No core answer in this clause depends on it, and none of it repairs a gap in the Basic block. Add **one** advanced move to a 15-marker, or **one to two** to a 20-marker, and only after the owner's own material is on the page. **Why this block is short.** The previous edition of this package placed the whole of the owner's doctrine dossiers here as an unedited source dump. Two of those modules - Cārvāka and Mīmāṃsā - supply the answer to printed previous-year questions (2025 Q5(a) and the 2020 Q6(c) route), and the Advanced dossier's own **promotion ledger of 15 August 2026** records that religious naturalism and non-realism/fictionalism "now live in Core and must not be described as Advanced-only". All of that material is therefore taught in the Basic block above, where it belongs. What remains here is genuinely second-order.

A1 - Impersonal law against intelligent causation

The dispute. Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā and Sāṃkhya explain order, moral consequence and liberation without a creator; Nyāya presses the need for intelligent causation and for a moral allotment of karmic fruit.

Strongest extra objection -> counter-reply. *Objection:* impersonal law cannot explain **purposive** order - regularity is one thing, the appearance of ends is another, and only an agent produces ends. *Reply:* the non-theistic schools deny that observed regularity must be modelled on artefact production; the milk-and-calf illustration is used precisely to display non-conscious purposiveness, and the Mīmāṃsā answer adds that a law-like relation delivers determinate outcomes without deliberation.

Safe use. Deploy when an answer risks becoming only Buddhism plus a definition. It restores balance by showing that the non-theistic case had a serious classical opponent and answered it - but the Core versions of both the objection and the reply are already in Sessions 9 and 10, so this adds evaluative pressure rather than new content.

A2 - Nietzschean post-theism against nihilism

The dispute. Nietzsche diagnoses the collapse of the God-framework and demands revaluation; critics fear that value-creation without an external standard becomes arbitrary or elitist.

Strongest extra objection -> counter-reply. *Objection:* once God is gone, values lose objective force, and "life-enhancement" is itself a value that requires the warrant it cannot supply. *Reply:* Nietzsche seeks active self-overcoming rather than passive nihilism and accepts the self-reference rather than escaping it; whether that is a defence or a concession remains disputed.

Safe use. ANALYSIS: Useful only in Nietzsche-style stems, not in every religion-without-God answer. Its value in *this* clause is comparative: it marks the difference between a horizon **lost** and a horizon **never had**, which is why Buddhist and Jain non-theism cannot be assimilated to post-theism.

A3 - Whether a fictionalist can sincerely inhabit a practice she declines to assert

The dispute. This is the residue the Advanced dossier leaves after promoting religious naturalism and fictionalism to Core. Fictionalists participate in liturgy, narrative and moral formation while withholding assertion; critics say the participation is either self-deceptive or hollow.

Strongest extra objection -> counter-reply. *Objection:* prayer is not merely an expressive act but an **address**; an address to a hearer one does not believe in is not an unusual mode of sincerity but a failure of it. *Reply:* the fictionalist appeals to transparent imaginative immersion, familiar from literature and ritual drama, and to the claim that ritual expresses commitment rather than reporting ontology - an empirical claim about sustained motivation that remains contested.

Safe use. One sentence in a naturalism/fictionalism paragraph, always followed by the Indian control: Advaita's sublation is not falsification, and Buddhism's two truths permit serious conventional practice, so graded truth preserves sincerity where pretence does not.

A4 - The four-way comparison that has not yet been promoted

The dispute. The dossier's own promotion trigger records that a **systematic four-way comparison of Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā and Sāṃkhya as non-theistic religions** would be promoted to Core if a printed question asked it directly. No such question has appeared, so the comparison remains enrichment rather than a required section.

Strongest extra objection -> counter-reply. *Objection:* running all four in a single answer produces breadth without depth, and the printed stems reward one tradition treated fully. *Reply:* the comparison is worth one paragraph at 20 marks, where it shows that the counterexample is structural rather than a peculiarity of Buddhism - but it must never displace the depth treatment.

Safe use. A single comparative sentence, or at most a four-row bench, at the end of a 20-mark answer. The Core bench in Session 18 already supplies the material; what is optional is spending an additional paragraph on it.

What not to over-study

Do not let contemporary "spiritual but not religious" discourse, civil religion, or the biographies of the Western critics crowd out Buddhism, Jainism and the Indian anti-creator arguments. The clause is decided by a definition and by concrete traditions.

Advanced source trail

FACT: Ninian Smart on the dimensions of religion · FACT: Buddhist texts on dependent origination and *nirvāṇa* · FACT: Jain discussions of non-creator liberation · FACT: Mīmāṃsā on authorless scripture (*apauruṣeya*) and unseen potency (*apūrva*) · FACT: Friedrich Nietzsche, *The Gay Science* and *On the Genealogy of Morality* · FACT: Ronald Dworkin, *Religion without God*.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Eighteen compressed retrieval cards, one per taught session, in teaching order. These are revision notes, not a second exposition: definitions, discriminations, named evidence, traps and answer routes only.

1. The necessity question, and the definition that decides it

- **The question owned:** whether a personal creator is *necessary* for religion - not whether God exists.
- **Four definitions:** substantive (by object) · functional (by what it does) · multidimensional (Smart's cluster) · family resemblance (no shared essence).
- **Two failures:** too narrow => excludes Buddhism by stipulation, question-begging · too broad => admits nationalism, empty category.
- **Smart's seven dimensions:** doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social, material. Creator-belief is **not** on the list.
- **Opening habit:** name the definition in sentence one and never drift from it.

2. The criteria table, and the working cluster

- **Seven candidates graded:** creator God (**not necessary**) · sacred/ultimate concern (broad) · ritual (not universal in one form) · ethics (common) · community (common) · **diagnosis-and-liberation (strong discriminator)** · myth/doctrine/experience (family features).
- **The working sufficient cluster:** a socially embodied, disciplined orientation to an ultimate/sacred order, through doctrine, ritual, ethical formation, experience and community, with a transformative or soteriological goal.
- **Two load-bearing conditions:** sacred order **and** soteriological practice. Both, not either.
- **What it must do:** admit Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā, Sāṃkhya; exclude nationalism; exclude Cārvāka.
- **Trap:** presenting the cluster as necessary conditions instead of a sufficient combination.

3. Which functions require a deity

- **Require a person:** petitionary prayer (a responsive addressee is built in) · propositional revelation from God (a speaker by definition) · grace and providence (in their personal-agency sense).
- **Do not:** worship/veneration · ritual efficacy (*apūrva*; Buddhist and Jain discipline) · moral motivation (compassion, non-injury, karma, vows, insight) · liberation (*nirvāṇa*, Jain release, *kaivalya*).
- **The separability result:** authority, efficacy and desert are separable and can each be secured otherwise - Mīmāṃsā proves it inside one system.
- **Answer move:** concede petition, grace and covenant; the concession buys credit for every denial that follows.
- **Trap:** treating "prayer" and "worship" as one function.

4. The four negative positions

- **Non-theism:** about the **path** - a creator is absent from diagnosis and prescription.
- **Atheism:** about **existence** - the positive denial that God exists.
- **Agnosticism:** about **knowledge** - weak ("not known") and strong ("unknowable").
- **Indifference:** the question does not arise. Adjacent: anti-theism; practical atheism.
- **The firewall:** non-theistic ≠ atheistic. Theravāda Buddhism permits cosmological gods while denying creatorhood and salvific ultimacy.
- **Trap:** "Buddhism is atheistic" in line one concedes the theist's framing.

5. Buddhism - the diagnosis without a creator

- **Engine:** dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*) + karma explain conditioned arising and cessation.
- **The claim is redundancy, not refutation:** a creator adds no explanatory and no practical step.
- **Presupposition to state:** dependent causation is explanatorily sufficient *for the problem Buddhism addresses*.
- **Scope control:** the undeclared questions (*avyākata*) concern specific speculative issues; they are not the whole case. Poisoned-arrow parable = urgency, not proof of atheism.
- **Text anchors:** *Brahmajāla Sutta* DN 1 · *Aggañña Sutta* DN 27. Gods and *Brahmā* figures are impermanent beings inside rebirth.
- **Objection/reply:** karma is providence renamed => causal-moral regularity is impersonal; nothing selects, forgives or answers.

6. Buddhism - the complete religion, and devotion

- **Cluster discharged:** doctrine (Four Noble Truths) · practice (Eightfold Path, meditation) · ethics (*śīla*) · experience · community (*Saṅgha*) · goal (*nirvāṇa*) · sacred order (*Dharma*).
- **The compulsory qualification:** *Dharma*, *Saṅgha* and *nirvāṇa* organise doctrine, practice and value **without functioning as one-for-one substitutes** for a creator.
- **Devotional Mahāyāna:** Buddhas and bodhisattvas may perform religious functions without becoming an omnipotent creator => non-theistic does not mean devotion-free.
- **2024 stem shape:** complete the *statement* before the *evaluation*; do not evaluate a caricature.
- **Verdict:** a strong actual counterexample - *provided* religion is defined multidimensionally.

7. Jainism - creator-denial and achieved divinity

- **Two arguments:** the **motive** argument (a perfect being has no unfulfilled desire creation could satisfy) and the **embodiment** argument (acting on matter requires a body, which is itself limited).
- **Same argument-family:** Kumārila's *Ślokavārttika* against a bodiless agent acting on matter.
- **Replacement machinery:** eternal souls (*jīva*) and non-soul (*ajīva*) · karmic matter binding and shed · vows and asceticism · liberation as the soul's own achievement.
- **The decisive line:** the ford-maker (*tirthaṅkara*) teaches and the perfected being (*siddha*) has completed - an **achieved** divinity, never a **governing** one.

- **Theist's best shot here:** worship of a passionless being is "commemoration" => answer with vows, ritual, asceticism, soteriology.

8. Mīmāṃsā - authorless scripture and injunction

- **Three jobs an author would do, all retired:** reliability => **authorless** (*apauruṣeya*) · validation => **intrinsic validity** (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) · meaning => the **eternal word-referent relation** (Nyāya denies this; note the dispute).
- **The definition:** Jaimini, *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra* 1.1.2 - *codanā-lakṣaṇo 'rtho dharmah*: dharma is what is characterised by injunction and is beneficial => known **only** from injunction.
- **Effect on theistic proofs:** Udayana's arguments from the Veda's status lose their premise rather than their conclusion.
- **Mantra-deities:** elements within the ritual structure - the dative of the offering - not agents who hear, choose and grant.
- **Trap:** calling the Veda "revelation" reinstates the speaker the school removed.

9. Mīmāṃsā - unseen potency and the two schools

- **Five steps:** injunction promises a result -> result is delayed -> act is momentary and perishes -> a perished cause cannot produce a later effect -> therefore an unseen potency (*apūrva*, "the not-before") persists.
- **Status:** a **postulate** (*arthāpatti*), licensed by the school's own epistemology - never a perceived entity.
- **The split:** Kumārila - a **power** (*śakti*) in act or agent => consequential mechanism of **desert**. Prabhākara - **the ought-to-be-done** (*niyoga/kārya*) => a **deontology of the injunction**.
- **Three objections/replies:** allocation (Nyāya's *karmādhyakṣa*) => law-like, not deliberative, and the objection begs the question · meaning => eternal word-referent relation · "bureaucracy not religion" => sacred order, soteriological promise, discipline, community.
- **CAUTION: Honest limit:** later Mīmāṃsā authors drift toward theism; the atheistic reading is of the **classical** system.

10. Sāṃkhya and Yoga - a cosmos without a maker

- **Two principles:** nature (*prakṛti*), one, unconscious, active, with three strands (*guṇa*) · selves (*puruṣa*), plural, conscious, inactive.
- **Process:** proximity -> evolution of intellect, ego-sense, mind, senses, elements -> misidentification -> discriminative knowledge (*viveka-khyāti*) -> **isolation** (*kaivalya*).
- **Yoga's special self (Īśvara)** is **not straightforwardly a creator** in the classical Sāṃkhya sense - never read it back into Sāṃkhya.
- **Illustration:** milk seeming to nourish the calf - non-conscious purposiveness.
- **Nyāya pressure and reply:** unconscious principles cannot organise ends => observed regularity need not be modelled on artefact production.

11. Cārvāka - perception alone, and concomitance

- **Ontology:** the four gross elements (*bhūtacatuṣṭaya*: earth, water, fire, air); **ether rejected as imperceptible**; human ends reduce to pleasure (*kāma*) and wealth (*artha*).
- **Why only perception:** a means of knowledge must yield certainty -> perception is immediately certain -> every other candidate depends on a rule perception cannot certify.
- **The four closed routes to concomitance (vyāpti):** not by perception (it is universal) · not by inference (regress/circularity) · not by testimony (not a means of knowledge here) · and the **conditioning factor** (*upādhi*) can never be excluded - fire with smoke only when the fuel is wet => deviation (*vyabhicāra*) stays possible.
- **Conclusion, already domain-restricted:** inference works by luck or habit in daily life and is worthless where no perceptual check exists.
- **Parity objection:** perception errs too - illusion, dream, defective organs.

12. Cārvāka - application, replies, and the limit

- **Application:** God unperceived · consciousness emergent (*dehātmavāda*), the intoxicating-power (*madaśakti*) analogy => no survival, transmigration or liberation · karma and unseen merit (*adr̥ṣṭa*) are props for ritual · Vedic authority denied · order by own-nature (*svabhāva-vāda*).
- **CAUTION: Attribution:** the Bṛhaspati verses and the hedonist couplet survive only in opponents' doxographies, chiefly Mādhava's *Sarvadarśanasamgraha*. Report as doxographic; never as primary text.
- **Five replies:** self-refutation · pragmatic · Nyāya's defence (repeated uncontradicted co-observation, non-observation of a counter-instance, hypothetical reasoning) · parity · **the reported Purandara strand** admitting ordinary (*laukika*) inference and denying it for the beyond-the-senses (*atīndriya*).
- **Two rejoinders to self-refutation:** the dialectical (*prasaṅga*) reading; the moderate Purandara thesis.
- **Verdict formula:** the critique succeeds exactly as far as its epistemology does - strong thesis self-refuting and unliveable; **moderate thesis unrefuted and fatal to every inference-based natural theology, including Udayana's.**
- **Classification:** WRONG: **not** a religion without God - the limiting case that shows non-theistic religions retain an accepted supersensible order.

13. Western critiques of theistic religion

- **Feuerbach**, *The Essence of Christianity* - "theology is anthropology"; God is the **projection** of humanity's idealised essence.
- **Marx**, Introduction to *A Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right (1843-44)* - religion is "the **opium of the people**", consolation masking exploitation, dissolving with a just society.
- **Freud** - religion as **illusion**, wish-fulfilment, cosmic father-projection.
- **Comte** - the **religion of humanity**: devotion to human values without a deity; the bridge to secular humanism.
- **Shared structure:** identify a human need -> derive the belief -> dispense with the object.
- **Shared limit:** these are **genetic** explanations. Origin does not settle truth. What they do establish: belief is not self-authenticating.

14. Nietzsche and post-theistic value

- **The claim:** "God is dead" diagnoses the collapse of the **Christian-metaphysical horizon** and the danger of **nihilism** - a cultural diagnosis, not a proof of non-existence.
- **Four steps:** truthfulness and science erode belief -> inherited values depended on the framework -> collapse creates nihilism -> overcoming requires **revaluation** and self-creation.
- **Presupposition:** values have genealogies tied to forms of life and can be assessed as life-enhancing or life-denying.
- **Canonical example:** *ressentiment* reverses aristocratic value terms and converts weakness into moral superiority.
- **Objection/reply:** revaluation risks elitism and arbitrary power => creative self-overcoming, though a universal standard remains difficult.
- **Ownership gate:** the printed 2025 stem coupling religion **with morality** is owned by **Religion and Morality**. This clause keeps Nietzsche as critique of theistic religion + bridge to post-theism.
- **Comparative point:** a horizon **lost** is not a horizon **never had** - Buddhism and Jainism never possessed it.

15. Agnosticism

- **Definition:** God's existence is **unknown or unknowable** => suspend judgement. Distinct from atheism (denial) and indifference (no question).
- **Coinage:** T. H. Huxley, 1869.
- **Subdivision:** weak = "not known" (open to evidence) · strong = "unknowable" (a substantial epistemological thesis needing its own defence).
- **Adjacent:** Kant's practical faith; Spencer's "Unknowable".

- **The relation:** religion and God are **separable**; ethical, experiential, ritual and communal dimensions remain available while assent is withheld => minimal or non-theistic religiosity.
- **Presupposition:** religious commitment can be **graded** and need not include metaphysical certainty.
- **Objection/reply:** reduces religion to ethics/aesthetics => community, ritual, transformation and orientation to ultimacy exceed ordinary morality.
- **Trap:** answering only the first of the two printed deliverables.

16. Religious naturalism

- **Thesis:** ultimacy, reverence and the religious response are located **within nature**; no supernatural person, but genuine attitudes of awe, gratitude, humility and commitment.
- **Dewey, *A Common Faith* (1934):** "religion" (institution with supernatural claims) vs "**the religious**" (a quality of experience unifying the self toward inclusive ideal ends); "God" = the **active relation between the ideal and the actual**, not a being.
- **Dworkin, *Religion without God* (2013):** "**religious atheism**" - objective intrinsic meaning of human life + the sublimity and intrinsic beauty of the universe; **value realism**, not theism, is the core.
- **Also:** Julian Huxley (evolutionary humanism) · Goodenough, *The Sacred Depths of Nature* (1998) · Crosby and Rue on nature as ground of ultimacy · Spinoza (*Deus sive Natura*) as ancestor.
- **Objection/reply:** ethics and aesthetics in religious vocabulary => ultimacy, reverence, community and transformation are present, and demanding a supernatural person restates theism.
- **Bounded caution:** civil religion and secular spirituality are **boundary tests, not owners**; without a transformative discipline the category becomes too broad.

17. Religious fictionalism and non-realism

- **Thesis:** religious sentences are (or may be) literally false or unwarranted, yet participation in a **non-assertoric**, fictive spirit is rationally permissible and valuable.
- **Named:** Cupitt, *Taking Leave of God* (1980) - non-realism, God as personification of the religious ideal, "Sea of Faith" · Le Poidevin, *Arguing for Atheism* (1996) - explicit fictionalism · Eshleman on participation · Wettstein on significance without metaphysical commitment.
- **Three-way discrimination: error theory** = false, so stop · **non-cognitivism** = never had truth-conditions · **fictionalism** = grants truth-conditions, declines to assert, continues in the practice.
- **Three objections:** insincerity/self-deception · motivational hollowing · the internal objection (believers reject the description).
- **Indian control - do not omit:** Advaita's everyday level (*vyāvahārika*) is efficacious and is **sublated**, not falsified, at the ultimate level (*pāramārthika*); Buddhism's two truths (*saṃvṛti/paramārtha*) permit serious conventional practice. **Sublation is not falsification.**
- **The comparative sentence:** Indian systems offer **graded truth** where Western fictionalism offers **pretence**.

18. The theist's denial, the bench and the verdict

- **Five theistic arguments:** definitional (category error) · devotional (worship needs a recipient) · moral (obligation needs a commander) · cosmic order (Nyāya's *Īśvara* as superintendent of karma) · soteriological (grace needs a giver).
- **Five rebuttals:** Smart's dimensions and the stipulation charge · the *siddha* as achieved not governing · non-theistic moral motivation · Mīmāṃsā's authorless Veda + *apūrva*, law-like not deliberative · Buddhism's complete diagnosis-and-path.
- **The assessment that scores:** the strongest surviving theistic point is **worship/grace**, not the definition; petition and grace genuinely require a responsive God, at a real cost in devotional structure.
- **Six-route bench:** Buddhism (yes) · Jainism (yes) · Mīmāṃsā (strong under ritual/functional definitions) · Sāṃkhya-Yoga (yes) · modern naturalism/fictionalism (only on a functional definition) · **Cārvāka (no - the limit).**
- **Four standing criticisms:** definition · hidden-God · motivation · nihilism - with the replies in Session 18.

- **Architectures:** 10 = define -> four-step doctrine -> nearest confusion -> one objection -> verdict. 15 = frame -> one Indian case in depth -> example -> objection and reply -> comparison. 20 = criteria -> full Buddhist/Jain/Mīmāṃsā case -> creator critique -> devotional complication -> Western comparison -> graded conclusion.
- **Closing formula:** *religion without God is possible; religion without a sacred order is not.*

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/26: The clause, the one question, and the definition that decides it

SYLLABUS CLAUSE (verbatim): "Religion without God."

CENTRAL QUESTION: is belief in a PERSONAL CREATOR necessary for something to be a religion?

NOT the existence question. Nothing here turns on whether God exists.

SUBSTANTIVE	FUNCTIONAL	MULTIDIMENSIONAL	FAMILY RESEMBLANCE
by its OBJECT	by what it	by a CLUSTER	no single feature is
God / gods /	DOES: ultimacy,	(Ninian Smart's	shared by every member
sacred beings	practice,	seven dimensions)	-> "religion" names a
	community,		family of practices,
	meaning,		not one essence
	liberation		

TOO NARROW

excludes Buddhism BY
STIPULATION

= QUESTION-BEGGING

TOO BROAD

admits nationalism,
art, political cause

= EMPTY CATEGORY

THE WORKABLE MIDDLE

creator-belief is NOT on the
essential list

SMART'S SEVEN DIMENSIONS: doctrinal | mythic | ethical | ritual | experiential | social | material

THE ONE RULE: every printed stem in this clause is decided by the definition you adopt in the first three lines. State it, defend it in one line, then apply it CONSISTENTLY.

THE FIREWALL: NON-THEISTIC is not identical with ATHEISTIC. Rejecting a creator does not entail denying every deity, sacred being, devotional act or transcendent value.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/26: Why the clause exists, and the only datable anchors

ORIGIN RAIL (conceptual, not calendar)

1 a definition of religion is proposed that centres on a personal creator

-> 2 established traditions are produced with doctrine, ritual, ethics, community and liberation, yet no creator

-> 3 the definition is defended by NARROWING it => the question-begging charge

-> 4 the definition is defended by WIDENING it => nationalism and ideology walk in

-> 5 a middle criterion is demanded: sacred order + disciplined soteriological practice
==> the clause exists because Stages 3 and 4 are BOTH unacceptable.

DATED PRINT ANCHORS (assert these; invent no others)

1843-44 Marx, Introduction to A Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right

1869 T. H. Huxley coins the word "agnostic"

1934 John Dewey, A Common Faith

1980 Don Cupitt, Taking Leave of God

1996 Robin Le Poidevin, Arguing for Atheism

1998 Ursula Goodenough, The Sacred Depths of Nature

2013 Ronald Dworkin, Religion without God <== the book that names this clause

CITE BY WORK, NEVER BY YEAR: Nietzsche (The Gay Science 125; On the Genealogy of Morality);

Feuerbach (The Essence of Christianity); Freud (religion as illusion); Comte (Religion of

Humanity); Spinoza (Deus sive Natura); Ninian Smart (dimensions); Jaimini (Mīmāṃsā-sūtra 1.1.2);

Kumarila (Slokavarttika); Madhava (Sarvādarsanasamgraha - REPORTED Carvaka only);

Brahmajāla Sutta DN 1; Agganna Sutta DN 27; Julian Huxley; Crosby; Rue; Eshleman; Wettstein.

ANACHRONISM CONTROL: the Indian systems are NOT responses to the death of God; they never had the theistic horizon Nietzsche mourns. Keep POST-THEISM and NON-THEISM in separate paragraphs.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/26: The seven candidate criteria, graded

CANDIDATE FEATURE	NECESSARY?	WHY NOT SUFFICIENT ALONE
personal creator God	NO - Buddhism, Jainism, classical Mimamsa are counterexamples	defines THEISM, not religion as such
sacred / ultimate concern	strong but VERY BROAD	nations, art, political causes qualify
ritual + disciplined practice	widespread, not universal in one form	secular ceremonies also have ritual
ethical orientation	common	ethical philosophies are not religions
community and tradition	common	clubs and nations organise community too
DIAGNOSIS AND LIBERATION	STRONG DISCRIMINATOR	some traditions stress worship or belonging
myth, doctrine, experience	family features	each may be thin or absent in a strand
THE WORKING SUFFICIENT CLUSTER (write this, not a list of necessary conditions)		
a SOCIALLY EMBODIED and DISCIPLINED orientation to an ULTIMATE / SACRED ORDER, expressed through some combination of doctrine, ritual, ethical formation, experience and community, and directed at a TRANSFORMATIVE or SOTERIOLOGICAL goal.		
TWO LOAD-BEARING CONDITIONS: sacred order AND transformative practice. Both, never either.		
ADMITS: Buddhism Jainism Mimamsa Samkhya-Yoga		
EXCLUDES: any strong commitment as such (nationalism, ideology) AND Carvaka.		

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/26: Which religious functions actually require a deity

FUNCTION	PERSONAL DEITY REQUIRED?	NON-THEISTIC FORM
petitionary prayer	YES, normally - a responsive addressee is built into petition (NOT petition in the same sense)	meditation, aspiration, recitation
worship / veneration	no	reverence for Dharma, liberated exemplars, scripture, sacred value
propositional revelation from God	YES, by definition	Mimamsa: AUTHORLESS scriptural authority, not creator-revelation
grace and providence	YES, in their personal-agency sense	self-effort, karmic law, disciplined path, communal support
ritual efficacy	no	apurva; Buddhist / Jain discipline
moral motivation	no	compassion, non-injury, karma, vows, insight, human flourishing
liberation / salvation	no, as a GENERIC function	nirvana, Jain release, kaivalya
THE SEPARABILITY RESULT: God is necessary for SOME SPECIFICALLY THEISTIC GOODS, not for every religious function. Mimamsa proves inside ONE system that AUTHORITY, EFFICACY and DESERT are each separable and can each be secured otherwise.		
ANSWER MOVE: concede petition, grace and covenant. The concession buys credit for every denial that follows, and identifies where the theist's real case lies - devotional, not definitional.		

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/26: The four negative positions, and what each leaves standing

NON-THEISM about the PATH	ATHEISM about what EXISTS	AGNOSTICISM about what can be KNOWN	INDIFFERENCE about what is ASKED
creator is absent from diagnosis and path	"God does not exist"	WEAK: "not known" STRONG: "un- knowable"	the question does not arise
LEAVES STANDING: lesser gods, devotion, sacred value, soteriology	leaves the sacred order ONLY if it is non-divine (Carvaka does NOT)	leaves ethical, experiential, ritual and communal religion available	leaves nothing in particular

RELATED BUT DISTINCT: anti-theism (God-belief is harmful as well as false); practical atheism (a life organised without reference to God).

BURDENS DIFFER: the non-theist must show a path can be COMPLETE; the atheist must defend a UNIVERSAL NEGATIVE; the agnostic must show suspension coexists with practice.

THE RULE: religion survives NON-THEISM; it does not survive the removal of every sacred order.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/26: Buddhism I - the diagnosis that needs no creator

THE FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS AS A DIAGNOSIS

- 1 THERE IS SUFFERING (dukkha) <- the datum
- 2 IT HAS AN ORIGIN: craving + ignorance <- the cause
- 3 THE ORIGIN CAN CEASE <- the possibility
- 4 THERE IS A PATH TO ITS CESSATION <- the prescription

|
v

DEPENDENT ORIGINATION (pratityasamutpada): "this being, that becomes" - conditions arise, conditions cease. Karma supplies moral-causal continuity.

|

+-----+-----+

v

WHERE WOULD A CREATOR GO?

[VACANT SLOT] - no step
of the diagnosis, the cause,
the cessation or the path
requires one.

v

WHAT ABOUT THE GODS?

devas and Brahma figures may occur in the cosmology, but they are
IMPERMANENT beings INSIDE samsara: neither creators nor final
saviours. Text anchors: Brahmajala Sutta DN 1; Agganna Sutta DN 27.

THE CLAIM IS REDUNDANCY, NOT REFUTATION. A creator adds no explanatory and no practical step.

PRESUPPOSITION, STATED HONESTLY: dependent causation is explanatorily sufficient FOR THE PROBLEM

BUDDHISM ADDRESSES - not for everything whatever. That is where a theist should press.

SCOPE CONTROL: the undeclared questions (avyakata) concern SPECIFIC speculative issues; they are
NOT the whole Buddhist case. The poisoned-arrow parable = urgency, never proof of atheism.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/26: Buddhism II - the cluster discharged, element by element

CLUSTER ELEMENT	WHAT BUDDHISM SUPPLIES	NEEDS A CREATOR?
doctrine	Four Noble Truths; dependent origination; impermanence and non-self	no
ritual / practice	meditation; recitation; monastic observance; later devotional (puja) forms	no
ethical formation	moral discipline (sila): right speech, action, livelihood	no
experience	staged meditative attainment; insight	no
community	the SANGHA - rule, ordination, transmission	no
soteriological goal	NIRVANA - liberation from suffering	no
sacred order	DHARMA - the order the path discloses	no

THE COMPULSORY QUALIFICATION: Dharma, Sangha and nirvana organise doctrine, practice and value
WITHOUT functioning as ONE-FOR-ONE SUBSTITUTES for a personal creator.

=> saying "Dharma takes the place of God" is exactly the sentence the hidden-God objection needs.

2024 STEM SHAPE (state and evaluate, 20 marks): complete the STATEMENT before the EVALUATION.

Half the marks are in the exposition; evaluating a caricature forfeits the other half.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/26: Buddhism III - the devotional complication, handled correctly

LATER MAHAYANA devotion to Buddhas and bodhisattvas is real, widespread and religiously serious.

TWO TEMPTATIONS, BOTH WRONG

- X "so Buddhism became theistic" - function mistaken for ontology
- X "so it must be a later corruption" - an evidential claim you cannot support

THE CORRECT LINE

V Buddhas and bodhisattvas may perform religious FUNCTIONS - refuge, gratitude, aspiration,
even grace-like assistance - WITHOUT thereby becoming an omnipotent creator.

V NON-THEISTIC DOES NOT MEAN DEVOTION-FREE. One sentence disarms the objection.

THREE OBJECTIONS AND THEIR REPLIES

- | | |
|----------------------------------|---|
| 01 karma is providence renamed | R1 causal-moral regularity is IMPERSONAL: nothing selects,
forgives, rewards out of love, or answers |
| 02 devotional Mahayana is theism | R2 performing a function is not occupying the creator role |
| 03 Dharma is God renamed | R3 functional similarity does not establish ONTOLOGICAL
IDENTITY |

THE COST TO CONCEDE: petition, covenant and grace require a responsive God, and Buddhism does
without them. Its devotional structure is DIFFERENTLY SHAPED, not absent.

VERDICT: a strong ACTUAL counterexample - PROVIDED religion is defined multidimensionally rather
than stipulated as God-relation, in which case it would be excluded before being examined.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/26: Jainism - motive, embodiment, and an achieved divinity

THE JAIN CASE AGAINST A CREATOR - two arguments, both with premises

1. THE MOTIVE ARGUMENT

a perfect being lacks any unfulfilled desire; creation would answer a need;
a perfect being has no need
∴ no motive to create

2. THE EMBODIMENT ARGUMENT

action on matter requires a body or instrument
a body is itself made and limited
∴ an embodied creator is not the UNLIMITED creator that was claimed

SAME ARGUMENT FAMILY: Kumarila's Slokavarttika against a BODILESS AGENT acting upon matter.

WHAT REPLACES THE CREATOR

eternal souls (jiva) + non-soul (ajiva)

KARMIC MATTER that binds and is shed

VOWS and asceticism

liberation as the soul's OWN achievement

WHAT IS VENERATED

TIRTHANKARA - the ford-maker who TEACHES the path

SIDDHA - the perfected soul, passionless (vitaraga):

grants nothing, hears nothing, governs nothing

THE DECISIVE LINE: an ACHIEVED divinity, never a GOVERNING one.

THEIST'S BEST SHOT HERE: "worship of a passionless being is really commemoration, so Jainism is a philosophy with ceremonies." REPLY: commemoration of a human exemplar does not carry vows, a ritual calendar, temple practice, ascetic discipline and a soteriological goal. A category that excludes this is tracking THEISM, not religion.

TRAP: never call the siddha a creator God under another name - that concedes the hidden-God objection in the one place where the Jain case is strongest.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/26: Mimamsa I - the three jobs an author would have done

IF SCRIPTURE HAD AN AUTHOR YOU WOULD NEED

- (a) a speaker whose reliability can be established
- (b) an external validator of the text's authority
- (c) a convention fixing what the words mean

MIMAMSA'S REMOVAL

APAURUSEYA: the Veda is AUTHORLESS, so there is no reliability question to answer at all

SVATAH-PRAMANYA: injunctions are INTRINSICALLY valid; validity is not conferred from outside

the WORD-REFERENT relation is ETERNAL

(sabdārtha-sambandha nityatva) - Nyaya DENIES this as merely conventional: note the dispute

JAIMINI, MIMAMSA-SUTRA 1.1.2: "codana-laksano 'rtho dharmah"

dharmā = that which is CHARACTERISED BY (Vedic) INJUNCTION and is beneficial

==> dharmā is known ONLY from injunction - not from perception, not from inference, and not from any deity's command. Quote the sutra FOR THIS CONSEQUENCE or not at all.

AND THE DEITIES IN THE MANTRAS? they are ELEMENTS WITHIN THE RITUAL STRUCTURE - the dative to which the oblation is offered - NOT agents who hear, choose and grant.

EFFECT ON THEISTIC PROOFS: Udayana's arguments from the Veda's status (vakyat / pratyayatah / sruteh) lose their PREMISE rather than their conclusion.

TRAP: one careless sentence calling the Veda "revelation" reinstates the divine speaker the school has just removed, and surrenders the whole counterexample.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/26: Mimamsa II - the five-step argument for apurva

1 a Vedic injunction PROMISES a result (heaven from the jyotistoma)

2 the result does NOT follow immediately upon the act

3 the act is momentary and PERISHES

4 a PERISHED CAUSE cannot produce a LATER EFFECT

5 ∴ the act must generate an UNSEEN POTENCY that persists until the result matures
= APURVA, "the not-before" - something new that did not previously exist

EPISTEMIC STATUS: a POSTULATE (arthapatti), NEVER a perceived entity. Mimamsa's own epistemology licenses postulation to explain an otherwise inexplicable fact - so this is a SANCTIONED move, neither an observation nor an arbitrary invention.

WHY THIS REMOVES GOD, PART TWO: no DISPENSER of karmic fruit is needed, since apurva does that work - so the Nyaya argument that a superintendent of karma (karmadhyaksa) is required is ANSWERED DIRECTLY rather than ignored.

STATE ALL FIVE STEPS OR NONE: a bare assertion that ritual generates apurva, without the perished-cause problem, reads as vocabulary rather than as argument.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/26: Mimamsa III - Kumarila against Prabhakara, and three objections

KUMARILA BHATTA	PRABHAKARA MISRA
apurva = a POWER (sakti) residing in	recentres on NIYOGA / KARYA - the sheer
the act or the agent, linking act	"OUGHT-TO-BE-DONE" disclosed by the injunction,
to fruit	which motivates without needing a promised fruit
=> a CONSEQUENTIAL MECHANISM OF DESERT	=> a DEONTOLOGY OF THE INJUNCTION

THE DIFFERENCE MATTERS: naming the two without the desert-versus-duty payoff is name-dropping.

THREE OBJECTIONS, THREE REPLIES

O1 (Nyaya) an unconscious potency cannot SELECT the appropriate fruit for the appropriate agent at the appropriate time; only an intelligent superintendent can.

R1 the relation is LAW-LIKE, not deliberative; the objection assumes that only agents produce determinate outcomes, which BEGS THE QUESTION against natural law.

O2 how can a beginningless, authorless text have determinate meaning?

R2 meaning is carried by the ETERNAL relation of word and referent (Nyaya denies it: dispute).

O3 is this religion, or bureaucracy?

R3 it has a sacred order, a soteriological promise, a disciplined practice and a community - exactly what a functional definition requires.

HONEST LIMIT (?): later Mimamsa authors drift toward theism. The atheistic reading defended here is of the CLASSICAL system - say so, and the answer is protected from an easy correction.

VERDICT FORMULA: "Mimamsa keeps scripture, ritual, duty, merit and a soteriological goal, and relocates AUTHORITY and EFFICACY in apauruseya Veda and apurva. What it thereby shows is that the religious functions God performs are SEPARABLE."

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 13/26: Samkhya and Yoga - a cosmos without a maker

PURUSA (plural, conscious, inactive)	PRAKRTI (one, unconscious, active)
mere PRESENCE / proximity	three strands (guna) in disturbed
+-----+-----+	equilibrium

v

EVOLUTION of intellect, ego-sense, mind, senses,
subtle and gross elements

|

ENTANGLEMENT: the self MISTAKES itself for what evolves <- the predicament

|

DISCRIMINATIVE KNOWLEDGE (viveka-khyati)

v

KAIVALYA - ISOLATION of the self from nature
(release, NOT the annihilation of nature)

WHERE IS THE CREATOR? nowhere; nothing in the sequence requires one.

YOGA'S ISVARA: a SPECIAL SELF, untouched by affliction and action - NOT straightforwardly a creator in the classical Samkhya sense. DO NOT read Yoga's Isvara back into Samkhya; that single editorial accident converts a non-theistic system into a theistic one.

PRESUPPOSITION: impersonal law or dual principles can explain order AND liberation.

NYAYA PRESSURE: an unconscious principle cannot organise ENDS.

REPLY: observed regularity need not be modelled on ARTEFACT PRODUCTION. Standard illustration - milk seeming to nourish the calf: non-conscious purposiveness with nothing deliberating. This reply is the GENERAL form of the anti-design answer in this clause; it also serves Buddhism and Mimamsa.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 14/26: Carvaka I - perception alone, and the four-element ontology

WHY ONLY PERCEPTION (pratyaksa)?

- 1 a means of knowledge (pramana) must yield CERTAINTY about its object
- 2 perception is self-evident and immediately certain
- 3 every other candidate - inference, comparison, testimony, postulation - is either reducible to perception or DEPENDS ON A GENERAL RULE that perception cannot certify
- 4 ∴ perception alone is a pramana, and knowledge does not extend beyond the perceptible

THE ONTOLOGY THAT FOLLOWS

reality = the FOUR GROSS ELEMENTS (bhutacatustaya): earth, water, fire, air
ETHER IS REJECTED because it is IMPERCEPTIBLE - not an omission but a consequence
the human ends (purusarthas) reduce to KAMA and ARTHA, because the other two require a supersensible order to be intelligible

THE CERTAINTY CONDITION IS THE HINGE - and it is where the school is most vulnerable:

PARITY OBJECTION: perception itself faces illusion, dream and defective organs, and is corrected only by further cognition. So either the certainty condition is weakened - and inference re-enters - or perception fails its own test.

NOTE THE SHAPE OF THE CONCLUSION: it is ALREADY DOMAIN-RESTRICTED in its own statement - inference "works by luck or habit" in daily life and is worthless where no perceptual check exists. That restriction is what makes the moderate reading available in Panel 17.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 15/26: Carvaka II - the attack on inference, in full

INFERENCE (anumana) depends on VYAPTI - an INVARIABLE, UNCONDITIONAL concomitance between the mark (hetu, e.g. smoke) and the inferred (sadhya, e.g. fire).

CARVAKA'S QUESTION: by what means is VYAPTI ITSELF known?

- | |
|--|
| (1) NOT BY PERCEPTION - perception grasps only PARTICULAR co-presences, here and now. Vyapti is a UNIVERSAL covering all cases, including unobserved past, future and remote ones, and no perception reaches those. |
| (2) NOT BY INFERENCE - establishing this vyapti by another inference requires that inference's own vyapti: INFINITE REGRESS or CIRCULARITY. |
| (3) NOT BY TESTIMONY - testimony's authority would itself have to be established, and for the Carvaka it is not a pramana at all. |
| (4) THE UPADHI PROBLEM - even repeated observation cannot rule out an unnoticed CONDITIONING FACTOR (upadhi) that makes the concomitance hold only contingently. Standard example: fire is accompanied by smoke ONLY WHEN THE FUEL IS WET. Unless every possible upadhi is excluded - and that exclusion is itself unverifiable - the concomitance remains merely PROBABLE: deviation (vyabhicara) stays possible. |

CONCLUSION: inference cannot deliver CERTAINTY. Where it works in daily life it works by luck or habit; and precisely in the supersensible domain - God, soul, karma, afterlife - no perceptual check is EVER available, so there inference is worthless.

TRAP: "Carvaka rejects inference" states a CONCLUSION and omits the ARGUMENT the 2025 directive asked for. Give all four moves, including the upadhi residue.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 16/26: Carvaka III - the application to religion

- (a) GOD never perceived => the inference from world-as-effect to an intelligent maker is DOUBLY worthless: unperceived object, uncertifiable concomitance
- (b) THE SOUL not a separate substance: consciousness is an EMERGENT property of the body (dehatmavada). Standard analogy: the INTOXICATING POWER (madasakti) arising when fermenting ingredients (kinva etc.) are combined, though present in none singly. => no survival, no transmigration, NO LIBERATION - the whole soteriology goes
- (c) KARMA and unseen merit (adrsta) - imperceptible postulates invented to prop up ritual
- (d) THE VEDA authority denied. The verses transmitted in Madhava's Sarvadarsanasamgraha and attributed there to BRHASPATI mock the fire-sacrifice, the three Vedas and ascetic practice as the livelihood of the witless.
(?) ATTRIBUTION DISCIPLINE: these survive ONLY as quotations in OPPONENTS' works. Treat them as REPORTED Carvaka positions, never as verified primary text; and never present the hedonist couplet ("yavaj jivet sukham jivet...") as more than a doxographic quotation, or build an answer on it.
- (e) ORDER SVABHAVA-VADA: things behave according to their OWN NATURE. The sharpness of a thorn and the colour of a peacock require no maker.

NOTE THE PARALLEL: (e) is the Carvaka counterpart of the Samkhya anti-design reply in Panel 13 - but stronger, because it declines the supersensible altogether rather than relocating it.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 17/26: Carvaka IV - the five replies, and the moderate strand

- 1 SELF-REFUTATION "no inference is valid" is itself a UNIVERSAL claim about all inferences, which cannot be perceived and must therefore be INFERRED. The thesis defeats itself.
==> REJOINDER A: advance the denial DIALECTICALLY, as a PRASANGA (reductio) internal to the opponent's own commitments, asserting no positive universal of one's own.
- 2 PRAGMATIC no one, including the Carvaka, can eat, speak, teach or argue without relying on inference; performative consistency demands its acceptance.
- 3 NYAYA'S POSITIVE DEFENCE OF VYAPTI
 - (i) repeated uncontradicted co-observation (bhuyodarsana)
 - (ii) NON-OBSERVATION OF ANY COUNTER-INSTANCE (vyabhicara-adarsana)
 - (iii) TARKA - hypothetical reasoning showing that denying the concomitance leads to absurdity plus the technical device samanya-laksana-pratyasatti, explaining how a universal is cognitively available at all
- 4 PARITY perception itself errs - illusion, dream, defective organs - and is corrected only by further cognition; certainty is not perception's exclusive property either
- 5 (?) THE MODERATE STRAND - and the one that separates a top script
a strand associated with the fragmentary PURANDARA is REPORTED as accepting inference for ORDINARY empirical matters (laukika) while rejecting it as a route to the SUPERSENSIBLE (alaukika / atindriya).
==> REJOINDER B: on this reading the school is NOT committed to self-refuting global scepticism. Its thesis becomes the far more defensible one that inference cannot be extended beyond the domain in which its concomitances can be PERCEPTUALLY CHECKED - a classical Indian anticipation of the empiricist critique of metaphysics.
(?) the evidence is fragmentary and reported by opponents: flag it as a REPORTED strand.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 18/26: Carvaka V - the classification verdict and its payoff

IS CARVAKA A "RELIGION WITHOUT GOD"? ==> NO. And saying so precisely is the mark-earning move.
no soteriology | no sacred | no community of practice | no ultimate concern

ITS PLACE IN THE CLAUSE: the LIMITING CASE at the other end.
Buddhism, Jainism and Mimamsa show that religion can survive the LOSS OF GOD.
Carvaka shows what happens when the EPISTEMIC ROUTE TO ANY SUPERSENSIBLE OBJECT is closed:
you get not a godless religion but NO RELIGION AT ALL.

THE PAYOFF: the contrast establishes that what non-theistic religions retain is NOT merely a substitute deity but an ACCEPTED SUPERSENSIBLE ORDER - dharma, karma, nirvana, apurva - which Carvaka alone rejects.

VERDICT FORMULA (write it): "Carvaka's critique succeeds exactly as far as its epistemology does.
If the STRONG thesis is held - perception alone - it is self-refuting and pragmatically unliveable. If the MODERATE thesis is held - inference is admissible only where its concomitance can in principle be perceptually checked - the critique is powerful, unrefuted, and fatal to every anumana-based natural theology, including Udayana's."

WHY THE MISCLASSIFICATION IS SO COSTLY: candidates reach for Carvaka as the obvious "godless Indian school", and thereby show they think ABSENCE OF GOD is the criterion. Placing it correctly is the fastest available demonstration that you know what the criterion actually is.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 19/26: Western critiques of theistic religion - four critics, one limit

CRITIC	THE CLAIM	NAMED SOURCE
FEUERBACH	"theology is anthropology"; God is the PROJECTION of humanity's idealised essence	The Essence of Christianity
MARX	religion is "the OPIUM OF THE PEOPLE" - a consoling illusion masking economic exploitation; dissolves with a just society	Introduction to A Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right, 1843-44
FREUD	religion is an ILLUSION: wish-fulfilment and cosmic father-projection	Freud on religion as illusion
COMTE	replace the OBJECT: a positive RELIGION OF HUMANITY - devotion to human values without a deity	Comte's Religion of Humanity

THE SHARED STRUCTURE: identify a human need, fear or condition -> show the belief would be produced by it anyway -> conclude the belief is fully EXPLAINED without the object.

WHAT THIS ESTABLISHES: the belief is NOT SELF-AUTHENTICATING. "People believe, therefore there is something to believe in" is blocked.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT ESTABLISH: that the object does not exist. A TRUE belief can also have a psychological or economic cause. ==> THE GENETIC-FALLACY LINE: ORIGIN DOES NOT SETTLE TRUTH.

WHERE THEY LEAD IN THIS CLAUSE: toward SECULAR HUMANISM and Comte's religion of humanity - which is why the clause routes them onward to the Humanism / Secularism owner rather than developing them for their own sake.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 20/26: Nietzsche - diagnosis, genealogy, and the ownership gate

THE ARGUMENT IN FOUR STEPS

- 1 modern truthfulness and science ERODE traditional belief
- 2 inherited values DEPENDED on that framework
- 3 their collapse creates NIHILISM
- 4 overcoming it requires REVALUATION OF ALL VALUES and self-creation (the Ubermensch)

PRESUPPOSITION: values have GENEALOGIES tied to forms of life, and can be assessed as life-enhancing or life-denying.

CANONICAL EXAMPLE: RESENTMENT reverses aristocratic value terms and converts weakness into moral superiority.

THE DISTINCTION THAT MUST BE MADE: "God is dead" is a CULTURAL DIAGNOSIS, not a syllogism proving that God does not exist, and not an empirical report about an event.

OBJECTION -> REPLY: revaluation risks elitism and arbitrary power ==> the Nietzschean reply appeals to creative self-overcoming, though a universal normative standard remains difficult. The self-reference is acknowledged rather than escaped.

===== THE OWNERSHIP GATE =====

The printed 2025 stem - "Present an account of Nietzsche's criticism of religion and morality" - couples religion WITH morality and is owned by the RELIGION AND MORALITY clause. The full genealogical dossier (slave revolt, ascetic ideal, Beyond Good and Evil, the criticisms and the Indian comparison) lives there.

THIS clause retains Nietzsche as (a) a critique of THEISTIC religion and (b) the BRIDGE to post-theistic value.

THE COMPARATIVE POINT THAT EARNS THE MARK: a horizon LOST is not a horizon NEVER HAD. Buddhism and Jainism never possessed what Nietzsche is mourning, so post-theism and non-theism must be argued in SEPARATE paragraphs.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 21/26: Agnosticism - the definition, the two strengths, the relation

PART ONE - WHAT AGNOSTICISM IS

the existence of God is UNKNOWN or UNKNOWABLE ==> suspend judgement.

DISTINCT FROM ATHEISM, which DENIES; and from INDIFFERENCE, which does not raise the question.

WEAK AGNOSTICISM

"not known"

contingent: evidence may underdetermine the question => open to future evidence

principled: the question exceeds the reach of human knowledge => closed in principle, and therefore itself a substantial epistemological thesis needing its own defence

COINAGE: "agnostic" was coined by T. H. HUXLEY in 1869.

ADJACENT POSITIONS: Kant's practical faith; Spencer's "Unknowable".

PART TWO - HOW AGNOSTICS RELATE RELIGION AND GOD (the SECOND printed deliverable)

the two are SEPARABLE. An agnostic may affirm religion's ETHICAL dimension (conduct, compassion), its EXPERIENTIAL dimension (contemplation, awe), and its COMMUNAL and RITUAL dimensions, while WITHHOLDING assent on the EXISTENCE of God ==> a NON-THEISTIC or MINIMAL religiosity.

PRESUPPOSITION, stated honestly: religious commitment can be GRADED and need not include metaphysical certainty.

CANONICAL CASE: a person may participate in Buddhist ethical and meditative practice while withholding creator claims.

OBJECTION -> REPLY: this reduces religion to ethics or aesthetics ==> community, ritual, transformation and orientation to ultimacy EXCEED ordinary morality.

TRAP: answering only Part One forfeits half the marks on the 2023 stem.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 22/26: Religious naturalism - the modern question, and its bench

WHY THE MODULE EXISTS: Buddhism, Jainism and Mimamsa show religion without God in CLASSICAL forms.

The modern debate asks a sharper question: can someone who accepts a NATURALISTIC ONTOLOGY nonetheless be religious?

THESIS: ultimacy, reverence and the religious response are located WITHIN NATURE; there is no supernatural person, but nature sustains genuine attitudes of awe, gratitude, humility, commitment.

THINKER	NAMED WORK	THESIS IN ONE LINE
JOHN DEWEY	A Common Faith, 1934	distinguishes "religion" (an institution with supernatural claims) from "THE RELIGIOUS" (a quality of experience that unifies the self toward inclusive ideal ends); proposes using "God" for the ACTIVE RELATION BETWEEN THE IDEAL AND THE ACTUAL
RONALD DWORKIN	Religion without God, 2013	"RELIGIOUS ATHEISM": reject a personal God while holding that human life has OBJECTIVE INTRINSIC meaning and the universe is SUBLIME; VALUE REALISM, not theism, is core
URSULA GOODENOUGH	The Sacred Depths of Nature, 1998	the religious response to natural depth
JULIAN HUXLEY	evolutionary humanism	religious attitude within evolutionary naturalism
CROSBY and RUE	nature as the ground of ultimacy	immanent locus of ultimacy
SPINOZA	Deus sive Natura	the historical ancestor of the family

OBJECTION -> REPLY: this is ethics and aesthetics wearing religious vocabulary; nothing is worshipped, nothing saves ==> ultimacy, reverence, communal practice and self-transformation are all present, and demanding a supernatural PERSON simply RESTATES the theistic definition.

HONEST CONCESSION: strongest where real practices and communities accompany the philosophy; otherwise "religious" survives chiefly as an ADJECTIVE for a quality of experience.

BOUNDED CAUTION: civil religion and secular spirituality are BOUNDARY TESTS, not owners, and never substitutes for the Indian cases: without a transformative discipline the category is too broad.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 23/26: Fictionalism, its rivals, and the Indian graded-truth control

THREE MODERN POSITIONS - the dividing line is ASSERTION

ERROR THEORY	NON-COGNITIVISM	FICTIONALISM
the claims are FALSE	the claims NEVER HAD truth-conditions	the claims DO have truth-conditions, and are simply NOT ASSERTED
==> STOP	==> never asserted	==> ACCEPTED WITHIN the practice

NAMED POSITIONS

Don Cupitt, Taking Leave of God (1980) - NON-REALISM; God as the personification of the religious ideal; "Sea of Faith" theology

Robin Le Poidevin, Arguing for Atheism (1996) - explicit religious FICTIONALISM

Andrew Eshleman on the fictionalist's participation

Howard Wettstein on the significance of religious experience without metaphysical commitment

THREE OBJECTIONS -> THREE REPLIES

- (i) INSINCERITY / SELF-DECEPTION: worship presupposes belief; make-believe worship is dishonest or hollow. R: immersion in a fiction is a familiar, NON-DECEPTIVE human capacity - literature, ritual drama.
- (ii) MOTIVATIONAL: the practice's power derives from believing it true. R: fictionalists appeal to the sustained efficacy of narrative and ritual - an EMPIRICAL claim that remains CONTESTED.
- (iii) INTERNAL: believers themselves reject the description, so the account is REVISIONARY of the very thing it purports to save.

===== THE INDIAN COMPARISON - DO NOT OMIT =====

ADVAITA already contains a TWO-LEVEL apparatus doing structurally similar work WITHOUT fictionalism: worship of the qualified absolute (saguna) is GENUINELY EFFICACIOUS at the everyday level (vyavaharika) and is SUBLATED, not exposed as fiction, at the ultimate level (paramarthika). ==> SUBLATION IS NOT FALSIFICATION.

BUDDHISM's TWO TRUTHS (samvrti / paramartha) permit full participation in conventional religious practice while denying ultimate substantial reference.

THE COMPARATIVE POINT THAT EARNS MARKS: Indian systems offer GRADED TRUTH where Western fictionalism offers PRETENCE - the Indian device preserves the practitioner's SINCERITY.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 24/26: The theist's denial, the rebuttal ledger, and the six-route bench

THE THEIST'S DENIAL		THE REBUTTAL	
1	DEFINITIONAL: religion IS relation to a personal transcendent => "religion without God" is a CATEGORY ERROR	Smart's dimensions; definition by STIPULATION is question-begging	
2	DEVOTIONAL: worship requires a recipient; Jain vitaraga worship is "really commemoration"	Jain siddha = an ACHIEVED, not a GOVERNING, divinity; vows, ritual, asceticism, soteriology	
3	MORAL: obligation requires a COMMANDER (divine command)	compassion, non-injury, karma, vows, insight, human flourishing	
4	COSMIC ORDER: purposive order and karmic allotment require intelligence (Nyaya's Isvara as karmadhyaksa)	MIMAMSA: apauruseya Veda + apurva secure authority, efficacy AND desert; LAW-LIKE is not DELIBERATIVE	
5	SOTERIOLOGICAL: grace and salvation require an AGENT who can give	Buddhism's complete diagnosis-and-path structure	
THE ASSESSMENT THAT EARNS THE MARK: the theist's strongest SURVIVING point is (2) WORSHIP/GRACE, not (1) the definition. Petition and grace genuinely require a responsive God, and non-theistic religions do without them AT A REAL COST IN DEVOTIONAL STRUCTURE.			
ROUTE	REMOVED	REPLACED BY	RELIGION? PYQ
Buddhism	creator + permanent self	dependent origination, Dharma, Sangha, nirvana	YES 2024 Q7(a)
Jainism	creator only	karmic matter, vows, siddha	YES 2018
Mimamsa	author of Veda AND dispenser of fruit	apauruseya authority + apurva	STRONG 2020
Samkhya/Yoga	creator (Yoga keeps a non-creating Isvara)	prakrti's evolution; viveka-khyati; kaivalya	YES 2021
Naturalism / fictionalism	supernatural ontology, or assertion itself	nature as locus of ultimacy; practice without assertion	ONLY ON FUNCTION 2018
Carvaka	the WHOLE supersensible order	nothing - svabhava, this-worldly ends	NO 2025 (LIMIT) Q5(a)
CONCLUSION: religion without God is possible; religion without a SACRED ORDER is not.			

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 25/26: PYQ routes and the graded verdict ladder

YEAR	PART	MARKS	EXACT DEMAND	ROUTE
2018	Q5(c)	10	Can you justify religion without God? Support...	definition + Buddhism/Jainism + boundary
2019	Q6(c)	15	How would a religious person deny the possibility...	theist's 5 arguments FIRST, then rebut
2020	Q6(c)	15	Critically examine the concept of God as prerequisite for a religion.	necessity test + counterexamples
2021	Q5(d)	10	Is religious life possible without the belief in God? Discuss.	one tradition as LIVED practice, in depth
2023	Q5(e)	10	What is Agnosticism? How do agnostics conceptualize the relation between religion and God? Discuss.	define + weak/strong + the relation
2024	Q7(a)	20	State and evaluate Buddhism as a religion without God.	statement complete, THEN evaluation
2025	Q5(a)	10	Discuss Carvaka's critique of the belief in the existence of suprasensible entities.	the EPISTEMOLOGY - vyapti, not slogans
(2022 is the only year in 2018-2025 with no primary-owned part in this clause.)				
GRADED VERDICT LADDER				
WEAK	~40%	"Buddhism has no God but is a religion"		no definition; "atheistic" loose
AVG	~50%	functional definition; Buddhism + Jainism		theist's case not constructed; Mimamsa missing
GOOD	~60%	definition defended; one case in depth		over-broad functionalism unpoliced; devotional Mahayana ignored
STRONG	~65-70%	substantive/functional dispute explicit; two Indian cases; worship/grace met		naturalism/fictionalism absent; Carvaka misclassified
TOP	~70%+	all the above + a DISCRIMINATING distinction (non-theistic != atheistic; apauruseya != revelation; sublation != fictionalism; Carvaka as limiting case) + the concession that petition and grace genuinely require a responsive God		

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 26/26: Answer architectures and quotation discipline

ANSWER ARCHITECTURES

- 10 define -> doctrine in four steps -> distinguish the nearest confusion -> one objection -> verdict on whether God is necessary
- 15 substantive vs functional frame -> one Indian case in depth -> canonical example -> theistic objection and reply -> comparison with another school
- 20 define criteria -> full Buddhist/Jain/Mimamsa case -> creator critique -> devotional complication -> Western post-theistic comparison -> graded conclusion

QUOTATION DISCIPLINE: "God is dead" = The Gay Science 125 (also 108, 343), cultural diagnosis | "opium of the people" = Marx 1843-44, quote the fuller sentence | "theology is anthropology" = Feuerbach | "agnostic" coined by Huxley 1869 | Brahmajala DN 1, Agganna DN 27 | Mimamsa-sutra 1.1.2 verified | Slokavarttika against a creator | A Common Faith 1934 | Religion without God 2013 | Taking Leave of God 1980 | Arguing for Atheism 1996 | The Sacred Depths of Nature 1998 | (?) Brhaspati verses, the hedonist couplet and Purandara: DOXOGRAPHIC / REPORTED ONLY.